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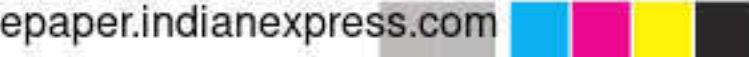
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Russian missile strike kills 10 after Zelenskyy hosts US defence firm

Associated Press
Kyiv, July 24

A RUSSIAN attack Friday a site near Kyiv that was hosting a defense industry event killed at least 10 people and wounded nearly 100 , Ukrainian government and industry officials said. The ballistic missile strike came a day after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy met in Kyiv with senior representatives of Raytheon, the U.S. company that makes the Patriot air defense systems that Ukraine desperately needs to counter the devastating ballistic missiles Russia uses to advance its invasion. Raytheon didn't immediately respond to an email inquiring whether any of its workers were at the event. "Missiles for Patriot systems are the number one priority," Zelenskyy said on social media, where he reported the attack. The attack hit the grounds of a privately operated military training site that was hosting an



The site of Russian missile strikes in Kyiv on Friday, REUTERS

China imposes export controls on 14 EU entities over Russia sanctions

Associated Press
Beijing, July 24

CHINA ANNOUNCED Friday it was adding 14 European entities to an export control list in retaliation for the European Union penalizing 14 Chinese enterprises as part of its latest round of sanctions against Russia. Chinese companies will not be allowed to export dual-use items, which can be used for both civilian and military purposes, to the 14 European organizations, China's Commerce Ministry said in a statement. Additionally, foreign companies are barred from providing to the 14 entities dual-use items made in China. The European companies affected include Czech vehicle manufacturer Tatra Trucks, Italian electric motor maker Lafert SpA, German manufacturer Sindlhauser Materials GmbH and French drone manufacturer Cavok UAS. A Chinese Commerce Ministry spokesperson said the measures were taken in retaliation for the EU on Thursday adding 14 mainland Chinese and Hong Kong enterprises to its latest list of sanctions against Russia over its war in Ukraine. The measures are intended "to safeguard national security and interests, and to fulfill international obligations such as non-proliferation, in response to the EU's egregious actions," the spokesperson said.

UNESCO adds West Bank site, Lebanese castles to Heritage List

Associated Press
Seoul, July 24

UNITED NATIONS committee voted Friday to inscribe a major archaeological site in the West Bank and a set of castles in southern Lebanon as World Heritage sites, despite objections from Israel, which had urged the committee to reject the bids. The decision at a UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization meeting in South Korea came days after Israel's Foreign Ministry urged committee to reject efforts to designate the small West Bank town of Sebastia and the Lebanese castles, calling nominations a "weaponization of cultural heritage." At their meeting in Busan, members of the UNESCO com-

mittee decided to place Sebastia and five castles in Lebanon's Mount Amel area on both the World Heritage List and the List of World Heritage in Danger after reviewing the nominations on an emergency basis, citing ongoing conflicts in West Asia. Sebastia, a hilltop town about 10 kilometers (6 miles) northwest of Nablus in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, is identified by scholars as ancient Samaria, capital of the biblical Kingdom of Israel. The five castles in Mount Amel are recognized for their layered architectural heritage, combining Crusader, Ayyubid, Mamluk and local influences, reflecting the evolution of fortified architecture over nine centuries, as per UNESCO description.

U.S. MISSILES HIT QESHM ISLAND AND SITES IN GILAN ON IRAN'S CASPIAN COAST

Drones target US bases in Iraq as tensions escalates

Tehran says it also attacked US bases in Kuwait, Bahrain & Jordan

Associated Press
Irbil, July 24

DRONES CARRYING explosives targeted a city in northern Iraq where US forces are stationed, and sirens rang out in Bahrain on Friday, hours after the American military said it finished its 13th night of strikes against Iran. The conflict has flared again over the past week, as the US pounded Iran while Tehran attacked ships in the Strait of Hormuz and targeted US assets and allies in the region. The strait, which is a crucial passage for the world's energy supplies, is at the centre of the latest fighting since Iranian attacks can effectively shut the waterway, sending fuel prices soaring worldwide and causing widespread economic turmoil. The Iranian-allied Houthis added further pressure this week by targeting two Saudi tankers in the Red Sea, making good on a threat to cut off an alternative route for the region's oil. Despite the war's unpopularity - and its widespread damage to Iran and the global economy - the latest round of fighting has no clear off-ramp. The Iranian Health Ministry



Iran Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf with Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi in Tehran, on Thursday, REUTERS

says 3,434 people have been killed since the war began. The US and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28 and have offered shifting goals for the war, including toppling Tehran's government and eliminating its nuclear programme. But the conflict has devolved into a fight for control of the strait - with Iran apparently hoping to win concessions by inflicting damage on the global economy. US-led forces shot down five explosive-laden drones Friday over Irbil, according to security officials in northern Iraq. No injuries or damage were reported. Flights continued as normal at the airport, the state-run Iraqi News Agency reported, citing the facility's director. US military officials in Iraq did not respond to a request for comment. A small contingent of US

Trump warns China, Russia not to join war

Washington: US President Donald Trump said Friday he does not believe China or Russia are "participating" in the ongoing Iran conflict, but warned that if they did get involved "it would be very bad for them." "President Xi, at our recent meeting in Beijing, China, told me that he would not, under any circumstances, give or sell Weapons to the Islamic Republic of Iran — And that statement included Chinese Companies," he wrote on Truth Social. Trump said Putin had also told him that he would not sell weapons to Iran and that he believed Russia and China were not participating in the Iran conflict. "If they did, it would be very bad for them — Certainly not in their best interests," Trump posted. **REUTERS**

ern Iran, the semiofficial news outlets *Fars* and *ISNA* reported. Blasts from US bombardment overnight were also reported on Iran's Qeshm Island, a base for naval assets including drone boats that Iran can use to attack vessels in Strait of Hormuz, as well as in Isfahan province, home to a major Iranian air base and Iran's nuclear sites.

Merz reshuffles top posts to counter far-right surge

Associated Press
Berlin, July 24

GERMAN CHANCELLOR Friedrich Merz reshuffled top posts on Friday as he tries to boost the fortunes of his deeply unpopular government ahead of elections in which a far-right party could get its first state governor. Merz took office less than 15 months ago with pledges to reform and turn around Germany's economy, Europe's biggest, after years of stagnation. But that economic turnaround

has been slow to start. And the middle-of-the-road coalition of Merz's center-right Union bloc and the center-left Social Democrats, two traditional rivals, has yet to persuade voters that it can produce results. That has resulted in Merz's popularity sinking to rock-bottom levels, while the far-right Alternative for Germany, or AfD, has gained support on the back of discontent. Merz took the opportunity to make a series of changes after a senior ally quit as the leader of



Chancellor Friedrich Merz

his bloc's parliamentary group over personal conduct that undermined his credibility.

Merz plans to put his chief of staff, Thorsten Frei, in that job. The German leader said Health Minister Nina Warken will take Frei's place at the chancellery, a post that is key to the smooth functioning of the government. She will be the first woman to take that job. Another close ally, Carsten Linnemann, the general secretary of Merz's Christian Democratic Union party, will become health minister. Merz said there will be further Cabinet changes, but didn't offer details. He said

decisions will take "a few days yet, and perhaps more time." "The personnel changes follow a clear line," he said. "We want a government that works with great vigor and pleasure and also represents the personal diversity of our society and politics. We are a reform government and want to continue showing that." In the eastern region of Saxony-Anhalt AfD is hopeful of winning a majority that would give it control of a state government for the first time.

Tens of thousands evacuated as wildfires sweep France, Spain

Reuters
Madrid, Paris, July 24

TENS OF thousands of people fled wildfires in southwest France by car and boat on Friday and Spain declared a national emergency as huge blazes merged outside Madrid and searing heat left tinder-dry conditions across the region. French authorities ordered total evacuation of the Cap Ferret peninsula, a tourism hotspot on its Atlantic Coast. Two fires merged outside Madrid, and a third was on the verge of joining them, government officials said. Both countries, which have suffered a succession of heatwaves and fires in recent months and years that scientists say have been exacerbated by climate change, sought help from the EU



Smoke and flames rise as a wildfire advances near La Adrada, Ávila province, Spain, on Friday, AP

as the blazes strained emergency services. Spain's national emergency — the first it had ever declared over a wildfire — opened up federal funding to tackle the crisis. "This is the worst wildfire in our region's history," Madrid's regional leader Isabel Diaz Ayuso said. "It's the perfect storm of very high temperatures and ceaseless winds that aren't letting up." In southwest France, authorities sent boats to help the evacuation and a total of about 63,000 people were told to get out as two separate fires threatened homes.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Singer Chris Brown pleads guilty over bottle attack at London bar



Chris Brown arrives at Southwark Crown Court in London on Friday, AP

GRAMMY-WINNING singer Chris Brown pleaded guilty Friday to brawling at a London nightclub in 2023, a fight in which he hit a music producer over the head with a bottle. Brown, 37, made the change of plea during a hearing at London's Southwark Crown Court. He had earlier denied more serious charges over what prosecutors called a "vicious attack." In return for the guilty plea, prosecutors dropped charges of assault, attempting to cause grievous bodily harm and having an offensive weapon, a bottle. AP

VIETNAM

Govt plans to ban kids from posting on social media

VIETNAM IS planning to force social media platforms to ban users under 16 from posting content, commenting or reacting to posts, according to a draft decree reviewed by *Reuters*. The rules would require accounts belonging to children under 16 to be registered using the information of a parent or legal guardian responsible for supervision. **REUTERS**

IRELAND

Police intercept car bomb near Northern Ireland

AN "EXTREMELY significant" car bomb was intercepted earlier this week near the Northern Ireland border during a probe of disident republicans, Irish police said Friday. A woman driver in her 20s was arrested Wednesday near County Monaghan, and remained in custody Friday. A man in his 40s was later detained and continues to be held. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

15 troops killed in attack on police outpost in KPK

AT LEAST 15 personnel, including 12 soldiers, were killed in an attack on a joint police checkpoint in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the military's media wing said on Friday. The ISPR said attack in Tank district was carried out by the Fitna-al-Khawarij early on Friday. **PTI**

SRI LANKA

El Niño may arrive early, warnings issued

SRI LANKA is likely to face severe dry weather till September, followed by heavy rainfall till December as El Nino could hit the island nation earlier than expected, warned Environment Minister Dhammika Patabendi on Thursday. This will likely cause economic hardships, and job losses. **PTI**

Bangladesh President Shahabuddin, a close ally of Hasina, resigns

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, July 24

BANGLADESH PRESIDENT Mohammed Shahabuddin, a former ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned on Friday, two years ahead of the end of his tenure. "I am suffering from various health complications," the 76-year-old leader was quoted as saying by *The Daily Star* newspaper. He was responding to a question about the reason for his resignation. Bangabhaban - the president's house - spokesman told *PTI* Shahabuddin's representatives have left his office for the parliament carrying his resignation letter. The resignation letter would be submitted to parliamentary Speaker Hafizuddin Ahmed, who would serve as Acting President in accordance with the Bangladesh Constitution until a new President is elected. "I can't make any official comment on the resignation until the Speaker receives the



Mohammed Shahabuddin. FILE

letter," the spokesman said. His resignation comes amid speculations that Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's government was uncomfortable with the largely titular head of the state, according to media reports. A 1971 Liberation War veteran and former lower judiciary judge, Shahabuddin had taken the oath in April 2023 for a five-year term. He was elected to the highest office by the previous parliament and is the only person still holding his constitutional position, long after the violent 2024 student-led street protest that toppled Hasina's Awami League government.

• LIGHTERS ARE SHARED BY DOZENS OF FAMILIES, PASSED FROM TENT TO TENT UNTIL THEY BREAK FROM CONSTANT USE

In Gaza's tent camps, a cigarette lighter becomes a lifeline

Haseeb Alwazir & Nidal Al-Mughrabi
Cairo, Gaza, July 24

IN THE sprawling tent camps of southern Gaza, a disposable cigarette lighter has become an unlikely luxury item, as essential to daily survival as food, water and fuel. For displaced mother-of-four Nisreen Abu Saada, lighting a cooking fire can be a daily struggle in a territory where gas remains scarce and families rely on burning cardboard, plastic and scraps of wood to prepare meals. "There's no gas, and we're lighting fires 24 hours a day, which means a lighter is very essential," she told *Reuters*. Before the war, three lighters

cost one shekel (\$0.33). Now, a single lighter costs 100 shekels (\$32.55), something Abu Saada, 38, cannot afford. She was sitting beside a makeshift cooking area outside her tent in Khan Younis. Nearly three years into the Gaza war, shortages of basic goods have transformed everyday objects into prized possessions. Lighters are shared among dozens of families, passed from tent to tent before breaking under constant use. "When I want to light a fire, I wait for someone else to light one, or I go to where someone has lit a fire, take a piece of cardboard, light it, and bring it back," Abu Saada said. The scarcity has created a niche trade for Hassan Abu



Palestinian repairman Hassan Abu Latifa tests a repaired lighter at his kiosk in Khan Younis, southern Gaza Strip, on Thursday, REUTERS

Latifa, a displaced father of three who repairs broken plastic lighters at a small kiosk. "Repairing lighters is not really a profession, but because

of the suffering, people's need for them, and our need to work, we were compelled to take it up as one," said the 35-year-old, who worked as an agricultural

engineer before the war. Surrounded by boxes of damaged lighters and salvaged spare parts, Abu Latifa said soaring prices have forced families to repair lighters rather than replace them. The war has devastated Gaza's economy. UN agencies say unemployment in Gaza exceeds 80%, while poverty has approached 100% after the conflict wiped out most economic activity and destroyed infrastructure across the enclave. A US-brokered ceasefire in October halted major fighting but failed to end attacks by Israel, which says it has targeted Hamas and other Gaza militants posing an imminent threat. Hamas blames Israeli attacks

SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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Happening today

● **A CENTRAL GOVERNMENT** team will visit flood-hit Assam to review the rapidly deteriorating situation. The deluge has so far killed 47 people and affected over 7.21 lakh people across 11 districts in the state.

● **THE WEST BENGAL** government will table all pending Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reports in the state Assembly and recommend registration of FIRs wherever the audit findings establish corruption.

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SC bars court hearing clips on social media without approval



Direction by three-judge bench led by CJI Surya Kant

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

IN AN interim order Friday, the Supreme Court barred the recording and circulation of courtroom proceedings without prior permission of the court concerned. It concerns over alleged misuse on social media but clarified that the curb will not affect news reporting.

A three-judge bench, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said, "As an interim measure, we direct that there shall be no posting, reposting, extraction, modification, dissemination, monetisation, recording or review of the live-streamed proceedings of this court on social media or any other digital platform without the prior permission of the concerned registrar and the secretary general of this court and registrar general of high courts."

Directing the secretary general of the Supreme Court and registrar general of high courts to display this order on their court websites, the bench said, "This order shall have no bearing on news reporting."

The bench, also comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, was hearing a PIL by journalist Harshita Grover highlighting "increasing misuse of audiovisual recordings through selective clipping, editing, decontextualised

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POLITICS PAGE 5

CJI: COCKROACH REMARKS ONLY FOR FAKE LAW DEGREE HOLDERS

● **ELECTORAL ROLL REVISION IN SOME OF STATE'S MOST INACCESSIBLE VILLAGES**

Rivers rising, BLOs in Punjab's border areas take boats to meet SIR deadline

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, July 24

FOR MOST Booth Level Officers (BLOs), revising electoral rolls means walking from one house to another with forms in hand. For some in Punjab's remote border belt, it has meant rowing across rivers, waiting out floodwaters and, on occasion, relying on Army boats to return home.

As the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls gathers pace, BLOs posted in some of Punjab's most inaccessible villages have been navigating swollen rivers and flood-prone terrain to ensure

BILL LIKELY IN PARLIAMENT MONDAY; PM THANKS PEOPLE FOR 'POSITIVE SUGGESTIONS'

Jail up to 10 years, Rs 10-cr fine for exam leak: Nod for tough new law

Statutory backing for fast-track courts, 5 months for probe, trial

Damini Nath, Harikishan Sharma & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 24

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced fast-track courts and a tough new law to punish those involved in exam paper leaks, the Union Cabinet Friday approved a draft Bill with provisions for a jail term up to 10 years, penalty up to Rs 10 crore, statutory backing for fast-track courts and a five-month timeline for investigation and trial of cases, official sources said.

Hours later, in an Instagram post, Modi thanked everyone for the responses and positive suggestions received on his Thursday midnight video in which he announced the government's decision.

"Thank you, friends. I got the opportunity to talk to you at midnight. The way you have responded to my video, positive suggestions given by you, thanks to everybody. Your love will continue to flow; our relations will continue with more bonding. Thankyou, thankyou friends," he said in the new video message.

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BEYOND SONAM: PROTEST SHOWS NO SIGNS OF ABATING

2024 ANTI-PAPER LEAK ACT: HOW THE HOUSE PASSED IT



Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh with CJP's Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, Friday. ANI

Pradhan resignation non-negotiable, says CJP; more talks today: Centre

Sophiya Mathew & Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 24

REPRESENTATIVES OF the Cockroach Janta Party, spearheading the protest at Jantar Mantar over examination paper leaks, told the Centre Friday that their key demands for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, compensation for the families of students who ended

THE BIG PICTURE

Meet the protesters: Young, angry and very Gen Z [PAGE 9](#)

their lives following the NEET paper leak, and no legal action

against the protesters were not negotiable.

Union Minister J P Nadda, who along with his colleague Jitendra Singh met CJP spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das for nearly two hours at the Constitution Club of India, not far from the protest site, told reporters that the CJP demands and suggestions had been noted and there would be another meeting Saturday afternoon.

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NTA sacks 47 officials, Govt starts recruitment for reform overhaul

Four General Managers and 16 young professionals to be engaged: Ministry

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 24

IN A sweeping internal crack-down following the NEET-UG paper leak and amid protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party, the National Testing Agency (NTA), which is the

nodal autonomous body that conducts entrance tests to higher educational institutions, has "terminated the services" of 47 officials, sources told *The Indian Express*.

Sources said the agency would also initiate "legal and criminal action" against the of-

ficials to send a "strong message". These are "only the initial steps" in reforming the functioning of the agency, and "several more stringent and reform-oriented measures" are likely to follow, the sources said.

In a separate statement signalling wider reforms within the NTA, the Education Ministry said it has issued advertisements for the appointment of senior professionals at the level

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



Lawyer who fought Wangchuk's NSA case, three days of talks: The nudge that convinced activist to end fast



Sonam Wangchuk with wife Gitanjali J Angmo and MPs Vivek Tankha, Sagarika Ghose and John Brittas at Medanta Hospital, Gurgaon. ANI

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 24

THREE DAYS of negotiations, the government softening its stand, and intervention by Sonam Wangchuk's lawyer and leaders from Ladakh driven by concerns about his health. That's what it took to nudge the activist, the face of the ongoing Jantar Mantar protests, to reconsider his position and break his fast late on Thursday night.

Sources said the government began making attempts to reach out to Wangchuk by the evening of July 20 when the protests ran into lathicharges and tear gas fired by the police during the march to Parliament. It is learnt that Vivek Tankha who was among the lawyers who fought Wangchuk's National Security Act (NSA) case in the Supreme Court — and is known to be close to the activist — played a

significant role in persuading him to end the fast. A source said Tankha's intervention was driven purely by his concern for Wangchuk's failing health due to the prolonged hunger strike. "He had lost more than 11 kg and those around him were concerned," the source said.

Sources said that after speaking to Tankha, who is a Congress MP, Wangchuk issued an open letter to Nadda in

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SECTION 301 FORCED LABOUR PROBE

India attracts 10% US tariff, lower rate after policy shift

12.5 per cent for Vietnam, China: Trump administration redraws tariff architecture

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 24

THE US Friday imposed 10% tariffs on India, lower than the 12.5% rate proposed in March when the United States Trade Representative (USTR) identified 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, citing import of goods produced with forced labour.

This comes weeks after the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) announced prohibition of import of goods produced using forced labour, along with parallel negotiations for a trade deal with the US.

In the new tariff regime enforced Friday, the European Union and Taiwan received the most favourable rates — the Section 301 tariff is applied on goods from these two economies only if the product's existing most favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%. If

E. EXPLAINED

Bar on import of forced-labour goods

Ahead of the US tariffs, India barred the import of goods made using forced labour. On July 13, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade had inserted a new paragraph in the Foreign Trade Policy regarding 'forced labour', stating that import of goods produced or manufactured, 'wholly or in part', through the use of forced labour is 'prohibited'.

the product from the EU or Taiwan already has an MFN tariff of 10% or higher, the Section 301 tariff is zero.

India has been placed in the

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HC: OpenAI's use of copyrighted material to train ChatGPT 'fair'

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI High Court has held that OpenAI's training of its large language models (LLMs) on original retrieved copyrighted works constituted fair dealing, and did not amount to infringement of copyright.

The interim ruling Friday by Justice Amit Bansal extends a measure of legal cover to developers of artificial intelligence (AI) chatbots such as OpenAI to continue training on Indian-origin content without licensing agreements, and also interprets broadly what constitutes "fair use" of copyrighted works.

The suit, the first of its kind in Indian jurisdiction, was moved by news agency ANI Media Pvt Ltd in 2024 against OpenAI Inc and OpenAI OpCo LLC, seeking an injunction against the use of

its copyrighted content in the training of LLMs.

California-based OpenAI is the developer of the ChatGPT series of generative AI models. Open AI OpCo LLC is the commercial arm of the organisation. "...in my prima facie view, Open AI's acts of storage of the literary works of ANI for the training of its LLMs would fall under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act (fair dealing) and hence, would not amount to infringement," Justice Bansal ruled.

He took into consideration that OpenAI's use of the copyrighted works for training its LLMs is "completely an internal process" and does not involve providing the copyrighted material to any third party.

"I am also of the prima facie view that the outputs generated

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NATION
13 DEAD AS FALLING BOULDERS CRUSH MOVING VEHICLE IN HIMACHAL

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NATION
ANOTHER INDIAN SAILOR KILLED IN UKRAINE-RUSSIA WAR: MEA

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POLITICS
UNION MINISTER BITTU QUILTS, TO FOCUS ON 2027 PUNJAB ELECTION

[PAGE 5](#)



BLOs Pushpa Grover and Darshan Singh cross the Sutlej on a boat to reach Kaluwala village in Punjab's Ferozepur district. EXPRESS

on the other, while the international border is barely 8 kilometres away.

Of Punjab's 12,500 villages, 50 are considered remote because they are located along the

international border and have poor road connectivity.

For part of the year, a temporary pontoon bridge connects the villages with the mainland. During monsoon, the bridge is dismantled as the river swells, leaving boats as the only means of transport.

"These villages are cut off during monsoons but that doesn't happen every year," one official said.

Gurdaspur alone has 15 such villages. "The Ajnala, Dharamkot and Bhoo Assembly segments also have such remote villages," Tript Rajinder Singh Bajwa, Congress MLA from Fatehgarh Churian in Gurdaspur, told *The Indian Express*.

For BLOs, this means crossing the swelling river multiple times during the exercise — from house-to-house enumeration and mapping, and follow-up rounds that involve revisiting locked houses and identifying ineligible voters, to sitting at local polling booths to process forms.

Singh recalled one such day when a routine visit nearly turned into a rescue operation.

"The water level was manageable when I went to Bharyal. But by the time I had to return, flash floods in Rajouri had affected the river here too. Then the Army boat helped us come back," he said.

"When the river is in spate,

village boats stop operating because it becomes risky. The Army takes over with boats, life jackets and all necessary arrangements."

He said residents had urged authorities to keep the pontoon bridge in place this year, but rising water levels made that impossible.

Boat to Kaluwala

Nearly 150 km away, a similar story is unfolding in Ferozepur district.

Kaluwala village, under Polling Station No. 7 of the Ferozepur Urban Assembly constituency, is often called Punjab's island village. Encircled by the

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Bhagwat: Knowledge on Hindu gods should be part of school textbooks

Divya A
New Delhi, July 24

RSS CHIEF Mohan Bhagwat on Friday batted for inclusion of knowledge on Hindu gods in school textbooks.

Addressing a programme organised by the RSS on the topic of ‘Contemporary Motherhood’, he said that the new generation seeks logic in everything, and believes in discussion, not dictation. “Sometimes, children ask these questions, especially abroad, why this god with a monkey face and why does this god have an elephant face? They come home and ask these questions but the father doesn’t know, the mother doesn’t know. This should be part of textbooks, even as children can’t be left to textbooks alone,” he said.

At the beginning of his address, he said, “Being asked to speak on the subject of motherhood, in itself, a contradiction... In a way, it is women’s right, and it is not appropriate for men to speak about it.” Even as he said that today everyone thinks more as an individual than as part of society, which leads to disintegration, he advocated that women of today must be given opportunities and empowered.

The audience — largely women and several male Sangh functionaries and BJP leaders — also included Union Women and Child Development Minister Annapurna Devi and Rajasthan Deputy CM Diya Kumar sitting in the front row along with BJP MPs Kangana Ranaut, Swati Maliwal and Bansuri Swaraj; besides Mallika Nadra and Lakshmi Puri, spouses of Union ministers J P Nadda and Har-



RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat at an event in Delhi, Friday. ANIL SHARMA

deep Puri, respectively. BJP veteran Murlu Manohar Joshi, who had a day earlier, expressed concern over the students’ protests and handling of the youth, was also present at the event.

Bhagwat said, “Being in accordance with the times is also a subject of motherhood that does not require discussion. It happens on its own. Human beings change all their ways according to time.” However, he said that since the focus of the family unit is the mother, she ought to be “*sanskari* and *vi-chaarsheel* (visionary)”. “It is the mother’s role to shape the perspective of her children, and not only their career,” he said.

He said parents should spend more time with their families and maintain open communication with children. He stressed that children learn more through observation than instruction, making it important for parents to lead by example. He said parents should continue to expand their knowledge so they can address their children’s questions and curiosity. The three-hour event, organised by Vishwa Mangalya Sabha, also had the RSS chief interacting with women leaders in a brief question and hour session. The next such session will be held in Hyderabad later this month.

MEA pushes back on Wang’s remark attributed to Jaishankar

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

TWO DAYS after China claimed that External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar had told Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi that India’s positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang (Tibet) have not changed, and that India respects China’s sovereignty, Delhi pushed back on Friday, clarifying that what Jaishankar actually said was “when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them”.

Jaishankar and Wang met in Manila, The Philippines, on July 22 on the sidelines of the ASEAN and East Asia foreign ministers meeting, where the Indian minister had underlined that “peace and tranquillity in the border areas” is the prerequisite for normal ties — Delhi’s position on the border standoff for the last six years.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry readout in state-run news agency *Xinhua* had stated, “Jaishankar said that India’s positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang have not changed, and India respects China’s sovereignty.”

Responding to questions

about the readout, the MEA’s official spokesperson Randhir Jaishwal said, “Yes. External Affairs Minister said that when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them. India does not violate China’s sovereignty in any manner and has been consistent. But China is in illegal occupation of Indian territory in Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh since 1963, where India’s right is officially acknowledged even by China. Also, there are Chinese projects on territories in Jammu and Kashmir that belong to India, and we object to that.”

On July 22, Jaishankar had said, “Peace and tranquillity in the border areas is obviously the prerequisite for normal ties. Since October 2024, both sides have engaged to ensure that important objective. This will continue to need our constant attention. Relevant mechanisms in this domain must be given full support and strong encouragement.” This was a reference to the India-China agreement on disengagement, after a four-year border standoff in eastern Ladakh, which was agreed in October 2024 and completed in November 2024.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

New law

The Cabinet, sources said, approved a proposal to amend The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. Under Section 10 of the Act, the punishment for individuals resorting to unfair means is imprisonment of three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh. Section 11 provides for imprisonment of five to 10 years and a fine of at least Rs 1 crore for those involved in organised crime.

Without specifying if it would be applicable to individuals or organised crime, sources said the Bill would increase the imprisonment term up to 10 years and a fine up to Rs 10 crore.

Among the proposed amendments in the Bill is a time-bound investigation and trial of paper leak cases within five months. According to sources, the proposed amendments in the law provides a two-month time frame for investigation of paper leak cases and three months for completion of trials of such cases. Thus, the Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

paper leak cases will be fast-tracked and will be taken to conclusion within five months, the sources said.

The fast-track courts to be set up for such cases would be given statutory backing through the Bill, the sources said.

The existing law that came into effect on June 21, 2024 aimed to curb leaks, malpractices as well as organised malpractices in public examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission, the Staff Selection Commission, the Railway Recruitment Board, the Institute of Banking Personnel

Selection and the National Testing Agency which, among others, conducts the NEET exam.

Sources said the amendment Bill is likely to be brought in Parliament Monday, as announced by the Prime Minister Thursday.

Earlier Thursday, Law and Justice Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said the fast-track courts would be set up in the High Courts of Bombay, Calcutta, Delhi and Madhya Pradesh where cases pertaining to the NEET paper leak are ongoing.

Any such move, a source said, could set a new precedent. “The government cannot be seen as succumbing to pressure from protesting forces or groups. Tomorrow, another group may come up and demand the resignation of others,” the source said. Another source said the government has indicated it is ready to accept CJP demand that there be no punitive measures against protesting students. The government, the source said, is also ready to look into ways to compensate families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide following the paper leak. “The government will look at the rules and procedure for providing compensation in these circumstances. DMs have been asked to look at the details of each family. The government has to see it does not create any wrong precedent... It should withstand judicial scrutiny too,” the source said.

CJP-Govt

The meeting took place hours after activist Sonam Wangchuk, who had backed the CJP demands, ended his 26-day hunger strike Thursday night at Medanta Hospital in Gurgaon in the presence of Nadda and Singh. Rankasaid, “The government has asked for time until tomorrow afternoon on our demand for Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation. We hope the government will remove him soon.”

He said there was “in-principle approval” from the government on the demands relating to compensation and the withdrawal of FIRs and legal cases against students.

The CJP also sought a public apology from the Centre, the head of the Rapid Action Force and the Delhi Police Commis-

sioner to students assaulted during the protests.

Nadda said, “Today, we had come here to discuss the issues of the agitating people, and the conversation lasted for almost two hours. From the government’s side, Dr Jitendra Singh Ji and I participated in the conversation. We listened to their points. The discussions took place in a cordial atmosphere, and from many perspectives. All matters were thoroughly discussed in every way.”

“Their main demands were three, and from the perspective of reforms, there were five suggestions for the examination. We have told them that we will meet with you again tomorrow afternoon, and then whatever further discussion or conversation takes place, we will inform you about it,” he said.

The CJP representatives also sought a response from the Centre to their five-point charter

Wrappers

the protest site in large quantities. The staff were told the store was tracked through the packaging material found at the protest site.

“We were not at the store when the officers came. They asked for details from our staff and, via them, summoned us to the police station,” the owner said, adding that they went to the police station the same night.

“The inspector there told us that many anti-social elements present at the protests were availing of our food and essentially asked us to refrain from sending more stuff. They also asked us about any bulk orders

that we received through online platforms like Swiggy and Zomato, and then told us that such orders should raise red flags for us and we shouldn’t service them. Since then, almost everyone in our family has advised us not to send food to the protests, and I guess that’s the police’s whole point, to create that kind of an intimidating environment,” the owner said.

Apart from volunteers bringing and distributing free food at Jantar Mantar since the protest started on June 20, supporters from across India and overseas have been sending meals, snacks and bottled water through delivery apps. Many local eateries also sent free food to the protest site, besides posting social media announcements offering “a place to pause,

OpenAI

by ChatGPT using the RAG (retrieval-augmented generation) technique does not amount to infringement under the Copyright Act since the outputs generated by OpenAI were not substantially similar to ANI (inputs),” he said.

Justice Bansal said ANI had “failed to satisfy” the court “that any memorisation or regurgitation” of ANI’s copyrighted works happened through the responses generated by ChatGPT. The “balance of convenience” was in favour of OpenAI, the judge said — “irreparable injury would be caused not only to OpenAI but also to the public at large” if any interim injunction was granted in favour of ANI.

Two district courts in the US took a broadly similar line in two closely watched copyright cases that were decided within days of each other in June 2025. A group of writers had filed a class action complaint against Anthropic, the company behind the Claude family of LLMs; in the second case, a group of authors had sued Meta Platforms, whose research division Meta AI has developed the chatbot Llama.

The judges held that AI works did not substitute for the original works; rather, they generated something new from them. The ruling in the Meta case underlined that the plaintiffs had not shown that the training measurably harmed the market for their books. Both US verdicts have been relied upon by the Delhi High Court in its ruling.

Several media and publishing organisations and associations such as the Federation of Indian Publishers, Digital News Publishers Association, and the Indian Music Industry had joined as parties to ANI’s suit and raised similar objections to OpenAI’s training model.

On Friday’s ruling, IP lawyer Amit Kumar Panigrahi, partner at Kochhar & Co., said the verdict, apart from being a boost to developers, is likely to prompt copyright owners to revisit their contractual frameworks, including licensing models and AI-specific restrictions in content access and use agreements.

Three days of talks

which he put forward his conditions for ending the fast. He requested an “unequivocal assurance from the government that none of the young protesters will face any punitive or retaliatory legal action for participating in this movement”.

This was a climbdown from the collective demand of the protests that Pradhan must resign. “The government did not approach me for this. They were talking to Gitanjali (Angmo, Wangchuk’s wife). Yes, I helped Gitanjali and Sonam in the whole process as they were consulting me throughout. I was also trying to convince him to break his fast. Sonam ending his fast is separate from the ongoing movement. The movement of the youth continues. But his health was deteriorating. It was important to save his life. He is an inspiration to the youth in the country. He was to end his fast on July 20 itself. But the government treated him badly. So, he continued his fast,” Tankha told *The Indian Express*.

On July 21, Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh met Wangchuk at Medanta Hospital in Gurgaon. The two are learnt to have assured him that issues raised by him would be taken up for discussion in Parliament and urged him to end his fast. Singh had spoken to Gitanjali Angmo earlier too, it is learnt.

On July 22, a delegation of MPs led by Tankha met Wangchuk and Angmo. They appealed to the activist to withdraw his fast, saying the struggle for a fair and transparent examination system had become a national cause.

Several other MPs also tried to meet Wangchuk at the time but were not allowed. The delegation also handed over a letter signed by MPs cutting across party lines, among them Shashi Tharoor, Tiruchi Siva, Ram Gopal Yadav, Kapil Sibal, John Brittas, and Sagarika Ghose.

By late night on July 23, Nadda and Singh arrived at Medanta with a written assurance from the government. It said, “Government is positive on not registering cases against those protesting peacefully at Jantar Mantar in Delhi and those participating in the march to Parliament...”

The assurances included a discussion in Parliament and “suitable compensation” for suicide victims following the NEET paper leak. PM Narendra Modi had already announced by then that a new Bill would be introduced in Parliament to

NTA

merit list”. These appointments, the Education Ministry said, will mark “the first concrete step in the institutional rebuild of NTA” being implemented in line with the recommendations of the high-level committee of experts chaired by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan.

The *Indian Express* had first reported on July 7 that the Government is all set to overhaul the NTA, covering its organisation, infrastructure, technology and processes.

According to the Education Ministry, four contractual positions of General Manager — each for an initial term of three years — have been notified: Test Centre Network and Operations; Information Security; Vigilance, Investigation and Forensics; and

deal with paper leaks.

Sources said that while Wangchuk was hesitant to end the hunger strike, his wife told him that he had to keep his word to the government. “His wife finally persuaded him to end the fast,” said a minister.

Sources close to Wangchuk said his decision was entirely informed by his concern for the well-being of protesters who he felt could face serious legal trouble in future. Sources said Wangchuk was likely to stay in the hospital for the next few days to complete his recovery. He is likely to meet youth leaders at Jantar Mantar before going back to Ladakh.

In parallel, civil society leaders from Ladakh arrived in Delhi from Leh on July 21. Their attempts to meet Wangchuk were unsuccessful on July 21 and 22. On July 23, however, the leaders were allowed to meet Wangchuk in the morning, accompanied by an Intelligence Bureau official.

The Ladakh leaders too urged Wangchuk to end his fast. “By the time we met him, an understanding had already been reached between the government and him about ending his fast. We need him in Ladakh to spearhead our own negotiations with the government on issues concerning our region,” a leader in the Ladakh delegation told *The Indian Express*.

— WITH INPUTS BY LIZ MATHEW

SC clips

circulation, and commercial exploitation on social media and digital platforms”.

The plea said, “Isolated courtroom exchanges, oral observations, and preliminary remarks are frequently extracted from lengthy hearings and circulated without the factual or legal context in which they were made. Such clips are often accompanied by misleading captions, sensational commentary, and clickbait headlines designed to maximise public engagement and commercial gain.”

It said unchecked circulation of such content had exposed judges, advocates and litigants to unwarranted criticism, trolling, vilification, and reputational harm. “More importantly, it risks undermining public confidence in the administration of justice by creating distorted and incomplete narratives regarding judicial proceedings,” it said.

The bench asked the various high courts to submit reports on the adoption of its livestreaming guidelines. It also asked the Centre to appraise which minis-

tries could implement the reliefs sought.

Appearing for Grover, Senior Advocate Vikas Singh expressed apprehension on clips of hearings being edited and circulated on social media.

“I personally don’t see any problem with livestream,” he said, referring to the recent instance of a hearing before a bench wherein the petitioner threw files and used abusive words, going viral on social media. “Adding words and showing clips is also happening,” he said.

Justice Bagchi said that once such live streams are uploaded on digital platforms, it becomes difficult to manage their circulation. “Regulating data is one of the biggest challenges in digital space... so we should ensure limited access and therefore restrict livestream itself. Parties must expressly make a prayer that they want to see. It can’t be a 24/7 entertainment channel by court... That belittles the justice system,” he said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta pointed to the dangers of AI and said some tools can alter the words spoken by someone while preserving the lip movements.

10% tariff

second tier where the US has imposed a standard 10% tariff rate on 17 economies — others in the category are Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia and Malaysia under which these economies would import US cotton and textile goods for final manufacturing. No such TRQ has been announced for India.

The USTR has also established textile tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia and Malaysia under which these economies would import US cotton and textile goods for final manufacturing. No such TRQ has been announced for India.

Based on the findings in the investigation of India, including India’s adoption of a forced labor import prohibition subsequent to the publication of the June 5, 2026 FRN, and considering the public comments and testimony, the advice of the Section 301 Committee, as well as the advice of advisory committees, and in accordance with the specific direction of the President, the Trade Representative has determined to impose 10% tariffs on products of India,” the USTR said.

The standard 10% tariffs on India are similar to those on ASEAN countries such as Malaysia and Indonesia but better than Vietnam which now falls under the least favourable countries with 12.5% tariffs alongside China, Russia, Brazil, Australia, the Philippines, Turkey and Saudi Arabia.

Under the new tariff design, Japan, South Korea and Switzerland are placed better than countries such as Vietnam and China, as they are subject to a 12.5% rate net of MFN.

Similar to the EU and Taiwan mechanism, their duty is determined by MFN plus Section 301. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+4zRvD_RG9mljMzg1

BLOs

Sutlej on three sides and the India-Pakistan border fence on the fourth, it sits barely a kilometre from the international border. The village has little permanent infrastructure and is accessible largely by boat. Temporary Army pontoon bridges are erected only during emergencies. Repeated floods and its location on the border have forced many residents to move away, leaving behind a population of about 200.

For Darshan Singh and Pushpa Grover, teachers at Government School, Tendiwala, carrying out the SIR has meant making repeated boat journeys across the Sutlej.

“There are 150 voters. I have completed 82 percent of my work,” Darshan Singh said. “Some residents who have gone out of the village will re-

turn after planting paddy. Earlier, I used to go every day. The villagers are adept at rowing boats and we have been using them.”

Pushpa Grover said, “I have also been taking the boat to reach the village. The pontoon bridge is no longer there... I live in this area, so it is not a hardship for me. I have completed 90 percent of my work. The rest will be done soon.”

Despite their isolation, villages such as Kaluwala have consistently recorded high voter turnout.

Punjab Chief Electoral Officer Anindita Mitra said the exercise had highlighted the dedication of BLOs working under difficult conditions. “The BLOs have shown tremendous professionalism in carrying out the SIR in Punjab. They took whatever route was available. They are the praiseworthy partners in the SIR and have done commendable work,” she said.



Protesters and security personnel at Jantar Mantar on Friday. TASHI TOBGYAL & ABHINAV SAHA

Speeches made since Sonam's removal to be examined: Police

Sakshi Chand & Pragynesh
New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI Police will assess all the speeches made at the protest called by the CJP at Jantar Mantar since activist Sonam Wangchuk was removed from the site on July 18 to examine if any inflammatory comments were made to trigger the demonstrators, sources told *The Indian Express*. A police officer also said that the speeches would include the ones given by celebrities and political leaders.

A total of 15 FIRs have been registered so far following the 'Sansad Chalo' march on July 20, said officers, adding that first one registered at Parliament Street police station — after the first reports of stone pelting came from the 'Selfie Point' area in Connaught Place — will have sections of criminal conspiracy added to it.

"Around 2,500 people have been found to be involved in violence and 100-200 protestors are suspected to have been involved in inciting the crowd and getting involved in stone pelting and creating ruckus," an officer said. A source said that the police have over 5 terabyte of related data, and will conduct a detailed investigation in the coming days.

Police had earlier said that they are examining encrypted chats on the Bitchat app, which works over Bluetooth mesh networks; locality and college-based WhatsApp groups; social media posts; CCTV camera footage; mobile phone data and facial recognition records.

Investigators said that they are examining whether charges of culpable homicide apply after a 22-year-old woman was injured in the stampede-like situation that followed.

The other challenge: 15,000 kg of garbage daily at protest site

Mishal Mussaddique & Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 24

AT JANTAR Mantar, the crowds are growing every day. So is the garbage. Plastic bottles, paper plates and food packets line the protest site, accompanied by a constant stench.

"There is no standard waste management protocol when more than 5,000 people gather every day," said an official from New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC), in charge of managing waste in the area.

"Earlier, we collected around 500-600 kg of waste from Tolstoy Marg, Sansad Marg and Jantar Mantar Road. Now we lift nearly 15,000 kg of waste every day."

To manage the waste, the NDMC has deployed extra workers in three shifts. About 50 workers clean the area in the morning, 15 in the afternoon and 20 in the evening.

"We also use gobblers — battery-operated, eco-friendly litter-pickers — and vacuum devices designed to rapidly collect solid waste. Fogging machines and disinfectant sprays are also used in regular intervals. Further, auto-tippers and garbage trucks come to the protest site in coordination with the police," the official said.

Still, garbage piled up over the last few days, especially next to an abandoned building opposite Kerala House.

"The NDMC had not collected garbage from the protest area for many days. Today we called them, and they cleared the heap," said Gyan (35), one of the protesters.

As per NDMC officials, they could not enter the area because police permission had not been granted. "We didn't have clear-



Four portable toilets — three for women and one for all — were installed on Tolstoy Road, Friday. MISHAL MUSSADDIQUE

ance from the district commissioner of police to clear waste for the last couple of days. As soon as we got permission, the entire area was wet cleaned," said the official.

Many protesters, meanwhile, have taken it upon themselves to keep Jantar Mantar clean. Near the protest site, on Tolstoy Road, opposite The Imperial Hotel, Amaldeep Singh (26) — who had travelled from Malout in Punjab for the protest — was seen collecting waste off the footpath amid the sea of people. "This is seva (service). When I came here last night, I saw some children clearing waste. I thought why can't I do this too? Whatever I collect, I put it near the barricade opposite McDonald's," he headed.

Priya (25), a UPSC aspirant, feels that collecting waste gives her a sense of responsibility.

"I want to show that we youth are not here to have fun, we can also take some responsibility... Many are littering without any hesitation. What is the kind of message that we are try-

ing to send out there?"

NDMC officials said such volunteers have made their work easier. "We can't deny it. The children have been really helpful and have coordinated with us throughout to make our work easier," said the official.

However, not everyone collecting waste is a volunteer.

Thirteen-year-old Janisar and his uncle Nasim, who collect scrap for a living, have been visiting the protest site for the last few days to gather discarded plastic bottles. The two sell them to a scrap dealer on Minty Road.

"We have been coming here for the last three-four days. We keep walking around collecting bottles. We eat the free food distributed here and sleep at the protest site," said Nasim, adding that they earn around Rs 800-900 a day.

Outside the The Imperial Hotel, meanwhile, stood four portable toilets — three for women and one for all. The Sakhkhand Foundation, whose members are volunteering at the protest site, got them installed

on Friday.

This comes amid reports that many protesters are complaining of headaches and sore throats at Jantar Mantar.

Volunteer doctors present at the site report that the overcrowding and open-air living conditions have left a large number of people grappling with viral infections, dehydration, and other health issues.

Speaking to *PTI*, Dr Shilpa from Punjab's Five River Heart Association said a large number of people are approaching her with complaints of sore throats, headaches and high fever.

Many are sleeping on the ground in the open, increasing the risk of infection, said Shilpa, who is providing free medical care to protesters at Jantar Mantar. She said that by Wednesday evening, over 200 people had been administered paracetamol and other related medications.

Another doctor from Patiala, requesting anonymity, said due to the large crowds, the infection is spreading through coughing and sneezing.

'To maintain law & order', liquor shops in Delhi to shut by 8 pm until Sunday

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 24

FOLLOWING INSTRUCTIONS from the Delhi Police Special Branch, the Excise department directed that liquor shops in the city will be shut by 8 pm on three days — Friday to Sunday. Currently, liquor shops in the city closes at 10 pm.

"The revised timings have been implemented from today. A formal order is on the way in the regard. The decision has been taken following directions from the Delhi Police," a senior Excise department official said

"While students are protesting peacefully, some anti-social elements are trying to disrupt the protest by drinking and creating ruckus. As this can lead to untoward incidents, police requested us to revise the timings of liquor shops... it has been done," the official added.

Officials said that the Special Branch, on Friday, officially wrote to Principal Secretary (Home and Finance) Santosh D Vaidya requesting that the order be immediately implemented. "It is submitted that credible intelligence inputs indicate the likelihood of certain anti-social and disruptive elements attempting to exploit the prevailing situation to create disturbances affecting public order at various locations in the National Capital Territory of Delhi," read the letter undersigned by Ankit Chauhan, DCP, Special Branch.

It added that the available inputs further "indicate that such elements may resort to consumption of liquor during the evening hours and thereafter indulge in hooliganism, unruly and disorderly conduct, breach

of peace, acts of violence, damage to public property, obstruction of public ways and other unlawful activities, thereby posing a potential threat to public safety, security and maintenance of law and order."

According to the police, continued operation of liquor vendors up to 10 pm may facilitate easy access to liquor during the critical evening period and "increase the possibility of intoxication-induced incidents capable of escalating into serious law and order situations, requiring substantial police intervention and deployment."

"...as a preventive measure aimed at maintaining public order, ensuring public safety and denying opportunities to anti-social elements to exploit the prevailing situation, it is requested that directions may kindly be issued for closure of all liquor vendors/shops in the National Capital Territory of Delhi by 2000 hrs... for the next three days..." the letter read.

The police have also told the government that if the current situation prevails, it may extend the further extend the time restrictions beyond three days. "The requirement for continuation of the above arrangement, if warranted by the prevailing situation, shall be communicated," the letter issued with the approval of Commissioner of Police, said.

Currently, the city has 700 government liquor shops run by four corporations.

An official from one of the corporations said, "The directions have been verbally issued... all the vendors and corporations will implement it immediately. An official order will be issued to all shops soon."

Delhi Police forms STF to probe paper leaks, public exam offences

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, July 24

TO STRENGTHEN probe into alleged irregularities in the conduct of public examinations, the Delhi Police on Friday constituted a Special Task Force (STF) within its Crime Branch to investigate paper leaks and other offences under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, officers said.

According to a statement issued by Delhi Police on Friday, the STF has been constituted with the approval of the Commissioner of Police and will conduct probe into offences related to public examinations conducted by agencies including the UPSC, Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Railway Recruitment Boards (RRBs), Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS), National Testing Agency (NTA) and recruitment examinations conducted by Union Government, besides any other authority notified by the Centre.

As per officers, the STF will also coordinate with prosecuting agencies to ensure speedy prosecution of such cases.

The unit will be headed by the DCP, Crime Branch, while the Special Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch will exercise overall supervision and administrative control over its functioning, an officer said.

Training of RAF personnel postponed; 10 more CRPF companies for Capital

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 24

THE CENTRE has directed the airlifting of 10 more CRPF companies from Chhattisgarh to deploy in Delhi to bolster security measures in view of the student protest underway, officials said on Friday. The CRPF headquarters has also postponed one of the training sessions of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) due to the ongoing protests at Jantar Mantar, they added.

According to an official communication, the RAF per-

sonnel were set to undergo training from July 27 to August 8 in Meerut. The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) officials said that orders have been issued to sanction only emergency leaves to its Delhi Metro unit as maximum manpower is required at the stations owing to the security situation.

According to officials, a security review meeting held in Delhi on Thursday required all Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) units scheduled to be stationed in the Capital ahead of Independence Day to report

early. They said that about 150 CAPF companies will be deployed in Delhi over the next few days. A CAPF company has about 100 personnel. About 100 such companies are already in Delhi assisting the local police with law and order duties, officials said.

Earlier this week, the Centre airlifted 20 CRPF companies from West Bengal to deploy in Delhi. Followed close in its wake was the induction of three RAF units and several other CAPF units, such as the SSB, BSF, and ITBP.

HC refuses to order NIA probe into foreign funding claims

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI High Court on Friday declined to entertain a plea seeking a probe by the NIA into the allegations of foreign funding and assault of police personnel tied to CJP-led march to Parliament on July 20 to protest the NEET paper leak and other related issues.

Even as the government suggested that the court can issue a notice, a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia noted that Supreme Court judgements have already dealt with the

procedure to be followed when officers are injured, and public and private property suffers damage during such cases of "unlawful assembly".

Addressing Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who was representing the government and the petitioner, the HC said, "Are you saying you're not following (laid down mandate.... to need court directions)? There is every authority available to you to deal with such situations. Do that. You're under a mandate (to act according to laid down law)."

Satish Kumar Aggarwal, ex-vice president of Akhil Bharat Hindu Mahasabha, who had

moved the petition, withdrew it after the HC indicated that it is not inclined to entertain the petition. Aggarwal, in his petition, wanted the court to direct the NIA or any other specialised probe agency to probe the alleged attempts at blocking Parliament and alleged stone pelting at police personnel on July 20 during the 'Sansad Chalo' march of the CJP.

Aggarwal sought the HC intervention to direct the authorities to "identify persons responsible for acts of violence, vandalism, obstruction of emergency services, damage to public and private property,"

While Aggarwal's counsel stressed that the "fundamental rights" of citizens are being denied owing to the disruption in livelihoods, including due to the shutdown of some Metro stations, the High Court said that there is an alternate remedy available to air these grievances.

The court opined that Aggarwal can approach the government with a representation, and the government can take a decision on it accordingly.

The court made the remarks even as SG Mehta urged the court that Aggarwal's petition can be heard along with two

other petitions that deal with police excesses on protesters, and the government's response can be called for.

The court also disposed of a petition by NGO Save India Foundation which was imploring the court's intervention on alleged attack on security officers. The court permitted the outfit to make its representation to the government.

The HC also dealt with a third petition by former JNUSU president Aishwarya Ghosh, objecting to the continuous and indiscriminate surveillance at the protest site, which it will hear on July 27.

● ACTIVIST ENDED HIS 26-DAY FAST EARLY FRIDAY

Beyond Sonam Wangchuk: At Jantar Mantar, the protest shows no sign of abating

Akriti Kanodia
New Delhi, July 24

AS LONG queues waited to enter Jantar Mantar, volunteers distributed food and water, slogans gave way to songs and protesters prepared for another long night, activist Sonam Wangchuk unexpectedly ended his 26-day hunger strike following talks with the Centre early Friday.

Many at the protest site did not immediately know that Wangchuk had ended his fast. With mobile Internet data sus-

pended within a 1.5-km radius of Jantar Mantar, many learnt of it only when they stepped outside the area.

"We went to Jama Masjid to eat," said Avik, a student. "We got network there and saw what had happened. Then we came back."

Wangchuk had been on an indefinite hunger strike since June 28 at Jantar Mantar, where the CJP has been demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over the NEET paper leak.

Around 12.45 am on Friday, he broke his fast in the presence of Union Health Minister J P Nadda and Union Minister Jitendra Singh.

For many who returned to the protest site after hearing the news, Wangchuk's decision did not change the reason why they were there.

"I think the limelight should shift away from a centralised personality to the issues, because it is the issues that matter," said a working professional at the protest.

"People can come and go,



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke at Jantar Mantar on Friday. ABHINAV SAHA

but this is about people's lives. It is about the 21 lives who are

not here with us anymore." Referring to images of

Wangchuk being offered a drink by Nadda, she added, "People who understand politics know what that means."

Krishna Yadav, one of the volunteers coordinating supplies, said donations from across the country had kept the protest running. "Some people sent medicines, some sent food," he said.

Asked whether Wangchuk ending his fast would change anything, he said the protest would continue regardless: "We are here 24 hours."

Supplies, however, have thinned.

At one point, an exhausted volunteer tried to stop a group of boys from entering the packed venue. "There's no point going inside now," he said.

One of the boys replied, "It's okay, we will be here tomorrow too."

Not all agreed on what would happen next.

Some said the focus had shifted from Pradhan's resignation to a broader demand for accountability; others said the original demands stood

unchanged.

"We have given you a chance to raise your voice in a democracy," said Vikant, a protester and medical volunteer.

"If we are asking, revert with the answer. Say sorry, at least. Come out and say, 'I made a mistake.' Then fix it," he added.

Avik admitted that the protest may now slow down with Wangchuk ending his hunger strike. He, however, maintained: "But the protest has become bigger than one person. Everyone is a face. Everyone is a leader."

Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram introduced in House

Nikhil Ghanekar, Asad Rehman & Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 24

AMID CONTINUED demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the first week of the Monsoon Session ended in a washout on Friday, with the exception of the introduction of The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in the Rajya Sabha.

The Bill seeks to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to make insults to National Song Vande Mataram a criminal offence, punishable with imprisonment up to five years.

Proceedings in both Houses on Friday began with paying homage to members of the Armed Forces killed during the Kargil War, ahead of the Kargil Vijay Diwas on July 26 (Sunday).

Soon after, the Opposition MPs resumed their protest

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>



Congress MPs Mallikarjun Kharge and Priyanka Gandhi, along with TMC MP Sagatika Ghose and others raise slogans seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi, Friday.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mJmZg1

against the NEET paper leak, resulting in both Houses getting adjourned until 12 noon.

When the Lok Sabha met again, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "If we don't have a discussion and make excuses, then it is not a good message. I request (Leader of Opposition) Rahul

he would allow him time to speak after papers are laid on the table. The Opposition members started raising "istifa do" slogans, and Pal adjourned the proceedings till Monday.

Speaking to reporters in the Parliament complex, Gandhi said, "Rijiju ji gave a statement that they want our MPs to hold a discussion. The normal protocol is that if someone names a person, he or she is allowed to respond. When I wanted to reply, the mic was taken away from me. I was not given an opportunity," he said. Gandhi reiterated the Opposition's stance that they will not have a discussion or conversation on NEET until Pradhan is sacked.

In the Rajya Sabha, proceedings were adjourned till 2 pm. When the business resumed, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai proposed to introduce "The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026".

The Bill seeks to make intentionally preventing the singing of the National Song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing an offence with a maximum punishment of five years, or fine, or both. It also seeks to accord the same statutory protection to the National Song as the National Anthem.

As the Opposition benches protested the Bill's introduction, Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha Harivansh allowed CPI(M) MP John Brittas and CPI MP Sandosh Kumar P to speak on the Bill. "The Constituent Assembly, after nearly three years of exhaustive deliberation, consciously refrained from placing the National Song and the National Anthem on the same constitutional footing. Had the framers of both intended to enjoy identical legal consequences, they would have expressed and so provided," Brittas said.

CJI reiterates: Cockroach remarks only for fake law degree holders, not all youth

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant on Friday reiterated that his remarks about cockroaches at a hearing in the Supreme Court in May this year was only in the context of those who had gained entry into the legal profession using fake degrees and not all youth for whom he had great respect.

The CJI told *The Indian Express* that the issue of fake law degree holders had been flagged by none other than the Bar Council of India in the past and it was only in this background that he made those comments. "It was about the lawyers who have entered profession through backdoor based on mostly fake degrees. Issue was about fake law degrees and how to clean up. It was in that context that I commented," he said.

The CJI said that when he travels, many youth come forward to meet him. "I am drawing my force from the youth of the country."

He said the Supreme Court's doors are always open to every citizen and "whatever in terms of constitutional principles or law of the land allows, will redress the grievance."

"If the country's youth have any grievance which they want to be redressed through the judicial forum, then the Su-



CJI Surya Kant

“If the country's youth have any grievance which they want to be redressed through the judicial forum, then the Supreme Court's doors are always open for them

SURYA KANT,
CHIEF JUSTICE OF INDIA

preme Court's doors are always open for them," he said.

The CJI's remarks on May 15 during a hearing likening unemployed youth in law to cockroaches had led to an uproar culminating in the creation of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), with many inter-

preting it as comments targeting the entire youth community and not just the legal profession.

A day later, the CJI stated that he had been "misquoted" by sections of the media and that his criticism was directed solely at those who had entered professions through fake or bogus degrees.

"I am pained to read how a section of the media has misquoted my oral observations made during the hearing of a frivolous case yesterday. What I had specifically criticised were those who have entered professions like the Bar (legal profession) with the aid of fake and bogus degrees. Similar persons have sneaked into the media, social media, and other noble professions as well, and hence, they are like parasites," the CJI had said in a statement.

"It is totally baseless to suggest that I criticised the youth of our nation. Not only am I proud of our present and future human resource, but every youth of India inspires me. It is not an exaggeration to say that Indian youth have great regard and respect for me, and I too see them as the pillars of a developed India," he had said.

Bittu resigns from Union Cabinet, will focus on poll-bound Punjab

Press Trust of India
Chandigarh, July 24

WITH PRESIDENT Droupadi Murmu accepting his resignation from the Union council of ministers, BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu on Friday said he will now shift his entire focus on poll-bound Punjab as his party is eyeing to form the government in the border state.

Bittu is likely to contest the 2027 Punjab assembly elections from Ludhiana. He had been holding the charge as Union Minister of State for Railways and Food Processing Industries.

A prominent Sikh face of the BJP, Bittu said he had tendered his resignation on June 21, when his Rajya Sabha term ended. In June, Bittu had expressed his desire to work for



Ravneet Singh Bittu's tenure in Rajya Sabha ended on June 21

Punjab in the Vidhan Sabha after spending nearly 17 years in Parliament. He had then said that the BJP made him the minister even though he had lost the 2024 parliamentary elections.

On the 2027 Assembly polls, Bittu expressed confidence that the BJP would form the govern-

ment in Punjab. "People of Punjab are fed up (with other parties). People are very much aware of development and progress taking place in other (BJP-ruled) states and they want prosperity in Punjab as well," Bittu said.

The grandson of former Punjab chief minister Beant Singh, who was assassinated in 1995, Bittu joined the BJP ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.

He remained Lok Sabha MP for three terms on Congress ticket. He was elected an MP for the first time from Anandpur Sahib in 2009. Later, he was elected from Ludhiana twice in 2014 and 2019.

After joining the BJP, he unsuccessfully contested from Ludhiana seat in 2024. He was defeated by Congress' Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

Mrityunjay Tiwari jumps ship from RJD to BJP

Yuvraj Singh
Patna, July 24

FORMER RJD spokesperson Mrityunjay Tiwari on Friday joined the BJP in the presence of the party's state unit president, Sanjay Saraogi. The move comes a week after Tiwari severed ties with the Opposition party in Bihar, bringing a formal end to his nearly 20-year association with the RJD.

Tiwari was inducted into the party during an event at the state BJP headquarters in Patna.

Addressing BJP workers after joining the party, Tiwari cited alignment with national goals as his main reason for switching sides. "I was inspired by the party's vision of Viksit Bharat... the BJP is working in the nation's interest. More people are joining the BJP be-

cause they identify with its ideology and vision."

On quitting the RJD, he said: "I no longer found myself aligned with the party's leadership despite having worked there for nearly two decades."

Tiwari's crossover follows his resignation from the RJD on July 16, when he publicly cited growing friction with party leadership and alleged that there was "no space for dedicated and loyal workers" in the RJD's organisational structure.

As the RJD's spokesperson for over a decade, Tiwari was often seen leading from the front in defending the party and pushing its viewpoints before the media. His exit deprives the Opposition party of a familiar, articulate defender.

Writer is an intern with The Indian Express



भारतीय कंटेनर निगम लिमिटेड
CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
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NOTICE OF RECORD DATE FOR INTERIM DIVIDEND FOR FY 2026-27

Notice is hereby given that 4th August, 2026 (Tuesday) has been fixed as the Record Date for the purpose of determining the entitlement of members to Interim Dividend @32% (₹1.60 per share on equity share of ₹5/- each), declared by the Board in its meeting held on 24.07.2026 for the financial year 2026-27. Further, Interim dividend will be paid:

(i) to those Members whose names will appear in the Register of Members of the Company, after giving effect to all valid Share Transfers in physical form lodged with the Company and its Registrar on or before 4th August, 2026; or

(ii) in respect of Shares held in electronic form, to those "deemed members" whose names appear on the Statements of beneficial ownership furnished by National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) and Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL), at the end of business hours on 4th August, 2026.

In order to avail the facility of payment of dividend through Electronic Clearing Service (ECS), members of the Company, holding their shares in Demat mode are requested to submit the duly filled in ECS mandate form to their Depository Participant and those holding physical shares to Company's Share Transfer Agent and Registrar: **M/s Beetal Financial & Computer Services (P) Ltd., BEETAL HOUSE, 3rd Floor, 99, Madangir, Behind Local Shopping Centre, Near Dada Harsukhdas Mandir, New Delhi - 110062.** ECS instructions once furnished by the member will supersede all his/ her previous bank mandates/details. ECS mandate form is available on Company's website: www.concorindia.co.in.

Shareholders holding shares in dematerialized mode are requested to update their records such as tax residential status, and permanent account number (PAN), mobile numbers and other details with the relevant depositories through their depository participants. Shareholders holding shares in physical mode are requested to furnish details to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, M/s Beetal Financial & Computer Services (P) Ltd at concor@beetalfinancial.com.

Shareholders are also requested to register/ update their E-mail ID with company at investorrelations@concorindia.com/ their Depository participants/ Company's Registrar & Share Transfer Agent at concor@beetalfinancial.com which will be used for sending official documents through e-mail in future.

Shareholders are requested to claim their unpaid/ unclaimed dividend, if any by writing to company at its Registered office or email or to its R&T. Dividends if remained unpaid or unclaimed for a period of seven years shall be transferred by the company to the Investor Education and Protection Fund. Further, all shares in respect of which dividend has not been paid or claimed for seven consecutive years or more shall be transferred by the company in the name of Investor Education and Protection Fund.

For Container Corporation of India Ltd.

sd/-
(Harish Chandra)

Place: New Delhi
Date : 24.07.2026

PED (Finance) & Company Secretary

Government of India
Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers Department of Chemicals and Petrochemicals
ENGAGEMENT OF TECHNICAL CONSULTANTS

The Department of Chemicals & Petrochemicals invites applications for engagement of three Technical Consultants i.e. two Mid-level and one Entry-level -on a contractual basis.

2. Detailed vacancy circular dated 01/07/2026 and 27/05/2026 are available on the website <https://chemicals.gov.in/recruitments>. Interested candidates may submit their applications in the prescribed format within 21 days from the date of publication of this advertisement in the Employment News to the following address:

**Deputy Secretary (Admin),
Department of Chemicals & Petrochemicals
Room No. 23051, 3rd Floor,
Kartavya Bhawan - 02, Dr. Rajendra Prasad Road,
New Delhi-110001
CBC-02101/11/0005/2627**



Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education (ICFRE)
(An Autonomous Body of Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Govt. of India)
P.O. New Forest, Dehradun - 248 006

Advt. No. 1-45/2009-ADG (EM)/Project Personal/ICFRE - Vol. III Dated: 23.07.2026

Walk-in-Interview

Walk in interview for temporary positions, purely on contractual basis under the following consultancy projects of EM Division will be held on **12.08.2026 in the committee room of EM Division, ICFRE H.Q. Building from 11.00 AM** onwards:

S. N.	Name of Projects	Name & No. of posts	Duration
1	Assessment of Environmental Damage resulting from Unauthorized Use/Diversion of Forest Land for Setting up Integrated Steel Plant in Bokaro District, Jharkhand', M/s, ESL Steel Ltd.	Project Associate - 01	08 Months
2	Post Impoundment Environmental Study of Vyasi Hydroelectric Project (120 MW) on Yamuna River in Uttarakhand	Project Associate - 01	01 Year

Willing candidates may see the details of Ad including requirement of qualification, work experience, terms of conditions of engagement at ICFRE website www.icfre.org - Recruitment (Home page).

**Assistant Director General (EM)
ICFRE, Dehradun**

PUBLIC NOTICE
M/S TATHASTU REALTY PRIVATE LIMITED
(CIN U70109HR2022PTC123262)
Registered Office: 10th Floor, Tower-B, Vatika Towers, Golf Course Road, Sec-54, Gurgaon, Haryana, India- 122011
E-mail:- cs@gangarealty.com, Phone No.: 0124-4544650

Whereas M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited is in the process of developing an Affordable Group Housing Colony namely "TATHASTU 35" situated in Village Mohammadpur Gujjar, Sector-35, Tehsil Sohna, District Gurugram over an area measuring 9.90625 Acres under Licence No. 131 dated 2023 granted by Director, Town and Country Planning, Haryana and having RERA Registration No. 108 of 2023 dated 04.12.2023.

And Whereas M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited (hereinafter referred "Company") has applied for change in Bank Account from ICICI Bank Limited to Indusind Bank Limited and accordingly Company has obtained Deficiency Letter for change of bank accounts from Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurgaon. Accordingly vide this public notice, the general public is hereby notified/ informed that the following changes in bank accounts.

Particulars	Previous Bank Accounts	New Bank Accounts
Bank Name	ICICI Bank Ltd	Indusind Bank Limited
IFSC Code	ICIC0007390	INDB00000005
Master Collection Account No. (100%)	739005000523	256000500161
RERA Account No. (70%)	739005000524	256000500162
Promoter Free Cash Flow Account No. (30%)	739005000520	256000500163

Date: 24.07.2026
Place: Gurugram

sd/-

M/s Tathastu Realty Private Limited



Dr Anoop Misra
Executive Chairman of Fortis C-Doc Hospital for Diabetes and Allied Sciences



Rinku Ghosh
Senior Associate Editor
The Indian Express

EXPRESS
explained.Live

LOSE FAT
NOT
HEALTH
The science behind weight loss



Scan to Register



Why is losing weight becoming harder despite eating less?

Why do people regain weight after dieting, and how can the 'yo-yo effect' be prevented?

Which diet actually works—intermittent fasting, keto, low-carb, Mediterranean, or calorie counting?

Do weight-loss medications and injections really work, and who should take them?

Can you lose weight without giving up your favourite foods?

How do hormones, sleep, stress, thyroid problems, PMOS and menopause affect weight loss?

29
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2026

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Public Enterprises Selection Board invites applications for the post of
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Last date of submission of application by applicants is by
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Last date of forwarding of applications by the Nodal Officers to
PESB is by 17:00 hours on 20th August, 2026.
For details login to website <https://pesb.gov.in>

epaper.indianexpress.com



Language No Bar

THE CONGRESS'S social media team, led by senior party leader Supriya Shrinete, had a tough task at hand on Friday — to translate Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi's newspaper article on the "education system's collapse" into different regional languages. The social media team didn't rely on Artificial Intelligence for the translations and asked its teams in different states to do the needful. Some senior leaders in the Delhi team also lost their cool when some of the state teams did not give a prompt response. The article by Sonia Gandhi was translated into 11 regional languages, including Telugu, Gujarati and Punjabi, and shared on social media handles in the states.

Rare Coffee Table Book

FORMER COMPTROLLER and Auditor General (CAG) of India Vinod Rai got nostalgic at a gathering on Thursday after being presented with a coffee table book chronicling his life and public service. Authored by B S Chauhan — a 1983-batch Indian Information Service officer who is serving as the media advisor to the current CAG, K Sanjay Murthy — the book is said to be the first coffee table book dedicated to a former CAG. It offers a glimpse into the life and career of Rai, a 1972-batch Kerala-cadre IAS officer who retired in 2013. Chauhan also presented a copy of the book to the current CAG.

No Network

SEVERAL REPORTERS who came to the National Media Centre in the Capital on Friday afternoon to attend the much-anticipated Cabinet briefing — in the wake of PM Narendra Modi's midnight message indicating crucial steps to prevent paper leaks — were disappointed to learn that mobile Internet services were down at the venue. Officials then managed a Wi-Fi connection to salvage the situation.

Delhi court denies bail to doctor accused in NEET paper leak case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 24

A DELHI court on Friday denied bail to paediatrician Manoj Shirure, one of the accused in the 2026 NEET-UG paper leak case, noting that the leak had caused "disrepute to the nation".

"It is widely known that the paper leak of NEET-UG 2026 has severely impacted millions of NEET aspirants in India and abroad. In case the allegations against the accused persons... as presented till date are taken on their face value, the same would prima facie show that in order to satisfy their greed and to gain illegal wealth, they not only sabotaged the entire process of the...exam which was supposed to be conducted fairly and flawlessly but by their aforesaid illegal acts, they have also brought disrepute to the nation," Special Judge Ajay Gupta of Rouse Avenue Court said in his order dated July 24.

The allegation against Shirure was that Siddhivinayak Hospital, which he ran in Latur, Maharashtra, was used to "facilitate access to a chemistry question paper in April 2026", ahead of the exams scheduled on May 3.

Will monitor NEET overhaul steps, take those extra miles: SC

Problems being monitored and supervised at highest level: SG

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

AMID THE ongoing protest in Delhi against paper leaks, the Supreme Court said Friday it would closely monitor the Centre's overhaul of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET), cautioning that a shift to computer-based testing alone would not eliminate the risk of paper leaks.

The Centre, meanwhile, assured the top court it was going "10 extra miles" to safeguard the NEET process.

A bench presided by Justice P S Narasimha, and also comprising Justice Alok Aradhe, was hearing pleas seeking reconstitution of the NTA following the alleged NEET-UG 2026 question paper leaks.

"We will monitor it, we will see. We will take those extra miles... We cannot let this go on... We will see that this is completely institutionalised and how it works, not just the commencement. We will follow it up throughout the year and see that complete and total institutionalisation takes place," Justice Narasimha said.

Referring to the recommendation of the high-powered committee constituted in 2024 under the former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan Committee to overhaul NTA to make the NEET foolproof, the top court then highlighted some points which it said the Centre's proposed affidavit should reflect.

"Last time, we mentioned the Radhakrishnan Committee's recommendations. It specifically refers to the governing board. Your affidavit should indicate exactly what has been done with respect to the board. And this would comprise transparency of the test, nominations and stakeholder equations," Justice Narasimha said.

"So far as the domain-specific requirement... You have

TOP COURT TO HEAR ON JULY 27 PLEAS AGAINST POLICE EXCESSES ON STUDENTS

The Supreme Court will hear on July 27 two petitions alleging police excesses against students protesting at Jantar Mantar and other places in the country since Monday against the alleged NEET question paper leak. CJI Surya Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, told Senior Advocates Gopal Sankaranarayanan and Shyam Divan, "Let it be listed, we will entertain," Sankaranarayanan told the bench, also comprising Justices Joydip Bagchi and V Mohana, that there are two petitions dealing with the violence that took place across the country. "There is urgency because this is happening on a daily basis," he said the "police are using excessive force against children." "It is just going on unabated. Some controls are necessary. The court stands between us and the police," Sankaranarayanan said he was waiting for the court's Registry to grant diary numbers before he could mention the same for an urgent hearing. "We didn't want to mention (the matter) until we got the diary numbers. We have diary numbers and properly constituted petitions. The states are parties," he submitted. ENS

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mljMzg1 tice Narasimha said.

At the outset, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta sought more time to file an affidavit in the matter, explaining what is being done to secure the process, and said he will present a "holistic view".

"Children's problems will have to be addressed without any reservations. I can assure you from my personal knowledge, it is being monitored, supervised, and everything is being done at the highest executive level," Mehta said.

This comes a day after PM Narendra Modi announced forming fast-track courts to ensure swift justice in paper leak cases.

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"So far as the domain-specific requirement... You have

indicated that IITs, UGC, and Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan have been considered, but then it doesn't indicate what progress has been made with respect to the domain experts," Justice Narasimha added.

Justice Narasimha said, "We are focusing on institutionalisation. Ad hocism has troubled us for years." He said the government should also address the aspects of printing and transportation of papers. "I am aware a similar issue arose two years back and we had explained, right from printing to when students get the paper, what the system is in place."

Justice Narasimha referred to the government's decision to deploy the IAF to transport question papers this time, saying, "that is only an ad hoc situation, not a permanent one."

Mehta said, "I can assure that with children, there cannot be any adversarial approach. The Radhakrishnan Committee (recommendations) is fully accepted. But we are going beyond that."

Justice Narasimha asked how data would be kept safe when NEET switches to digital mode. "That's very important because when you shift to this, leaks could occur, making data unsafe. And the entire thing breaks down," he said. Mehta said there has been no such instance as of now, but they will have to be careful.

Video of cop 'grabbing' woman misinterpreted: Mumbai Police

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 24

A DAY after a Mumbai Police constable was transferred over a viral video in which he allegedly threatened protesters with a false narcotics case, another video involving a police officer has sparked controversy, with Opposition leaders demanding action.

The latest video, widely circulated on social media, purportedly shows a plainclothes officer grabbing a woman protester as police personnel disperse a crowd.

Mumbai Police rejected allegations of misconduct, saying the video was being misinterpreted. DCP (Operations) Akbar Pathan said senior officers reviewed the footage.

"The video in reference is being irresponsibly misinterpreted. The officer was trying to hold on to a male protester and a woman stepped in while he was looking away," Pathan said.

Congress MP Varsha Gaikwad shared the video on X, tagging CM Devendra Fadnis, and asked why a male officer was physically handling a woman protester. NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar also demanded strict action. BJP spokesperson Navnath Ban accused Pawar of trying to malign Mumbai Police for political gain. Ban said the video showed officers rushing to catch a man in a blue shirt and argued there was no evidence the officer had deliberately misbehaved with the woman.

Suspended constable hands over his badge to Dipke, 'resigns'

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, July 24

SAYING HE was extending solidarity with the protesters, a police constable from Uttarakhand "resigned" from his post while on the stage at Jantar Mantar Friday. Uttarakhand Police, however, said later the constable had already been placed under suspension earlier.

The constable, Sher Singh, alleged that the question paper for a patwari post was available at grocery stores. He was referring to reports of exam leaks in Uttarakhand since 2021.

"This is Bhagat Singh's coun-

Not a single page related to protests filed on July 22: CJI

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant on Friday dismissed as "reckless reporting" that he had denied listing of a plea on July 22 against crackdown on protesters during "Chalo Sansad" march on July 20, and said that "not a single page has been filed" and "only a representation was received".

During the mentioning hours, CJI Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, said, "In the last two days, a completely false statement was made that a matter has been filed. And the media is absolutely free from all responsibility, falsely reporting that the Chief Justice refused to list the matter." The remarks came when Senior Advocate Shob Alam sought listing of an unrelated matter.

"Until 10 am, I tried to find out, no case had been filed... Not a single page has been filed in the Supreme Court. It was one representation... How can I treat the representation as a writ petition? And people start recklessly reporting this," the CJI said.

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"The government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down," said Jack Dorsey, platform's co-founder. Dorsey also shared a copy of the blocking order by Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the MHA, issued to GitHub on July 23. According to the order copy shared by Dorsey, I4C said the app could be used to evade lawful surveillance and coordinate unlawful assemblies during restrictions on Internet services.

The order involved Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, 2000, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT

Rules, 2021, and asked GitHub to disable access to three repositories linked to Bitchat within three hours. The URLs include the app's main source-code repository, its Android repository and a page used to distribute its Android installation file.

Bitchat is an open-source, decentralised messaging app that can allow users located near each other to communicate without mobile data, Wi-Fi, phone numbers or centralised servers. Its offline mode uses Bluetooth Low Energy to connect nearby phones, with each device capable of relaying messages to others and thereby extending the network's reach.

The order, shared by Dorsey, said the app's design "creates a substantial risk of misuse by anti-national elements, terrorist organisations, organised criminal groups, and cybercriminals seeking to evade lawful detection" despite "legally imposed restrictions". Queries sent to Home Ministry remained unanswered until publication.

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Rules, 2021, and asked GitHub to disable access to three repositories linked to Bitchat within three hours. The URLs include the app's main source-code repository, its Android repository and a page used to distribute its Android installation file.

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LoP Rahul Gandhi with Sahil Lochab in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

Pellet-hit student by his side, Rahul slams Pradhan, says PM must apologise

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 24

CONTINUING TO up the ante against the Centre and Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Friday addressed reporters along with a student protester who had suffered pellet gun injuries in police action amid the protest in the national capital against paper leaks on July 20.

Gandhi said Pradhan must be removed, action must be taken against the personnel who shot at protesters with pellet guns and lathicharged them, and PM Narendra Modi should apologise to students.

"My brother was struck by a pellet gun when he was peacefully protesting with a Tricolour," said Gandhi, pointing to 19-year-old Sahil Lochab while addressing reporters outside CPP chief Sonia Gandhi's 10, Janpath residence.

Gandhi lifted Sahil's T-shirt to show his injuries to the media and said the teenager also risked losing vision in an eye damaged by pellets. "This has happened to thousands of youth. They have been shot at with pellet guns and have been beaten up

Govt orders GitHub to block Bitchat app that works without Internet

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 24

AMID REPEATED mobile Internet shutdowns around Delhi's Jantar Mantar, the site of the ongoing students' protests, the government has directed GitHub to disable access to repositories hosting Bitchat, an offline messaging application developed by Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey.

"The government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down," said Jack Dorsey, platform's co-founder. Dorsey also shared a copy of the blocking order by Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the MHA, issued to GitHub on July 23. According to the order copy shared by Dorsey, I4C said the app could be used to evade lawful surveillance and coordinate unlawful assemblies during restrictions on Internet services.

The order involved Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, 2000, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT

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With bipartisan support, how House passed 2024 anti-paper leak Act

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 24

Barely two-and-a-half months before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the then Narendra Modi government brought the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Bill, 2024, in Parliament, which sought to prevent "unfair means" in order to "bring greater transparency, fairness and credibility to the public examinations system".

These exams include common entrance tests and government recruitment exams conducted by "public examination authorities" such as the UPSC and NTA, among others. The Bill was passed by both Houses in February 2024 during the Budget Session.

Amid its current standoff with students and protesters led by the CJP, the Modi govern-

ment is planning to amend the 2024 Bill to make it more stringent.

Piloting the Bill in Lok Sabha on February 6, 2024, Union Minister Jitendra Singh underlined that while the Bill seeks to punish officials or organisations that indulge in various exam malpractices, including leaks of question papers and tampering of answer sheets, students or candidates will not come under its purview.

While the Act stipulates a prison term of three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh for any person resorting to unfair means in exams, it provides for a jail term up to 10 years and a fine over Rs 1 crore, in cases of "organised" paper leaks.

The Bill had bipartisan support in both Houses.

Introducing the Bill in LS,

Singh flagged media reports about 18-year-old Niharika Solanki, a JEE aspirant from Kota, who had died by suicide two days before exam on 31 January 2024. The minister quoted from the girl's suicide note: "Mummy, papa, please forgive me. I cannot do it. I am the worst daughter."

Singh had said the government was taking steps to serve the youth just months after it had passed a constitutional amendment legislation, 2023, to provide for one-third reservation for women in LS and Assemblies.

"In all provisions made for the youth in the last 10 years, it has been seen that there is transparency and that the youth get opportunities in keeping with their talent (*pratibha*), ability (*yogyata*) and hard work (*parishram*)," Singh had said.

Commercial vessel attacked in Black Sea, Indian killed

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

AN INDIAN seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea on July 18, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday.

This came to light days after four Indians were among 10 killed in an attack on a commercial vessel off the coast of Ukraine on July 19.

“It has come to our attention that on July 18, the commercial vessel MV OMORFI was attacked while transiting the Black Sea, reportedly in Russian territorial waters. At the time of the incident, there were 10 crew members on board, including three Indian nationals,” the MEA said.

“As per available information, one Indian national tragically lost his life in the attack. We extend our deepest condolences to the bereaved family of the deceased. The other two Indian nationals on board are reported to be safe,” MEA said.

It said the Indian mission in Russia has reached out to the relevant authorities and is making efforts to extend all possible assistance to the affected family.

“India unequivocally condemns such attacks targeting commercial shipping and plac-

ing the lives of innocent civilian crew members at risk. It is a matter of serious concern that the freedom of navigation and international commerce is facing increasing threats,” the MEA said. “India calls upon all concerned parties to uphold international obligations to ensure the safety and security of maritime navigation and uninterrupted flow of global commerce.”

On Tuesday, New Delhi had summoned the Russian charge Charge d’affaires following the killing of the four Indians in the strike on the MV Golden Leo vessel on July 19.

In response to Moscow indicating that the ship in Black Sea was targeted for carrying military supplies for Ukraine, India on Friday said that the vessel was carrying “grain” as cargo.

During a weekly briefing, the Ministry of External Affairs’ official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, while responding to Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov’s comments, said: “As per information made available to us from the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, India, MV Golden Leo, the Guinea-Bissau-flagged commercial vessel involved in the tragic incident in the Odesa port, had loaded grain as cargo prior to departure on 19 July 2026...”

Boulders roll down on taxi in Lahaul-Spiti, infant among 13 killed

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, July 24

ALL 13 occupants of a taxi, including a six-month-old child, were killed as massive boulders suddenly fell from a hill and crushed the moving vehicle in Himachal Pradesh’s Lahaul and Spiti on Friday, police said. The overloaded taxi, a Tata Sumo, also caught fire in the incident that took place near Kuddu Nala on the Udaipur-Killad road, they said.

While Deputy Commissioner, Lahaul and Spiti, Kiran Badana confirmed that 13 people have died in the accident, local MLA Anuradha Rana said 10 victims deceased belonged to Pangni in Chamba district, while three, including a woman and her infant, were from Lahaul and Spiti.

According to the preliminary information, the passengers had remained stranded overnight at Tindi as the Udaipur-Killad road was closed for traffic the previous day. They set off for Pangni in the morning after the road reopened.

Apart from the infant, the victims include seven men and four women. They were identified as Bir Singh, Buthi Singh,



Wreckage of the vehicle in Lahaul-Spiti on Friday. PTI

Bir Singh, Kamla Kumari, Anil Kumar, Rekha, Saurabh Singh, Anjana, Soman Angmo, Aaru (the infant), Sanjay Kumar and Hans Raj, DC Badhana said.

MLA Rana said, “The weather was clear, but there were reports of shooting stones in the area. All the bodies were recovered from the mangled vehicle and taken to the Civil Hospital at Udaipur for post-mortem examination.”

Rana said there was no telecom signal at the accident spot and she used a satellite phone to reach out to SP (Lahaul-Spiti) Shivani Mehla for carrying out rescue and relief operations.

Personnel from the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) reached the spot as did police teams from Lahaul and Tindi, and officials from Udaipur administration and other emergency agencies.

Expressing grief, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu directed that all possible assistance be provided to the next of kin of the deceased.

In a separate incident, a woman died and seven people were injured in a landslide in Mandi.

The Shimla Met office, meanwhile, issued an orange warning of heavy to very heavy rain state from July 27 to 29.

Shah dials kin of policeman killed in Anantnag terror attack

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, July 24

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah Friday dialled the family of the policeman who was killed in Anantnag on July 22. Head Constable Ahsiq Hussain Qureshi, a resident of Budgam, who was posted with the Indian Reserve Police and attached with the Special Operations Group, was on Amarnath Yatra duty.

The J&K Police said that a militant fired at Qureshi from point blank range near Lalchowk in Anantnag.

BJP’s Sunil Sharma, Leader of the Opposition in the J&K Assembly, visited the family on Friday to offer condolences. During the visit, the LoP facilitated the call between Qureshi’s son Absar and the HM during which Shah offered his condolences to the family. Qureshi is survived by his wife and three children.

J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha also visited Beerwah to meet the family members of Qureshi. Sinha paid tribute to the policeman and conveyed his condolences to the bereaved family. He said the entire nation is proud of the braveheart “whose courage, sacrifice, and devotion to duty will remain etched in our collective memory.”

He assured the family that the administration stands firmly with them and will ensure their well-being and dignity. The LG also assured full support to the family until Qureshi’s son finishes his studies and becomes eligible for a compassionate government appointment.

Now Bengal: Led by BJP leader, prayers held outside 650-year-old mosque

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 24

A MANDIR-MASJID row is brewing now in West Bengal as a Hindu right-wing group, led by a BJP leader, conducts prayers near a 650-year-old mosque which it claims was once a temple, in Malda district. On the coming Monday, the ‘Adinath Puratan Shiv Mandir’ organisation plans to install a big Shiva Lingam outside the mosque.

Built in 1373 AD by Sikandar Shah, the Adina Masjid in Pandua, Malda, is considered by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to have been the biggest mosque in medieval times in the entire subcontinent. However, Hindu groups and the BJP have been claiming that it came up in the place of an ‘Adinath Temple’, dedicated to Lord Shiva.

Kajal Goswami, the chief patron of the Adinath Puratan Shiv Mandir and a convenor of the BJP’s ‘Good Governance Wing’ for North Bengal, says: “There are Hindu and Buddhist statues in the so-called mosque. The Adinath Temple was destroyed to build a mosque on it.”

The organisation claims many Hindu and Buddhist motifs are present in the mosque, apart from a Shiva Lingam, and says it will approach the Calcutta High Court soon seeking an ASI report on the issue.

“Our aim is to restore the temple and place the Shiva Lingam inside it,” Goswami says. A 3.6-ft-high Shiva Lingam, weigh-



The Adina Masjid in Malda was built in 1373 AD. SOURCE: ASI

ing 1.5 tonnes, is being brought from Tarakeshwar, 289 km away, for installation near the mosque.

“But we will follow the law,” Goswami stresses. “We do not want a law and order problem. We have already held a meeting with representatives of the ASI and police, and they told us to do puja outside the mosque area.”

Calling the mosque “a historic monument”, a senior ASI official confirmed to *The Indian Express* that their representatives had held a meeting with the organisers of the prayers. “Nothing will be allowed inside the monument. Police deployment has been increased. We are also increasing our staff strength.” No prayers are currently held inside the mosque.

Recently, the Malda district police issued an advisory saying it had heard about social media posts claiming that “certain individuals intend to visit Adina Monument and perform relig-

ious rituals, including puja and other ceremonies”. “The general public is hereby informed that Adina Monument is a Centrally Protected Monument of National Importance under the Archaeological Survey of India and is governed by the provisions of the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958 (AMASR Act). No religious rituals or any other unauthorized activities are permitted within the protected monument premises,” the statement added, warning strict legal action in case of any violation.

It was on December 5, 2025, that – months to go for the West Bengal Assembly elections – BJP Rajya Sabha MP and current Bengal president Samik Bhattacharya scaled the issue up, to Parliament.

In his statement in the House, he said: “The Adina Mosque... was constructed in 1373 AD by Sultan Sikandar

Shah of Bengal Sultanate. This mosque was built using material from pre-existing Hindu and Buddhist structures. Local traditions and historical accounts suggest that the site was originally home to Adinath Temple dedicated to Lord Shiva and Lord Vishnu. The presence of Hindu iconography within the mosque and architecture supports this assertion.”

Adding that “the Adinath Temple needs to be protected at any cost”, Bhattacharya said: “It is one of those thousands of temples which, following the invasion of West Bengal, were destroyed by the invading hordes... I hope that the Government of India, the Archaeological Survey of India, will look into the matter seriously.”

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, BJP Rajya Sabha MP and former West Bengal chief Rahul Sinha compared the dispute to the Ayodhya Babri Masjid row. “A lot of emotions and religious sentiments prevail in connection with the Adinath Temple. Like Ram Mandir and other temples, it was also destroyed and a mosque built on it... The religious sentiment surrounding the temple should not be ignored, and truth must prevail.”

CPI(M) state secretary and Politburo member Md Salim said it was a familiar playbook of the BJP. “The BJP or RSS, whenever they get a foothold, they start this. In the first stage, they bring in religious activities. Then they create conflict and division. The Adina Mosque is the latest example.”

Ken-Betwa stir claims its first win, activist suspends fast

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 24

EIGHTEEN DAYS after beginning an indefinite hunger strike against alleged irregularities in the rehabilitation of families affected by the Ken-Betwa Link Project in Madhya Pradesh, Jai Kisan Sangathan leader Amit Bhatnagar on Friday suspended his fast, saying the agitation had achieved its “first success” after the state agreed to conduct fresh village-level surveys to identify families left out of compensation and rehabilitation.

Bhatnagar, who has been leading the Ken-Betwa Chita Andolan, said he was ending only the indefinite fast and not the movement itself.

“After achieving the first success of this 18-day indefinite fast, I am suspending my hunger strike today. But this struggle has not ended. From today, I am taking a pledge of ‘Nyay Satyagraha’. Until the last eligible person receives justice under the project, I will not rest. I will go from village to village, lead this movement, cooperate with every positive step taken by the administration and monitor every promise. If required, the next phase of the agitation will also begin,” he said.

The rehabilitation process concerns villages falling within the Daudhan Dam submergence zone. Bhatnagar had alleged that hundreds of eligible families were excluded from rehabilitation lists, that compensation assessments were flawed, and that Gram Sabha proceedings contained irregularities.

According to Bhatnagar, district authorities have agreed to form joint teams comprising officials and representatives of the Jai Kisan Sangathan to conduct fresh village-by-village surveys in Chhatarpur district and include every eligible family that had been left out.

• BRIEFLY



Devotees during the Bahuda Yatra in Puri on Friday. ANI

ODISHA

Devotee dies of ‘suffocation’ in Puri amid massive procession rush

A DEVOTEE died of suffocation amid a big rush of people who attended the Bahuda Yatra, or the return chariot procession, of Lord Jagannath in Puri on Friday, officials said. According to health department officials, the 57-year-old man from Cuttack collapsed in the crowd while pulling the chariot. He was immediately rushed to the nearby health centre and then to the Puri district headquarters hospital, where doctors declared him dead. Officials said that as per a preliminary report, the deceased had high blood pressure. More than 100 people suffered health issues amid the big rush and humid conditions during the Bahuda Yatra on Friday. “Most of the patients were discharged from hospital after preliminary treatment,” an official said. ENS

Boy falls off auto, dies after being run over by lorry

A SEVEN-YEAR-OLD boy died after falling from an autorickshaw while returning from school and being run over by a lorry in Kerala’s Kozhikode district on Friday, police said. The deceased was identified as Amal, a Class 2 student. According to police, the incident occurred around 4 pm when Amal was returning home in an autorickshaw. When the vehicle reached Pulparamba, its door accidentally opened and the child fell onto the road, police said. A lorry travelling behind the autorickshaw ran over the boy, killing him on the spot, they said. PTI

2 workers killed in factory blast in Saharanpur

TWO MIGRANT workers were killed while two others went missing after an explosion took place at a fireworks factory in Saharanpur district in UP on Friday. Twenty three labourers from Madhya Pradesh were employed at the factory in Gangoh area, police said. The deceased were identified as Deepraj Devde, 23, and Sandeep, 25. Their bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination. The factory premises have been sealed. With no trace of the two missing workers, police suspect they may have fled the scene out of fear following the blast. ENS

4 killed after car falls into drain as Gujarat reels under monsoon fury

Aditi Raja & Ritu Sharma
Vadodara, Ahmedabad, July 24

FOUR MEN were killed and two others were rescued after their car skidded off a rain-soaked highway and plunged into a drain in Gujarat’s Kheda district late Thursday night, as incessant monsoon showers continued to wreak havoc across the state.

The victims were residents of Ahmedabad. Preliminary investigations suggest the driver lost control of the vehicle while negotiating a sharp bend amid heavy rain. The car overturned and was swept into a fast-flowing drain, trapping those inside.

According to officials, two occupants seated in the front managed to survive and were rescued after an extensive operation, while the four passengers in the rear seats drowned.

The victims were identified as Raj Rathod, 26, Mustakim Rajput, 19, Mayur Panchal, 34, and Virendrasinh Shekhawat, 26.



Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel interacts with people in Ahmedabad on Friday. EXPRESS

Meanwhile, Ahmedabad was inundated by 295 mm of rain in the 24 hours ending 6 am Friday, marking the city’s fourth-highest single-day rainfall ever, according to IMD records. The weather bureau said

Ahmedabad received 294.6 mm of rain between 6 am Thursday and 6 am Friday. This is the highest rain seen in the city in a single day since 2000.

The deluge left several parts of the city under water, with residential societies, roads, and underpasses remaining submerged early Friday morning. Several cars and two-wheelers were spotted abandoned on roads.

The affected areas, some of which Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel visited on Friday, included the Sentossa Park on Ambli Road, Iscon Greens and Hariom Villa areas — all of these being luxurious apartment and bungalow schemes in the Bopal area.

Residents of Sabarmati, Chharanagar, and Rabarivas were stranded on their rooftops after water entered their homes. The Ahmedabad Fire and Emergency Services rescued nearly a dozen people.

“People had climbed onto the rooftops to save themselves. We rescued them,” a civic body official said.

• ONE OF THE CONVICTS, A JUVENILE AT THE TIME OF THE 1999 ATTACK, HAS EMBRACED CHRISTIANITY, SAYS ‘IT BROUGHT ME INNER PEACE’

Village where Staines was killed lives with regret, fears Dara Singh’s return

Sujit Bisoyi
Manoharpur (Keonjhar), July 24

MANOHARPUR LIVES with regret — regret of the fire that killed Australian Christian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor sons 27 years ago in this Santhal village of Odisha. The possibility now that the main accused, Ravindra Pal alias Dara Singh, a former Bajrang Dal member who is serving a life term, may get premature release has brought the memories back.

Along with apprehension of what it might mean for the village that, on the face of it, is a long way from that night of January 22-23, 1999 — dotted by pucca houses and roads; marked by a police station that came up after the Staines kill-

ings, and has not seen any communal violence since; and home now to many more tribals who have embraced Christianity, among them a juvenile who was convicted in the murders.

Laxmi Hansdah, in her 60s, says: “That night will stay with me until I die. Why are you asking about it now?”

Dara, lodged in Keonjhar District Jail, moved the Supreme Court in 2024 seeking remission, appealing that he had spent 24 years in prison and that he repented acting as he did, in “a fit of youthful rage”. The SC has directed the Odisha government to take a call on the matter within a month.

Dara, who was 37 when arrested, belongs to UP and it is not clear where he will choose to settle down if released.

Another accused in the case who was also serving life, Mahendra Hembram, came out on parole last year.

A villager, who does not want to be named, says he was a child in 1999 but remembers what happened enough to dread a repeat. “We are living in harmony... Whether Dara is released or not is up to the government and court, but it should not trigger problems in the village.”

Ojen Hansdah, who was convicted for the Staines killing and spent six years in jail before being acquitted in 2005, is also repentant, though he claims he was framed. Partially paralysed, Hansdah says: “I don’t know what exactly happened. It shouldn’t have happened...”

Hansdah’s nephew was the only juvenile convict in the case

• In Odisha’s Keonjhar



and spent nine years in a juvenile home before being freed in 2008. Now 38 and a father of two, he talks of “regret” too, while asserting that he was an unwitting participant in the attack. “A mob came and started attacking the vehicles.”



At Manoharpur village, where Graham Staines and his two minor sons were killed in 1999

Earning a living from a small patch of farm, he converted to Christianity around two years ago. “It brought me inner peace,” says the 38-year-old, adding: “Nobody influenced or pressured me. It was my own decision, stemming from grief

and introspection...”

Asked about allegations of forcible conversion, including by Staines, Chetan Murmu, the pastor at a newly built church-cum-prayer house in the village who knew the missionary well, suggests the numbers say it all. Only seven of the over 250 households in the village were Christian when Staines and his sons were killed. “Now 41 families follow Christianity.”

Talking about how Staines, who ran a centre for leprosy afflicted, helped his daughter, Murmu, 60, says releasing Dara would set a wrong precedent. “Staines was a victim of hate crime and his killers should not be allowed to walk free... And why did they kill his two innocent children?”

While he was in the Opposition, Chief Minister Mohan

Charan Majhi, who represents the Keonjhar Assembly constituency, had supported the demand for Dara’s release.

Keonjhar BJP MP Aananta Nayak also supports it, saying Dara has already received his punishment.

Hembram, who was given life for Staines’s killing and was released in April last year on grounds of “good behaviour”, says he himself has “no regrets”. “Staines was a missionary, who was invading our culture and forcing people to convert. The attack happened in a fit of rage by an angry mob.”

Then just 21 and a final-year student doing his graduation, Hembram says he once dreamed of becoming an official “to serve the community”. “It’s all over now,” he says, adding that no one in the village

wants to associate with him since his release. He lives at his late elder brother’s home and gets by on the Rs 10,000-Rs 15,000 monthly given by the ‘Dara Sena’, a little-known self-confessed fighter for Hinduism and for Dara Singh.

Hembram, 48, says he too is fighting for the release of Dara, “my elder brother”, and visits him regularly in jail. Staines arrived in Mayurbhanj in 1965. In 1999, he drove down with sons, 10 and 6, for the annual jungle camp in Manoharpur. On January 22, Staines and his sons went to sleep in their station wagon. Around midnight, the camp was attacked.

Hembram says he has one regret. “We were not aware his (Staines’s) kids were inside the station wagon.”

epaper.indianexpress.com



100 DAYS of SEVA SANKALP SAMARPAN

TRANSFORMING EDUCATION FOR A FUTURE-READY BIHAR

- 211 new degree colleges inaugurated, ensuring higher education reaches every block of Bihar and expanding access to quality education statewide.
- Announcement of an Artificial Intelligence & Computer Science University (Bhagalpur), an Architecture & Civil Engineering University (Muzaffarpur), and approval for 4 new private universities to strengthen higher education and innovation.
- Under Saat Nischay-3 (2025-30), Saraswati Vidya Niketan model schools to be established across all
- 534 blocks, with 155 government and aided schools upgraded in line with NEP 2020.
- Model schools will offer smart classrooms, science & ICT labs, libraries, digital learning, weekly assessments, remedial classes, and NEET/JEE coaching, bringing quality education closer to students.
- Focus on academic excellence, digital integration, skill development, and equitable access, creating a modern, inclusive, and future-ready education ecosystem for Bihar.



BUILDING TOMORROW'S BIHAR

FASTER GROWTH, BETTER GOVERNANCE, BRIGHTER FUTURE

DRIVING INDUSTRIAL GROWTH & BUILDING AN AI-ENABLED BIHAR

- The government is creating an investment-friendly ecosystem by accelerating industrial approvals, expanding industrial land availability, strengthening MSMEs, and promoting employment-intensive sectors.
- Priority sectors include Manufacturing, Food Processing, Textiles & Leather, Electronics, Renewable Energy, and Biofuel industries to drive industrialisation and job creation.
- A new Unified Industrial Policy is being developed to integrate multiple



- sectoral policies into a single, simplified investment framework for investors.
- Within three months, the government announced 11 Mega Industrial Parks and a 50,000-acre industrial land bank to meet future investment and industrial infrastructure requirements.
- Alongside industrial expansion, Bihar is pursuing an AI-driven IT agenda focused on AI adoption, digital governance, IT investment promotion, technology skill development, and positioning Bihar as an emerging AI-enabled technology hub.

SAHAYOG SHIVIR TRANSPARENT & CITIZEN-CENTRIC GOVERNANCE

- State-Level Sahayog Shivir launched to ensure transparent, impartial, and time-bound grievance redressal, with citizen satisfaction as the key measure of success.
- Application Receipt Centre and Sahayog Path inaugurated to strengthen public access to grievance redressal services.
- During the inaugural camp, 129 applications were received, with 100 grievances resolved on the spot, demonstrating responsive governance.
- Officials directed to ensure quality disposal of complaints within 30 days, with strict action against delays or negligence.



- SDOs, OCLRs, District Magistrates, Divisional Commissioners, and departmental secretaries tasked with regular monitoring to strengthen administrative accountability.
- Departments instructed to expedite pension approvals, allow applicants to submit missing documents, accelerate post-monsoon road works, and ensure citizens are treated with dignity and respect.
- With nearly 90% of grievances already resolved under the Sahayog initiative, Bihar is advancing transparent governance, stronger accountability, and efficient delivery of public services.

BIHAR'S HELI-TOURISM INITIATIVE GIVES NEW WINGS TO TRAVEL AND ECONOMIC GROWTH



- Rs.15,422 per ticket; 10-minute Patna joyrides available for Rs. 2,100.
- Introduction of 20-seater aircraft services to Valmikinagar Tiger Reserve and helicopter connectivity to Rajgir and Kaimur to strengthen eco-tourism, heritage, and spiritual tourism.
- Government promoting homestays, local handicrafts, folk culture, regional cuisine, rural tourism, tourism circuits, hotels, and PPP-based infrastructure to create livelihoods and attract private investment.
- By combining modern air connectivity with Bihar's rich Buddhist, Jain, wildlife, and cultural heritage, the initiative aims to drive sustainable tourism and inclusive economic growth.



- Bihar Heli-Tourism & Air Tourism Service Scheme 2026 launched to improve connectivity, boost tourism, generate employment, and position Bihar as a global tourism destination.
- From 18 July 2026, subsidised helicopter services connect Patna, Rajgir, Valmikinagar, and Kaimur every weekend, with government support of up to



The Samrat Government has established four degree colleges in my region—Laxmi pur, Khairi, Aijani, and Jamu. Opening degree colleges across 211 blocks is transformative, especially for women and underprivileged students. Smart online classes are a modern initiative benefiting future generations."

-ARYAN



Under the Samrat Choudhary-led Bihar Government, law and order has improved significantly. The healthcare system is witnessing steady progress, reducing the need for patients to travel outside their districts for referrals. The government is also modernising education by developing an advanced and future-ready learning model.

-PUNIL KUMAR



Under the Samrat Choudhary Government, investor-friendly industrial policies are being introduced. Free medicines are strengthening healthcare, pending projects are being completed, roads are being widened, and development is visible across sectors. The AI Summit at Usha Auditorium showcased Bihar's growing focus on technology and innovation.

-SARITA SINGH



Samrat Choudhary is a dynamic Chief Minister. Under his leadership, healthcare services have expanded, law and order has improved, and industrial reforms, such as the Single Window System have replaced cumbersome licensing, accelerating investments and giving fresh momentum to Bihar's economic development.

-NEELAM SHAHI

BIHAR ACCELERATES DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION WITH LANDMARK AI PARTNERSHIPS



Bihar has taken a major step towards becoming an AI-powered state by signing landmark MoUs with indigenous AI firms Sarvam AI and BharatGPT. Signed in the presence of Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, the partnerships aim to build a

citizen-centric AI ecosystem that enhances governance, strengthens digital infrastructure, and improves public service delivery. The initiative will enable government departments to use India-developed AI models,

making services faster, more transparent, efficient, and accessible. It will also promote AI research in Indian languages and regional dialects to address local needs. A strong focus has been placed on AI skill development, with training programmes for government employees and youth to build future-ready talent. The collaborations will further support AI startups through mentoring and institutional partnerships, positioning Bihar as a leader in innovation, digital inclusion, and technology-driven governance while setting a benchmark for other states.

URBAN DEVELOPMENT

- 11 new satellite townships planned across Patna, Sonapur, Gaya, Darbhanga, Saharsa, Purnia, Munger, Muzaffarpur, Chhapra, Bhagalpur & Sitamarhi, featuring modern roads, parks, affordable housing, commercial & institutional zones, and EWS infrastructure to drive planned urbanization.
- Rs. 4,750 crore World Bank-backed urban infrastructure initiative approved to strengthen drinking water supply, underground sewerage, solid waste management, urban beautification, and digital municipal governance across Bihar.
- Focus on scientific land-use planning and transit-oriented development to support sustainable urban expansion and improve civic services.
- Patna Metro construction has been accelerated, with the initial metro network already expanded, integrating housing, transport, and public utilities while reducing traffic congestion and improving urban mobility.
- Plans to extend Metro connectivity to Gaya, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, and Bhagalpur, supporting the next phase of Bihar's rapidly growing urban centers.



BIHAR REVIVES SUGAR SECTOR, BOOSTING FARMERS' INCOME AND EMPLOYMENT



- Pending sugarcane dues cleared to revive the Sasamusa Sugar Mill (Gopalganj), benefiting thousands of farmers and creating new livelihood opportunities.
- 266 acres of the closed Motpur Sugar Mill (Muzaffarpur) reclaimed for a modern sugar mill, sugarcane research centre, and other industrial projects.
- State-wide programmes for seed development, mechanisation, and sugarcane nurseries to provide disease-free high-yielding seeds, modern farm equipment, free sugarcane seeds, technical support, and improved cultivation practices.
- MoUs signed with the Sugarcane Breeding Institute, Varanasi; Sugar Institute, and IIT Patna to promote advanced sugarcane varieties, modern technologies, and AI-based crop management, strengthening Bihar's long-term sugar economy.

Bihar Sugar Industry Investment Promotion Policy-2026 approved to attract investment in integrated sugar complexes comprising sugar mills, distilleries, co-generation power plants, and Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG) units, boosting industrial growth and employment.



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I was asked to sing with an AI band. Here’s why I said no



SONA MOHAPATRA

LAST EVENING, I found myself facing a decision I had not anticipated. I had been approached to sing an Odia bhajan — ‘Aahe Nila Shaila’ — for a band called Trilok. I have always believed that artistes who have acquired visibility, like me, should occasionally lend that visibility to younger musicians. An Odia bhajan, new talent, a cultural collaboration in the month of the Rath Yatra, it seemed like something I would naturally want to support.

Then I did a little research. I discovered that Trilok was not a band in the sense in which most of us understand the word. Its members were virtual identities. It now has some men with painted faces to play live stages. The project had been developed as an AI-led “spiritual rock band” by a talent-management and media company, not by four musicians who had met, rehearsed, disagreed, failed and finally found a sound together.

I would have appreciated being told this at the very beginning. The fact that this was an AI-generated band with fictional identities was not a minor production detail. It was central to the nature of the invitation and materially changed my decision about whether I wished to associate my voice with it. I gave my answer the same night. It did not come easily, because I am not opposed to technology. In fact, I had to examine my own recent choices before arriving at it.

Every generation of musicians has feared some new machine. When synthesisers entered studios, many instrumentalists believed their livelihoods would disappear. The anxiety was understandable: Why hire an orchestra if a keyboard could imitate one? Why call a drummer when a machine could keep perfect time?

But the synthesiser did not bring music to an end. It became another instrument. Drum machines did not eliminate rhythm; they altered its vocabulary. Sampling, digital recording, Auto-Tune and home-produc-

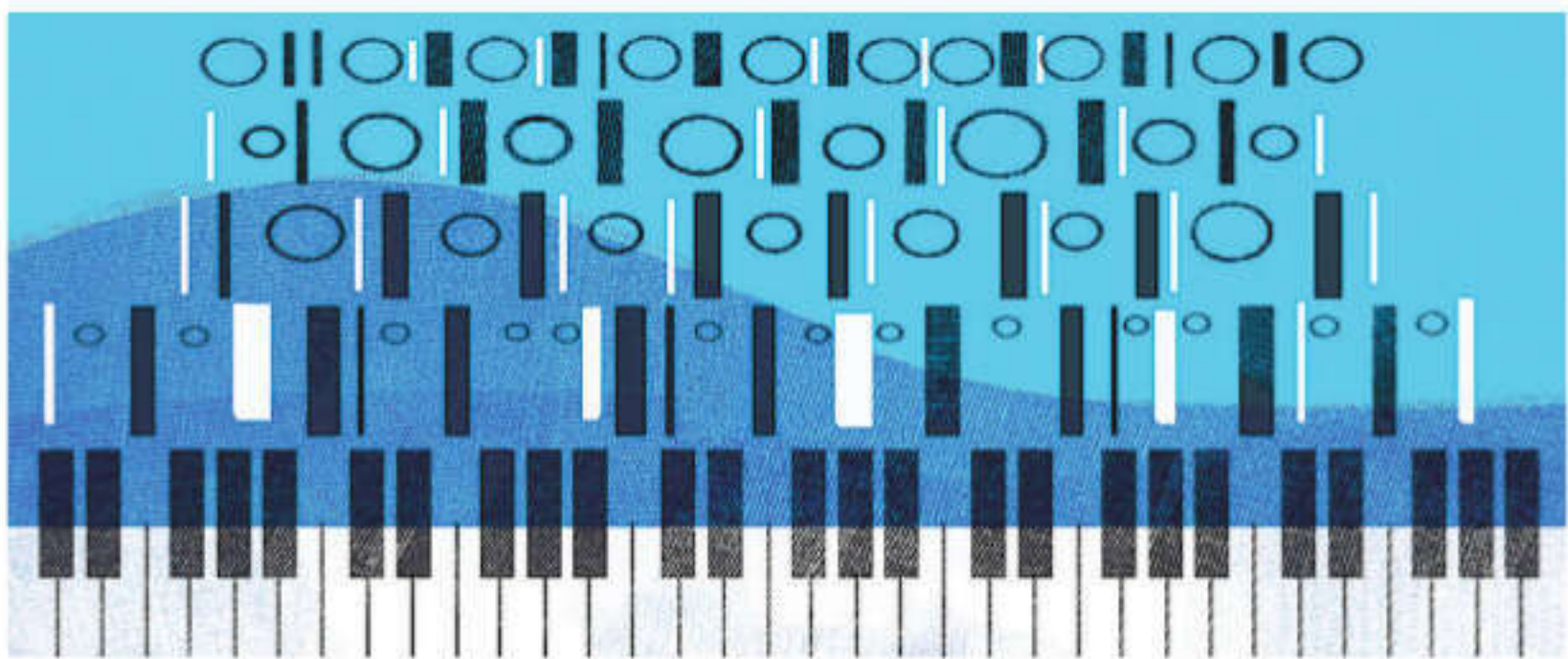


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

tion software all provoked similar alarm. Each was eventually absorbed into music. So it would be simplistic to declare that any use of AI is automatically an attack on art.

I recently released ‘Ghane Bhadra’, an original song whose video combines a live green-screen shoot of me performing with AI-assisted imagery. I am bodily present in the video. I sang the song. Human musicians played on it. AI helped us enlarge the visual canvas. It did not invent the artiste, replace the performance or conceal the people who made the music. That distinction matters to me.

Independent musicians in India work within an increasingly punishing economy. We write and produce original songs, pay for recordings, musicians, mixing, mastering, styling, shoots, editing, publicity and distribution without the machinery of a major film studio or record label. We then place that work on social-media platforms that depend on our content to hold audiences but do not pay most of us meaningfully for it. A new technology that allows us to tell a more ambitious visual story without waiting for a label’s permission or budget can feel liberating.

This is why I had to ask myself an uncomfortable question: Was I being inconsistent? How could I use AI in my own video and then refuse to sing for an AI band?

The answer became clearer when I stopped treating all uses of AI as though they were the same.

There is a meaningful difference between an artiste using a ma-

chine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artistes. One begins with human authorship and uses technology to extend its reach. The other can create an entire synthetic identity around which a catalogue and business may be built. One helps a financially constrained artiste complete a labour of love. The other can produce material at a velocity no human musician can possibly match. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible.

When I examined the Trilok project, what troubled me was not simply that the members were digital avatars. It was the larger proposition. Devotional music is among the most enduring and commercially powerful musical traditions in India. The songs come with faith, familiarity and an audience already attached to them. A synthetic act built around beloved bhajans can rapidly create a catalogue without undergoing the slow, uncertain process through which musicians develop a voice.

Except for the guest collaborator, a known name used presumably to expand reach and gain credibility, all Trilok uploads just credit “Trilok” as the performer. That makes the question of authorship even more important. The point is not that no human work exists behind an AI output. Of course it does. But if human beings perform the labour while fictional identities receive the fame, where will value eventually accumulate? And what happens when a rec-

There is a meaningful difference between an artiste using a machine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artistes. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible



MANOJ KUMAR JHA

YOUTH MOVEMENTS across the world are concerned with matters well beyond their immediate aims. The immediate concern of the young people protesting in Delhi is fair examinations. They have shown ample understanding that irregularities deepen inequalities of class and identities. The protest expresses a sense of betrayal among students, aspirants, and parents. The moral language of protesting youth has helped add urgency to wider grievances about the quality and experience of democracy itself.

Movements do not appear in a political vacuum but are a product of the political environment in which collective action develops. Whether some people like it or not, opposition parties are an important part of this process. Where a regime restricts protest or raises the costs of dissent, opposition parties can play an important role in expanding the space available to a movement.

Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Mallikarjun Kharge, Akhilesh Yadav and other parliamentarians pressed for both a parliamentary debate and ministerial accountability. They carried the students’ demands from Jantar Mantar to the vicinity of the PM’s residence, and were detained. Opposition MPs, CMs and ex-CMs met with protesters and condemned the police action. Opposition representatives also provided food and other practical sup-

A march towards the PM’s residence expresses the shared conviction that responsibility for institutional breakdown ultimately resides with the highest executive office



RAJAN KUMAR

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump is trapped in a strategic deadlock with Iran with no clear options. His strategy is unlikely to deliver a decisive military victory or a negotiated peace. And political and strategic constraints will not allow the US to withdraw either. Therefore, the US is likely to remain engaged in a prolonged low-intensity confrontation.

Negotiations remain the most viable option, but Trump’s negotiating strategy suffers from inconsistency, inexperience and ineptitude. That bombing and negotiations can run in parallel is an inherently flawed and futile logic. In his negotiating team, there are three states and two individuals: Oman,

Opposition amplifies, not captures, citizens’ voice

port, and offered legal assistance.

These actions are significant because repression isolates protesters by raising the personal costs of participation. The physical presence of recognised political leaders makes violence more visible, gives detained participants access to institutional assistance and ensures that demands enter legislative debate. The youth have not rejected party politics; they want parties to perform their representative function. The intervention of opposition CMs and regional leaders also enlarges the meaning of the mobilisation.

Against this, the BJP’s response has combined coercion with politically hollow and morally reprehensible rhetoric. The use of barricades, prohibitory orders, detention, tear gas, pellet guns and baton charges treated a crisis of public confidence as a problem of crowd control. The subsequent attempt by Dharmendra Pradhan to portray Rahul Gandhi as “exploiting” students or staging a political spectacle evaded the elementary democratic point that opposition parties are expected to politicise failures of government and demand accountability. By attacking the legitimacy of Opposition involvement, the ruling party seeks to leave citizens facing the state as isolated individuals. The Opposition’s task is to protect the movement’s autonomy while giving its demands institutional en-

ognised human singer is brought in?

My voice could give such a project something an avatar cannot manufacture: History, credibility, cultural location and emotional trust. My participation could tell listeners that this synthetic band had been accepted by a working artiste. Even unintentionally, I might help normalise a model that could ultimately reduce the space available to the world I come from. That was the ethical and moral line. Would I cross it?

There is another unresolved question. Generative music systems learn from large bodies of existing material. Around the world, creators are asking whether copyrighted work has been used for training with consent, transparency or compensation. The legal position is still contested. Technology has always learned from human knowledge. Artistes, too, learn from other artistes. But artistes do not ingest a million recordings at machine scale and then produce a competing catalogue within days. Scale changes the ethical character of the act.

I do not believe the answer is panic, prohibition or romantic speeches about returning to some pure pre-technological past. But artistes need to ask harder questions before lending their names and voices to synthetic acts. Who owns the resulting work? Who is credited? Was the training material licensed? Can a voice be cloned later? Is the human guest artiste helping build their own replacement? Is technology reducing the cost of expression or reducing the need to compensate creators? Is the audience being told clearly what it is hearing? And the final question: Where is the human being in this, and are we being invited to see them?

After thinking through, I knew I could not participate.

My use of AI in ‘Ghane Bhadra’ may still be questioned. That is fair. Artistes should not demand exemption from scrutiny simply because our intentions are good. I am also learning where my boundaries lie. But this experience clarified one of them. I will use technology to help human expressions travel further. I cannot knowingly lend my voice to make the human artiste disappear.

That is not fear of the future. It is a choice about the kind of future I am willing to help create.

The writer is a singer, producer and live performer

Young have spoken. They must now engage with government



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

IN NON-DEMOCRATIC systems, people resort to clandestine protests in the form of sabotage or violence to express their dissent. But dissent in a democracy must be disciplined. Because, unlike other systems, democracy recognises dissent as a constitutional right. Article 19 (1) (a) of the Indian Constitution guarantees freedom of speech and expression, which also includes the right to peacefully disagree and critique the government. It is this fundamental right that the agitating students in Delhi are entitled to enjoy. However, they must also keep in mind that this right comes with reasonable restrictions in the interest of the sovereignty and integrity of India, public order, decency and morality, etc. They are expected to uphold the discipline of democratic dissent.

The core issue raised by the agitating students concerns the conduct of examinations by the National Testing Agency (NTA). The NEET-UG paper leak that led to the cancellation of the exam a couple of months ago, causing enormous agony to a large number of students, was a genuine issue. There were widespread protests over the leak, and the government promptly acted and handed over the case to the CBI. Thirteen accused have been arrested and legal proceedings are ongoing against them. Subsequently, the exam was reconducted without any glitch, and over 20 lakh candidates participated. The results were declared on schedule, with over 11 lakh students qualifying. Ideally, the matter should have ended with that. But it didn’t. It is understandable if the agitators demanded reform and overhaul in the conduct of the competitive examinations. But their demand is limited to the removal of the education minister. Accountability is an important argument, but it should be about reforming the system and punishing those involved in malpractices. Both have been effectively addressed by the government.

Over the course of a month of the agitation, the assembly at the designated protest site near Jantar Mantar has acquired critical mass and momentum with the joining of several other sections of people. When a movement acquires that momentum,



vested interests, professional “*andolan jeevis*” and political parties also jump in. We are witnessing that now. Several objectionable slogans began to be raised at the venue. Violence and attacks on security personnel, too, were reported. The plunge taken by the opposition parties, led by Congress, cannot perse be objected to, but their refusal to use the constitutional platform of Parliament to discuss the matter points to an anarchist streak. This was evident when a group of MPs led by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi indulged in a sudden sit-in protest outside the Prime Minister’s residence, knowing well that it was against the rules and public order. On the one hand, Rahul Gandhi demanded accountability for paper leaks from the government, but on the other, he himself publicly refused to be accountable to the law, claiming it to be his “prerogative”. The government expressed its willingness to debate the issue in Parliament. But the Opposition is running away from it because it knows the consequences of such a debate. Paper leaks are not happening for the first time in the country. Not a single year passed during the UPA regime without accusations of that nature confronting the government. Yet, not a single minister ever resigned, nor was anyone held accountable and punished. This exposes the Opposition’s duplicity and their reticence to debate the matter in Parliament.

The government is sympathetic to the agitating students’ legitimate concerns. The Modi government enacted the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act 2024, the first ever law to tackle paper leaks and other unfair means, prescribing strict punishments including fines up to Rs 1 crore. Respecting the sentiments of the students, the Prime Minister has announced fast-track courts and stringent punishments to tackle these cases.

The government is also sincere in engaging with the leaders of the agitation to address their concerns. Two central ministers were deployed to speak with them. The ball clearly is in the court of those young leaders. It is good that Sonam Wangchuk, the social activist supporting the agitation, decided to end his fast. He understood that with the entry of various interests into the movement, there is the danger of it losing its way. Wangchuk and the agitating students succeeded in making their views heard across the country. It is time now to work towards a resolution through active engagement with the government. The movement for a genuine cause should not be allowed to turn into the “grammar of anarchy”, to quote B R Ambedkar, when a sincere government and secure constitutional methods are available.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

No victory, no deal, no exit for Trump in Iran

Qatar and Pakistan; and Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff. They were chosen for their loyalty to Trump rather than for real experience in strategic affairs.

A negotiation requires trust-building and neutrality. However, in the ongoing negotiations, negotiators are running with the hare and hunting with the hounds. Oman and Qatar are US allies, while Pakistan carries little political weight. They are not neutral, and their legitimacy is highly suspect. On the other side, Witkoff and Kushner are unable to restrain Trump from making provocative statements. Thus, the ongoing negotiations have achieved nothing substantial, besides an episodic ceasefire.

If Trump’s negotiating strategies are flawed, his war strategy is no better. A victory requires full political and military commitment, entailing high economic cost. Trump

lacks the political or economic capital to risk a full escalation. His ratings are declining, his loyalists are jumping ship, and his party fears losses in the November midterm elections, in which 435 seats in the House of Representatives, 35 seats in the Senate, and 36 state governor seats are at stake. The Democrats have a modest edge in the election for the House of Representatives.

Further, the US’s ability to project

Trump wanted regime change in Iran, but he cannot even keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He wanted a decimation of the Iranian military, but is incapable of protecting US allies

power beyond the region faces serious constraints. The cases of Afghanistan, Iraq and Syria clearly illustrate this limitation. But Trump seems to have little regard for strategic constraints.

Essentially, Trump has drawn the US again into a Middle Eastern quagmire. He began with the goal of regime change, but is unable to keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He desired a decimation of the Iranian military, but he is unable to protect the US’s allies in the region. He sought to restore American hegemony in the region; instead, he has driven the Gulf states to deepen their ties with China.

At the global level, the Iran war has damaged the reputation of the US as a rational and capable superpower. Allies no longer view Washington as a reliable partner in winning a war, striking a deal or securing peace.

NATO refused to endorse Trumpmon Iran, the Gulf countries are cautious, and the Global South views the US as imperious, hegemonic and erratic. A Pew Research survey of 36 countries found that China is viewed more favourably than the US in 25 countries. The trend is likely to accelerate.

Trump’s Iran strategy has reached a cul-de-sac where every option — war, withdrawal or deal — entails high strategic costs. In the short term, a further escalation involving other regional states is the most likely outcome. The leading countries of the Global South must step forward to broker a ceasefire and advance a de-escalation process. Strategic silence today may result in high strategic costs tomorrow.

The writer is professor, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi

	NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY	
	Open Tender No: JHS-RCNK-M-NTU-26-27-10	Dated: 23.07.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE		

E-Tenders are invited by Chief Workshop Manager, Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, Jhansi from experienced and interested contractors on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work :-
Name of Work: Toilet Upgradation in LHB NAC Coaches.
Cost of work: ₹ 6,78,62,984.25 (Including 18% GST)
Earnest Money Deposit/Bid Security: ₹ 13,57,300.00
Time of completion: Twenty-Four Months
Online tender closing date and time: 20.08.2026 at 11:00 Hrs.

www.ireps.gov.in. 1689/26 (A)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE-TRS-GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender against Tender No. 230-TRS-GZB-2025-26-22-RT. The details are as under:

1.	Name of work	Repairing, dismantling, cleaning, testing and fitting of Main Brake Cylinder (PBAC) Parking Brake Cylinder (PBACF) of pneumatic brake system of WAP5 and Brake Cylinder (PBAC) of WAP7/WAG9 locomotives and replacement of defective pneumatic pipeline, fittings and clamps during Major Schedule (TOH/IOH) and unscheduled locomotives and fitting of manual release Spindle in FTRTLP PBACF (Parking
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2.	Approx. cost of work:	₹ 35,52,036.00
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3. Earnest money to be deposited:	₹ 71,100.00
4. Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender	14.08.2026 (15:00 Hrs.)
5. Date & Time of opening of tender document:	14.08.2026 (After 15:00 Hrs.)

6.	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen:	www.reps.gov.in
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System (i) The bidder must be registered on the Indian Railway e-Tendering System (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in e-tender system. (ii) For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. (iii) No manual offers are acceptable. (iv) Cost of Tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

NO. 230-1 RS-GCB-2023-20-22-R1 Dated: 11.01.2023
 SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2551/26
 राज्य पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता मिशन,

गामि गंगे तथा ग्रामीण जलापूर्ति विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश शासन

W-314(ID)/DEPU.SELECTION-III)/2023 दिनांक: 22 जुलाई, 2026

संशोधित पत्र
 एवं स्वच्छता मिशन के पत्रांक 1100/W-314(ID) /DEPU-

-III /2023 दिनांक 23 जून, 2026 में किये गये अनुरोध के क्रम में एवं लेखा संवर्ग के कतिपय अधिकारियों एवं कर्मचारियों को प्रतिनियुक्ति पर

बन्ध में समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशित कराया गया विज्ञापन की तिथि दिनांक को राज्य पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता मिशन की वेबसाइट p.gov.in पर दिनांक 05.08.2026 की सायं 5:00 बजे तक बढ़ा दी गयी है।

(जोगिंदर सिंह)
अधिशासी निदेशक

UTIVE ENGINEER PROVINCIAL
DIVISION, BUILD PERIOD

DIVISION, P.W.D BIJNOR

-Tender/26-27 Dated: 15.07.2026
(E-Tender)

the Engineer Provincial Division, U.P.P.W.D. Bijnor on behalf of Governor of Uttar Pradesh the percentage rate bids online from the eligible and approved Contractors

Building Works with UP PWD, class A,B,C,D The Bidder may submit bids for any works. Bidders are advised to note the minimum qualification criteria specified in the Instructions to Bidders to qualify for the award of the contract.

Work	Estimated cost (Rs. In Lacs)	Bid Security (Rs. In Lacs)	Cost of Bid Document	Time of Completion	Address of Executive Engineer of the Executing	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer
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and ce of nent Building Bijnor.	11.00	1.10	854/- (Tender Cost be accepted only by Net banking)	09 Months	Provincial Division, P.W.D. Bijnor	Rampur Circle P.W.D Rampur	Chief Engineer Moradabad Zone P.W.D. Moradabad
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adopted in the BOQ include all Other taxes but excluding GST.
 1. The amount should be deposited online through Net Banking as per Column No. 5 & 6

must be downloaded online from 10:00 AM on date 30.07.2026 to 12:00 PM 08.2026 and the technical bids will be opened online on date 04.08.2026 at Office of Executive Engineer Provincial Division PWD Bijnor and Financial

qualified bidders will be opened on date & time as notified. According to
 us of Government Order no. 1/2018/3070/78-2-2018/42 IT/2017 (22) Date
 after opening of the technical and financial bids, the qualified bidder has to

Documents can be seen on website <http://tenderup.nic.in>

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01662, 2240001665, 2240001682, 2240001701, 2240001706, 2240001728, 2240001745,
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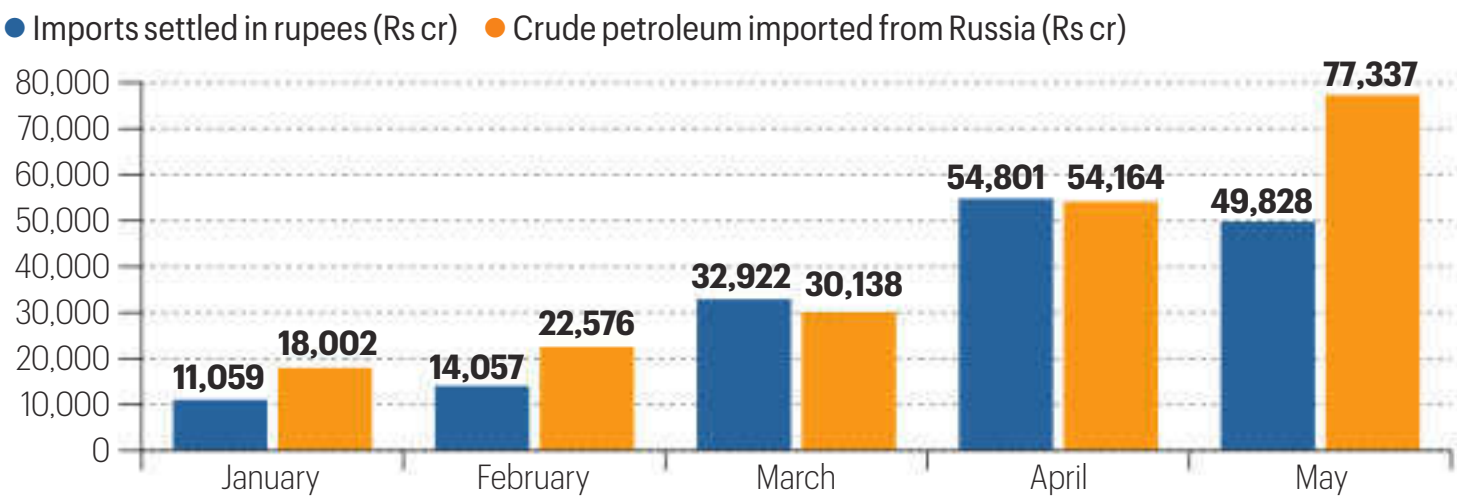
02148, 2240002152, 2240002162, 2240002165, 2240002167, 2240002207, 2240002239,
02310, 2240002332, 2240002358, 2240002396, 2240002467, 2240002492,
25591, 2240002601, 2240002611, 2240002632, 2240002647, 2240002656.
not get completed on the same day due to any reasons, the same will be conducted

MUTHOOT FINCORP LTD

AS RUSSIAN OIL PURCHASES SURGED

India paid \$15 bn of imports in rupees in March-May

• RUSSIAN OIL PURCHASES & PAYMENT FOR IMPORTS IN RUPEES



NOTE: DATA ON SETTLEMENT OF IMPORTS IN RUPEES IS FOR ALL MERCHANDISE GOODS. SOURCE: RBI, MINISTRY OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 24

EVEN AS the value of the rupee tumbled to multiple all-time lows following the onset of the war in West Asia, India used its domestic currency to pay for nearly \$15 billion worth of imports in March, April, and May.

The payment in rupees may have been for oil bought from Russia, whose share in India's oil imports surged after the US and Israel's attack on Iran in late February led to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

According to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) this week, imports worth Rs 1.38 lakh crore were paid for in rupees during the three months in question, calculations by *The Indian Express* showed. This accounted for 7.1% of India's merchandise imports in the three months and is approximately equivalent to \$14.6 billion at the average exchange rate of 94-per-dollar that prevailed during March-May. In the previous three months — December 2025 to February 2026 — imports worth Rs 42,506 crore were settled in rupees, equal to 2.4% of total inbound shipments.

"The rupee's depreciation will only explain a small part of this increased rupee settlement of imports," said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda, instead pointing to the sharp rise in India's purchases of Russian oil starting March.

The imports paid for in ru-

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

Address genuine grievances of taxpayers fairly: FM to tax officers

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 24

Asking tax officers to "serve with humility", Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday said the honest taxpayers should be given the opportunity to correct bona fide errors, while "firm consequences" should be ensured for those who engage in deliberate tax evasion.

Speaking at the 167th Income Tax Day, Sitharaman in her message to the gathering of tax officials also said that the duration of processing timelines needs to be reduced

further along with focusing on shifting from "litigation management" to "litigation prevention" as a long-term objective.

Spelling out five Rs — recognise, respond, redress, reflect and reform — to the tax officers, Sitharaman said tax officials need to recognise every taxpayer's concern promptly, acknowledging that all grievances need timely attention; response with clarity, courtesy, empathy ensuring taxpayers receive meaningful communication at each stage.

They should address genuine grievances fairly and within defined timelines, deliver timely and recent solutions; re-

flect on the root causes of grievances using complaints as an opportunity for institutional learning.

The FM also said that the officers should also reform the processes, systems and procedures continuously so that similar grievances become increasingly rare. "But sometimes we make the error of treating honest taxpayers with deliberate evaders and everybody goes home unhappy with this. We have to be intelligent. We have to be discreet...the authority conferred by tax law must always be exercised with humility," she said. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Renewed war erases Russian oil discounts

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 24

DISCOUNTS ON Russian oil for Indian refiners have vanished again amid the resurgence of conflict in West Asia and the sharp drop in energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, a senior official with government-owned refiner Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) has said.

Amid all this, the demand for oil from other regions has shot up once again, leading to erosion of discounts on Russian oil — the mainstay of India's oil imports.

BPCL's Director (Finance) Vetsa Ramakrishna Gupta said that while Indian refiners are not receiving any discount offer for Russian crude in the prevailing market conditions, there is ample availability of Moscow's oil and crude from other sources in the market to keep India well-supplied.

Given the tightness in global energy supplies, Indian refiners are prioritising oil supply security over price considerations.

As for the US allowing its sanctions waiver on Russian oil purchases to lapse, Gupta said that the move has had no notable impact on buying behaviour as there are enough non-US-sanctioned suppliers of

Russian oil in the market.

The sanctions waiver, which was issued by the US to keep the global oil market well-supplied, lapsed on June 17, the same day on which the US-Iran MoU was inked.

"Russian oil was never sanctioned, only some vessels, service providers, and certain other entities were sanctioned (by the US). But if you are purchasing from other entities, you can very well continue to buy... We are buying completely from the non-sanctioned entities," Gupta told *The Indian Express* Thursday.

He added that the non-sanctioned sources of Russian oil supplies were more than adequate to meet India's demand and supplies till August-end were already tied up, with

"Volumes are available, only the price fluctuates. At times it (Russian oil) even commands a premium, instead of (the usual) discount, but enough volumes are available. In fact, because Russian refineries got impacted (due to Ukrainian attacks), surplus Russian oil volume was available for exports," he said.

Ever since the Russia-Ukraine war broke out in February 2022, Russian crude usually traded at a discount as numerous countries, predominantly in the West, shunned Moscow's oil.

• DIMINISHING GAINS

AFTER THE June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily

THE OPTIMISM led to a fall in oil prices. Discounts on Russian oil at Indian ports had also widened to over \$10 per barrel to benchmark Brent crude in early July, as per industry estimates

HOWEVER, THE recovery in energy flows from West Asia



lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region resumed and tanker traffic crashed again

Highly import-dependent Indian refiners, however, were quick to step up their purchases of Russia's discounted barrels, catapulting Moscow to the position of New Delhi top source of crude within a few months. Before the Ukraine war, Russia was a peripheral oil supplier to India, with less than 2% share in India's oil import basket.

But amid the West Asia war, as vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz — which usually accounted for a fifth go global oil flows — effectively came to a halt, refiners in India and even other parts of the world scrambled for oil from al-

ternative sources, leading to discount erosion and even premium on Russian oil.

After the June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily.

The optimism led to a fall in oil prices; discounts on Russian oil at Indian ports had also widened to over \$10 per barrel to benchmark Brent crude in early July, as per industry estimates. However, the recovery in energy flows from West Asia lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region re-

• BRIEFLY

Manipal Hosps to use IPO money to repay debt & fund acquisitions

Mumbai: Manipal Hospitals is set to come out with one of the biggest IPO in India's healthcare industry next week, aiming to raise around up to Rs 8,000 crore through fresh issue of shares. The issue, which opens for subscription on Wednesday, also comprises an offer for sale (OFS) component of around Rs 1,275 crore. Funds raised via fresh issue are used for a company's growth, while that via OFS goes into the pockets of promoters and selling shareholders. **ENS**

India to roll out common customer ID for banks & insurers

Mumbai: Indian banks and insurers will launch a common customer identification system in August, with asset managers joining later, two regulatory sources and industry executives said, allowing

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▼	US Dollar ■
76,059.77	23,767.45	₹1,43,781	₹96.57
-331.62	-102.15		
-0.43%	-0.43%	Silver ▲	Oil ▲
		₹2,22,721	\$103.33

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 23, 2026

NEW UNITED STATES TARIFFS

India well positioned, but textile input sourcing a worry: Exporters

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 24

AS THE US imposed fresh tariffs of 10% on India after a Section 301 investigation, Indian exporters said the country is better positioned than most of its competitors, particularly China and Vietnam.

But Indian textile exporters said that due to new textile tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia, based on their imports of US cotton, sourcing of cotton, yarn and other intermediate goods from India could be reduced.

SC Ralhan, President of The Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO), said that Indian exporters largely retain their relative competitiveness in these sectors, as competing suppliers will face a similar duty incidence in the US market. "More importantly, Indian exporters could benefit from trade

diversion in several product segments where competing countries are subject to the higher 12.5% tariff. Even a differential of 2.5% can influence sourcing decisions in highly competitive markets, particularly where Indian exporters can offer quality products, reliable deliveries and stable supply chains," he added.

The textile challenge

The USTR has established textile tariff-rate quotas (TRQs) for Bangladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia under which these economies would import US cotton and textile goods for final manufacturing. No such TRQ has been announced for India.

Bangladesh, being one of India's top competitors and also a large importer of Indian cotton and fibre, could now begin sourcing input items from the US, as USTR said that the TRQs will allow a specific volume of textiles and apparel from Bang-

ladesh, Cambodia, Indonesia, and Malaysia to enter the United States free of Section 301 tariffs. These TRQs will have an initial duration of three years, and imports to the US would then begin attracting a 10% Section 301 tariff. Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) Chairman Ashwin Chandran said that the tariff imposition on the issue of forced labour is unfortunate as it does not indicate an expiry date, causing reputational risks, and CITI looks forward to the Indian government taking up this issue with the US given the detrimental impact it could have on textile and apparel exports from India.

"A window has been opened for textile and apparel exports from these countries to enter the United States free of the Section 301 tariffs. This differential treatment risks diverting sourcing orders for textile and apparel items away from India," Chandran said. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

SEBI bars ex-Axis MF chief dealer from market for 7 yrs, 20 others too face ban

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, July 24

THE SECURITIES and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has barred former Axis Mutual Fund chief dealer Viresh Joshi from accessing the securities market for seven years, saying that he orchestrated a front-running scheme using confidential information about the fund house's impending trades.

The regulator also barred 20 others from the market for 3-7

years in its final order in the front running case.

SEBI also slapped Rs 3 crore penalty on Joshi and a total of Rs 7.4 crore from 21 persons involved in the case. Front-running in a mutual fund is an illegal trading practice in which an insider — such as a fund manager, dealer or broker — uses material non-public information about a large pending trade on behalf of the mutual fund or a client to execute personal trades ahead of that order,

intending to profit from the price movement that occurs when the fund's trade is executed. During the investigation after the fraud was detected in 2022, it was found that Joshi shared non-public information about impending orders of a big client to an external co-conspirator, Priyesh Kurani. Priyesh on the instructions of Viresh would place orders in certain conduit/mule accounts of 15 others, the SEBI order said. **FULL REPORT ON** WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



Assets managed by portfolio managers have more than doubled over the past six years. REUTERS

other regulated investment vehicles. SEBI has proposed allowing portfolio managers to invest in overseas listed equity and debt securities, securities that are yet to be listed and a limited exposure to unlisted debt instruments. The move is intended to align PMS

regulations more closely with those governing mutual funds and alternative investment funds (AIFs). The regulator has also proposed to expand the permissible investment universe to permit investments in "to be listed" securities. This would enable

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 24

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has proposed a sweeping review of the SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2020, seeking to modernise the framework governing portfolio management services (PMS).

The SEBI consultation paper, released on July 23, comes against the backdrop of rapid expansion in the PMS industry and changing investor preferences. According to SEBI, assets managed by portfolio managers have more than doubled over the past six years, prompting the need for a fresh regulatory framework. For investors and market participants, the PMS reforms, including mutual fund only category and permission to invest in

overseas securities and to-bes-listed securities, signal SEBI's broader approach of adapting regulations to the growing complexity of India's capital markets while ensuring that investor interests remain at the centre of the regulatory framework.

What is PMS?

Portfolio management service (PMS) is registered under the SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2020. It is a professional investment service where a qualified fund manager takes charge of the equity, debt and other securities portfolio of a customer — who is a high net-worth investor.

Only corporate entities, companies, or LLPs with SEBI registration can legally offer these services in India. SEBI mandates that no PMS provider

can accept less than Rs 50 lakh per client. The assets under management (AUM) of the PMS industry reached Rs 42.61 lakh crore as on May 2026 from Rs 18.07 lakh crore as on April 2019.

The total number of clients as of May 2026 stood at 2.19 lakh from 1.5 lakh in April 2019. The total number of portfolio managers has also increased from 226 in the year 2020, when PM Regulations were revamped, to 515 as on May 31, 2026, an increase of more than two times from 2020.

Wider investment universe

One of the biggest changes proposed is the expansion of investment avenues available to portfolio managers. Currently, PMS providers face restrictions on investing in certain asset classes that are accessible to

foreign securities under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS), subject to an overall limit of USD \$250,000 per financial year.

New MF-only category of portfolio managers

SEBI has proposed a simplified "Mutual Fund-only" PMS framework with lowered entry barriers. This proposed framework aims to effectively serve mass-affluent investors who seek professional portfolio management services for their mutual fund investments.

This framework is introduced to enable portfolio managers intending to exclusively manage client investments only in direct plans of mutual funds schemes including Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs) and Specialized Investment Funds (SIFs). PMS managers

sumed and tanker traffic crashed again. Amid the West Asia crisis, as oil flows from the Gulf dried up, Russian crude became India's strongest energy security hedge.

As per Kpler data, India's Russian oil imports rose to around 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd) in June, accounting for over half of New Delhi's total crude imports. July arrivals are also tracking at healthy levels and could match or even exceed June's volumes, as per estimates. India depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil needs, and over 40% of that was met by oil that came via the Strait of Hormuz.

In the months preceding the West Asia war, oil imports from Russia had reduced notably as the US imposed sanctions on Russian oil majors Rosneft and Lukoil, and amid trade pact negotiations with New Delhi and Washington.

The US made a meaningful reduction in Russian oil imports a prerequisite for scrapping its 25% additional penal tariff on India. But as supplies from West Asia dwindled due to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Russian oil came to India's aid and volumes surged to historic highs.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

HCL, Sarvam AI to set up AI data centre in Odisha

Bhubaneswar: The Odisha government on Friday signed two MoUs with HCL Technologies and Sarvam AI for setting up an AI data centre and a global delivery centre in Khurda district, involving a proposed investment of more than Rs 15,000 crore over the next five years. The state's Electronics and IT Department signed one MoU with HCL Technologies and another jointly with HCL Technologies and Sarvam AI in the presence of Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi. HCL Technologies, with support from Sarvam AI, will establish its first AI data centre in Odisha. PTI

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

LEGAL

Puri temple the only ‘Jagannath Dham’: Odisha’s trademark move

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 24

FIVE TRADEMARK applications submitted by the Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA), the statutory body that administers the 12th century temple in Puri, have cleared the second round of examination by the Trade Marks Registry and been approved for publication in the upcoming Trademark Journal.

SJTA chief administrator Arvind Padhee said Thursday that the Registry had approved names such as “Jagannath Dham”, “Shree Kshetra”, “Mahaprasad”, “Nilachakra” and “Koili Vaikuntha” — associated with Jagannath culture and the shrine. SJTA has filed a total of 29 such applications so far.

Political confrontation

SJTA’s decision to secure trademark registration of words and logos associated with the temple came last year after it locked horns with West Bengal’s then Trinamool Congress government, which built a Jagannath temple in Digha and named it Sri Sri Jagannath Dham Cultural Centre in April 2025, triggering a confrontation.

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, in a letter last May to then Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, said that using “dham” for the Digha temple “dilutes the distinct heritage of Puri”, and added that it hurt the sentiments and emotions of millions of pilgrims and devotees. He said that the Puri shrine holds unparalleled religious, spiritual and cultural significance not just for the people of Odisha but for devotees worldwide, and that the name “Jagannath Dham” holds a unique identity linked to Puri.

Puri’s erstwhile royal and chairperson of Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee, Dibyasingha Deb, said that

SACRED NAMES

- ‘Jagannath Dham’ and ‘Shree Kshetra’ are sacred words associated with Puri, ‘Mahaprasad’ refers to the food offered to the deities and ‘Nilchakra’ is the eight-spoked metal wheel atop the temple.
- ‘Koili Vaikuntha’ refers to the sacred garden inside the shrine where the deities are made from the sacred wooden logs and old deities are buried after consecration of new idols.

using the word “dham” for the Digha shrine amounted to violation of the “scriptural injunctions and long-established tradition” of Lord Jagannath. The controversy ended last month after Suwendu Adhikari, the new Chief Minister of Bengal’s BJP-led government, said that using “dham” for the Digha temple was not in accordance with “Sanatan culture” and removed it from the name.

Trademark registration

Trademark registration is the legal process of protecting a unique brand — like a name, logo, symbol or slogan — associated with any organisation. Established in 1940, India’s Trade Marks Registry administers the provisions of the Trade Marks Act, 1999, and the Trade Marks Rules, 2017. The Registry is a resource and information centre and facilitates matters relating to trademarks in India.

The Act aims to provide for the registration of trademarks relating to goods and services, ensure better protection and prevent their fraudulent use.

Publication of these words in trademarks journals amounts to preliminary approval, as final certificates are issued if no objections are received within three months.

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9 Indore	22 जुलाई शाम 5:30 बजे	27 July 8:00 AM
9 Lucknow	29 जुलाई सुबह 8:00 बजे	30 July 11:30 AM
9 Prayagraj	30 जुलाई सुबह 8:00 बजे	3 Aug 5:30 PM
9 Ranchi	एडमिरल आरंभ	31 July 8:00 AM
9 Patna	एडमिरल आरंभ	30 July 8:00 AM
9 Jaipur	6 अगस्त सुबह 8:00 बजे	11 Aug 5:00 PM

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ECONOMY

Alongside Centre, states’ education expenditure too declined over past 12 years

GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES

BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

THE ONGOING youth protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi and in several other cities, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and seeking education reforms, have brought attention to the state of education in India.

The Indian Express has recently explained how the Education Ministry’s share of the Union Budget had sharply declined over the past 12 years — from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year that the Congress-led UPA government was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26. The fall suggests that the BJP-led NDA government reduced emphasis on education.

As a subject of policymaking, however,

education is not the sole preserve of the Union government.

Common subject

Education falls under the Concurrent list in the Seventh Schedule of the Indian Constitution.

The schedule essentially divides powers and responsibilities between the Union and state governments through three lists — Union, State and Concurrent. Both the Centre and state governments can legislate on subjects under the Concurrent list.

So, how do states act on the subject of education and what policy significance do they attach to it? A broad marker of priority is to examine the share of a state’s total expenditure on education. The table and chart alongside provide a glimpse of where things stand.

Apart from providing an average for all states and Union Territories, the table also looks at a selection of states to provide a geographically and politically diverse sample for the country.

GLOBAL

New US tariffs leave India better off than competitors



RAVI DUTTA MISHRA

THE Donald Trump administration has begun its efforts to reconstruct its International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs that were declared illegal by the US Supreme Court in February.

Starting Friday, the administration began imposing new tariffs under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 on the grounds that the 60 countries it targets — all major exporters to the US — have failed to take measures to stop imports of goods manufactured through forced labour.

According to the US Trade Representative (USTR), countries that import goods made by forced labour get an artificial cost advantage while exporting goods, forcing American workers to compete on an uneven field. The main target, however, is clear: China. These tariffs are largely meant to force countries to cut their dependence on China, which the US is in a trade war with. The US State department says the country uses forced prison labour to make goods and injects these into international supply chains.

The new US architecture is yet to fully take shape. Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple other Section 301 tariff investigations are still ongoing.

India, as of now, faces 10% tariffs, down from the 12.5% when the USTR first proposed the tariffs in March. The Trump administration is expected to announce the results of another Section 301 investigation, this one focusing on excess manufacturing capacity. The lower rates for Indian goods come with New Delhi engaging in negotiations with the US for over a year, stepping up energy imports from Washington and lowering duty for some US goods.

On June 14, India also amended its foreign trade policy to explicitly ban the import of goods produced using forced labour. The USTR considered this an improvement, placing India in the lower-tariff category alongside 16 other economies.

India’s grouping

The USTR’s stated reason for imposing the new Section 301 tariffs is the import of Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

AVIATION

Can airport operator own airline? Concerns over fair access

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 24

THERE IS talk that the Centre may be weighing policy relaxations that could allow airport operators to own airlines, with preliminary internal discussions being underway as per sources. While nothing is concrete yet, such a move could pave the way for airport operators like the Adani group and the GMR group to enter the airline business.

Earlier, there were indications that initial discussions on cross-ownership in airport operators and airlines followed the Adani group’s request for an enabling policy environment, but Adani Enterprises on Friday denied that it was evaluating any proposal to enter the airline business.

The government, on its part, has been calling for more airlines in the Indian skies, given the duopoly of IndiGo and the Air India group, which have a cumulative domestic market share of over 90%. The objective of the discussions to allow airport operators to also run airlines is to foster more competition in the sector, sources said.

Currently, there are stringent restrictions on airport operators having stakes in airlines. For instance, operators of India’s largest airports at Delhi (GMR has 74%) and

Mumbai (Adani group has 74%) are barred from owning more than 10% in a scheduled carrier. The converse is also true, with strict limits on airlines’ ownership in airports.

Conflict of interest

But a move to allow airport operators to run airlines is bound to face resistance from existing carriers and other aviation stakeholders. IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia on Thursday said that any such move will create a “massive conflict of interest” and will be against the interest of consumers.

Globally, aviation and competition regulators have viewed this type of vertical integration with abundant caution, as airports are natural monopolies and provide critical infrastructure for the aviation ecosystem. This implies that they must facilitate fair market access to carriers. If an airport also owns an airline, there are bound to be questions about competition, fair play and non-discriminatory market access.

“One can see where the instinct (of allowing airport operators to own airlines) comes from. India’s entry problem is capital. New airlines... cannot afford to lose money for seven years against a carrier with two-thirds of the market. Adani and GMR can,” said Anupam Manur, professor of economics at

Necessary safeguards

- If India does allow airport operators or entities affiliated to them to also run an airline, experts say that a watertight regulatory and competition oversight system is required.
- Safeguards should include structural separation between airport and airline businesses, independent boards and management teams, protection of carriers’ commercially sensitive information, independent airport slot coordinators, and transparent gate and terminal allocation policies.

the Takshashila Institution. “There is even an efficiency argument: airport profits increasingly come from footfall, so an airport that owns an airline wants more flights at lower fares, not fewer at higher ones. But, obviously problems abound — both economically and ethically.”

The most obvious concern is conflict of interest in important decisions like slot allocation to airlines. If the airport operator is the slot coordinator, there will be an inherent conflict if its own airline was competing with others for prime slots. Even if discrimination doesn’t actually occur, experts believe that it still will be a concern for stakeholders. Generally, anti-trust policies focus on maintaining a level-playing field and not just on instances of actual discrimination.

Airlines depend on airports for critical infrastructure such as parking bays, check-in counters and aircraft stands. As an airport usually controls them, they are expected to be neutral infrastructure and service providers. Any difference on these counts between airlines, even owing to differences in commercial agreements, could lead to allegations of anti-competitive practices. So, regulatory confidence in airport neutrality is important to prevent even subtle forms of preferences or discrimination.

Global trends

Aviation and competition regulators worldwide have largely preferred keeping airports and airlines operationally independent. Even in the few cases of common ownership, like in the major hub airports in West Asia, the government ultimately owns both airlines and the airports. Dubai airport and Emirates are government-owned but are separate corporate entities. So are Etihad and the Abu Dhabi airport, and Qatar Airways and Doha airport.

Similarly, Singapore’s Changi Airport and Singapore Airlines are linked through the Singapore government investment ecosystem, but have distinct management structures and regulatory oversight.

Moreover, all these examples involve large hub airports in territories that have virtually non-existent domestic air traffic, and primarily operate as pure-play international airports serving as hubs for airlines owned by the respective governments. Domestic airline competition is also absent.

But in India, all airlines — except regional carrier Alliance Air — are in the private sector, and a growing number of major airports are being operated by private firms. That makes India’s aviation market more like Europe than West Asian states or Singapore.

The four-tier US tariff structure

Brackets countries based on measures they have taken to prevent imports of products made through forced labour

	Section 301 tariffs	Number of countries
Most favourable group	10% net of MFN tariff rate	EU, Taiwan
Second-most favourable group	Flat 10% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	17 (including India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Canada, Mexico)
Third-most favourable group	12.5% net of MFN tariff rate	3 (Japan, South Korea, Switzerland)
Least favourable	Flat 12.5% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	38 (including China, Vietnam, Russia, Brazil)

SOURCE: GLOBAL TRADE ALERT, USTR; NOTE: MFN REFERS TO MOST-FAVOURABLE NATION

- USTR took action against 60 countries in a forced-labour Section 301 investigation
- Exemption given to Scotch whisky, medical devices, semiconductors

goods made by forced labour.

But the four-tier tariff structure — ostensibly bracketing countries based on their measures to curb imports of forced labour goods — suggests that they were imposed along geopolitical lines. All 60 countries under investigation were found guilty — the most favoured countries or groupings remain the European Union (EU) and Taiwan, and the most unfavourable Vietnam and China.

The USTR explained that for a product of the EU or Taiwan, where the product’s most-favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%, the US shall impose a Section 301 tariff in a way that the sum of the MFN tariff and the Section 301 tariff shall be 10%. In cases where a product’s MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 10%, the section 301 tariff would not be imposed.

In trade parlance, MFN rates are duties that countries use across the board for all countries. As per World Trade Organisation (WTO) norms, MFN rates are the standard, non-discriminatory tariff or tax levels that a WTO member country promises to apply to imports from other WTO members.

The second-most favourable rate has been offered to India and 16 other countries, where a flat addition of 10% has been imposed. This would mean that the Section 301 rate of 10% would be added to the current MFN rate. Countries in this bracket in-

Rebuilding the tariff regime

The new US tariff architecture — meant to reconstruct the IEEPA tariffs struck down by the Supreme Court — is yet to fully take shape.

Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple Section 301 investigations are still ongoing.



US President Donald Trump at the White House on Thursday. AP

clude Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, India, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, the UK, and Trinidad and Tobago. Notably, when the investigation began in March, Pakistan had lower tariffs than India.

Higher rates on competitors

The third-most favourable grouping includes Japan, Korea and Switzerland. These countries had, in earlier tariff structures, received better rates than India. The USTR said these three countries will now face a 12.5% rate. However, just like countries in the first category, the overall tariffs will be capped at 12.5% itself if the MFN tariff is less than that level.

“...where such product’s MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 12.5%, the Trade Representative shall impose a Section 301 tariff of zero,” the USTR said in its finding.

The least favourable group had 38 countries, including top Indian competitors such as Vietnam and China. The USTR said these countries, like the second category, face a flat 12.5% rate, which means 12.5% over and above the MFN rates. These two countries have not only been hit with higher tariffs under the “forced labour” category but are also facing more Section 301 tariffs than India. Exporters said that with Vietnam and China facing steeper rates than India, source-

ing requirements could shift to India.

No credible alternative

In the wake of the tariff measures imposed by the US since early 2025, a significant decline in India’s merchandise exports was widely anticipated. But trade data from the Ministry of Commerce reveals that India’s exports to the US actually grew 0.9% (or \$801.7 million) from \$86.5 billion to \$87.3 billion, an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Research (ICRIER) report released in July said.

This, however, was driven by exports of products in the exclusion list, which primarily included pharmaceutical and electronic goods. “In 2025-26, exports of products covered under the exclusion list rose sharply by 24.5%, climbing from \$29.4 billion to \$36.6 billion. Exports of non-excluded products, by contrast, fell by 11.2% over the same period, declining from US\$ 57.1 billion to US\$ 50.7 billion - a contraction that reflects the true effect of the tariff measures imposed by the United States,” the ICRIER report said.

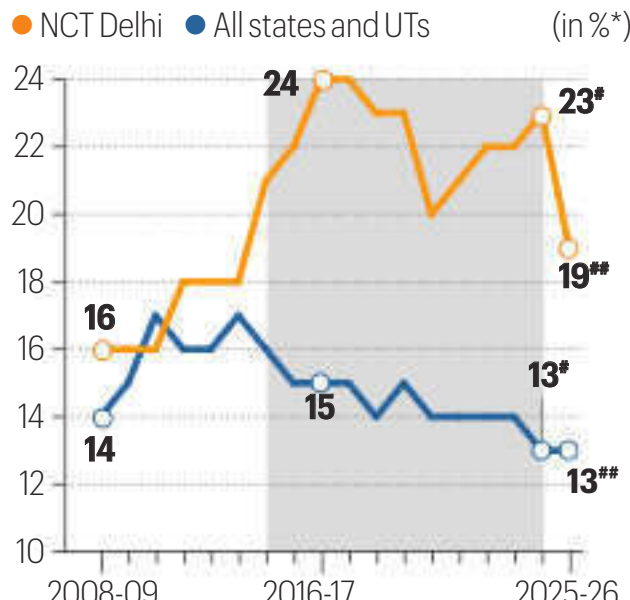
Even as India aggressively scouts for newer markets through free trade agreements, the report pointed out that the capacity of alternative markets to absorb India’s US export losses is “highly uneven... for some product categories, partial for others, and altogether absent for several”.

State of education expenditure

State/Union Territory	Expenditure on education (2025-26)*	State-wise gross enrolment ratio (2024-25)**
Bihar	20	45
Gujarat	13	61
Kerala	12	94
Tamil Nadu	12	89
West Bengal	14	75
NCT Delhi	19	92
All states and UTs	13	69

*AS PERCENTAGE OF AGGREGATE EXPENDITURE **FOR SECONDARY EDUCATION *2024-25 (RE) **2025-26 (BE) SOURCE: RBI NOTE: INCLUDES EXPENDITURE ON SPORTS, ART AND CULTURE UNDER REVENUE EXPENDITURE AND CAPITAL OUTLAY

AAP effect on education spend



chosen, the table shows data on gross enrolment ratio (GER) at the secondary edu-

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+2RvD-RGf9mljMzg1> below the national average. Longer-term data — going back to 2008-09 — shows that Tamil Nadu has largely tracked and then fallen just behind the national level. Kerala used to allocate a higher share than the national average until the Covid-19 year of 2020, and has lagged since then. Gujarat, too, has lagged behind the national average more often than not.

What is concerning is that the national average of all states and UTs itself has been trending down, as the chart alongside shows. After staying at around 17% in 2013-14, the average share of expenditure on education has gradually fallen. This fall is crucial, since it mirrors the fall in the share of money spent by the Union government as well.

There are exceptions to this trend, though. Take the Union Territory of Delhi under the Aam Aadmi Party government, which initially made health and education the key pillars of its pitch to voters. Between 2014-15 and 2024-25, education’s share went up sharply, in contrast to the falling trend of the national average.

Shubhra Gupta

A FILM made four years back, releasing only now, suddenly feels current. Mention of protests and placards woven into the plot around an unraveling couple makes you feel that it's reflecting the times we are passing through. But then, who is to say that thorny relationships and problem-ridden times aren't the story of us, decade upon decade?

Max (Siddharth Menon) and Min (Medha Shankr), a pair whose relationship is heading south, find themselves connecting over their cat. Or is it just the handsome creature that draws Min back to Max, especially when things aren't quite as smooth with the new man in her life? The feelings are relatable: if you've been together for a while, parting is never easy, and could perhaps encompass residual warmth alongside resentment and sadness.

The Max-Min conflict initially feels a little too talky, not enough feely. But the film rescues itself by building upon the connections and gives the characters a few tics

The elements surrounding them feel refreshingly life-like as well. Bad dates we are desperate to get out of. Parents with whom we are in constant, guilt-ridden conflict. How we deal with those things defines who we are, and by the end of this film, we do get to know the contours of its characters, and that's the best part of the film, which begins a little clunkily, and then settles down into its groove, as we go along.

The most interesting character here is Mahesh aka Max's near-estranged father, Ramesh (Adil Hussain), a well-to-do businessman. The latter's brusqueness comes from a broken childhood that is acknowl-



edged when he begins loosening up under the patient ministrations of his therapist, Dhaara (Mandira Bedi, appearing in a series of distractingly gorgeous linen saris). Mahesh's own father (Nassar), now living in an old age home, was always a distant figure, busy with his career as a successful Carnatic classical singer; reconciliation and healing become a key aspect of the thing between the trio, representing three generations.

A cat called Meowzaki just because the two interfaith (Hindu-Muslim) lovers love

MAX MIN & MEOWZAKI
★★★★

DIRECTOR:

Padmakumar Narsimhamurthy

CAST: Siddharth

Menon, Medha

Shankr, Adil Hussain,

Vidhatri Bandi,

Mandira Bedi, Nassar,

Nafisa Ali

Miyazaki, is too cutesy for words, but is handsome enough to be forgiven his name. The Max-Min conflict initially feels a little too talky, not enough feely. But the film rescues itself by building upon the connections and gives the characters a few tics: Max finds it hard to sleep; his sleeplessness finds an echo in a cat-sitter (Vidhatri Bandi), whose grandmother (Nafisa Ali) is in an advanced stage of Alzheimer's. And as we see them begin leaning on, and into each other, we begin to lean into the easy warmth the film is

trying to build.

There are also the unexpected touches which lift the film, especially in the way a lesbian relationship is slipped in quietly, adding to the texture. Menon is a constant presence, and does well as the coming-of-age young man. It is Hussain, as the man who takes the longest, most difficult steps towards self-awareness, who holds this film: despite a few places where the emphasis on the Tamilian vowels is evident — Dhaara becomes Daara — his Ramesh Mahadevan is pitch perfect.

No Kick to the Blend

Shubhra Gupta

A THREE-WAY modern romance set in a small town. That's the pitchline of *Musafir Cafe*, based on a novel of the same name by Divya Prakash Dubey and created by Sharanya Rajgopal and directed by Ruchir Arun. The eight-part show takes the memo very seriously indeed. Chander and Sudha — someone here is evidently a fan of Dharam-veer Bharati's classic novel of the same name — meet and ignite in Bhopal.

Having quit his software job in the US, he works in a dull government office, nursing a dream of opening his own cafe in the hills, while meeting suitable girls with a view to marriage.

She is your ambitious girl who never hides anything she's thinking, outspoken in the way Bollywood *chulbulis* are: Sudha, like that other girl in the train, is her own favourite, and doesn't care who knows it.

There's passion. There's a bit of sex — yes, really — too. Small town people aren't squeamish like that, okay? All is well until ambition rears its ugly head. So, a rift in the lute. Time elapses. And then, bingo, there comes that picturesque cafe, blue skies, misty hills, and a generous-hearted girl called Preeti.

But, but, is that that? Will Chander and Preeti live happily ever after? Even though good-looking guests make puppy eyes at Preeti, knowing full well that her heart beats for another? And even though she knows, yes, she does, that Chander hasn't forgotten his first love?

Musafir Cafe is that rom com that is aiming for sweet and winsome, which should have left you with the warm fuzzies. But it doesn't quite get there. Not because the actors aren't up for it. Not because they don't try. Not because the plot doesn't have room for all of them. But because it ends up being more performative than felt.

Vikrant Massey as Chander tries his best to be believable and he really does come close to it. Mahima Makwana as the steady



MUSAFIR CAFE
★★★★

DIRECTOR: Ruchir

Arun

CAST: Vikrant

Massey, Vedika Pinto,

Mahima Makwana,

Rajeev Siddhartha,

Anubha Fatehpuria,

Loveleen Mishra,

Sadiya Siddiqui

STREAMING ON:

Netflix

third wheel is commendable too, even though she gets short shrift when it comes to a backstory. It is the spritely Vedika Pinto, who acts out her part, for no fault of hers: the writers keep putting her in front of a man whose jaw keeps dropping at her carefree airs: '*kya hotum*,' he says in amazement, not once, but twice, and maybe thrice. And by then, our Sudha believes in it too: that she's too cool for school, and certainly for the sedate Chander.

There are also a bunch of excellent actors with very little to do but play out ropes: Anubha Fatehpuria as Chander's mother, Loveleen Mishra as Sudha's mother, and Adil Hussain and Sadiya Siddiqui as the still madly in love silver-haired couple as Chander and Preeti's mentors and well-wishers.

Why does it take eight stretched episodes to tell a tale that would have been better told in half the time? Why is the serene city of Bhopal such a fleeting presence — the famed lake glimpsed from a terrace cafe — even though it is named frequently through the show? Those are also questions which this could-have-been-a-*pyaari-prem kahani* doesn't answer well enough.



When Every Lesson Is a Lecture

Shubhra Gupta

THIS SEVEN-PART series reminds me a little of *Maamla Legal Hai*, the show set in a lower Delhi court in a part of the national Capital far away from the swag and smoothness of Central Delhi. *Adarsh Baal Vidyalaya* functions in the same mould: this is a sarkari school in the fictional mohalla of Tinki Toli, whose students come from a certain section of society, with parents working low-rung jobs, whose only way out of the rut is education.

It's quite ironic that the show is out at a time when student protests are ringing out in Delhi and in other parts of the country, demanding accountability and the reset of an education system which has been systematically devalued over time. And it's even more ironic that for a show which wants to do the right thing — picking up topics which are relevant and timely — it goes about it in such an overstated manner. Everything is underlined; very little is left to the imagination.

Gyansheshwar Tripathi (Kay Kay Menon) is the principal of ABV, where he spends much of his time playing cricket with his students, when not dashing his head against the intractable wall of 'no money, no resources' which stops his wards from doing well in exams. And that's a factor which prevents him from taking off to a foreign jaunt which he has set his heart upon, not just for himself, but for his loyal wife (Prachee Shah), who has stood by him all these years.

Over seven episodes, around 25-35 minutes each, such issues as corruption, honesty, respect for an older generation, as well as jobs that are considered beneath your dignity, sex education by a shrinking female teacher (Annapurna Soni), and others, are brought up for an airing, and kept aside after being neatly resolved. Not much is left hanging, because that would

make things complex, and that wouldn't do, would it?

The able Naveen Kasturia plays a counsellor raising his teenage daughter — who attends the same school — and learning on the job. Abhimanyu Singh, breaking from his usual grey roles, pitches in as the burly teacher who learns better than using force to get the students to fall in line: the fact that he has a second job to augment his meagre salary — moonlighting as a mehendi artist to make ends meet — makes for an interesting layer.

Archana Puran Singh, shilling for a local MP (Deven Bhojani), keeps coming in the way of the principal and his undeniable affection for his students. Prasanna Bisht is a newbie who adjusts to the ways

of an ill-funded government-run school without losing sight of why she wanted to be a teacher in the first place: she speaks up against the labelling of kids as *malai* vs *khurchan*, telling us every child has the right to an education.

The premise is solid, and in between all the preachiness, there's an attempt to showcase the difficulties faced by overburdened and underfunded *sarkari* institutions. But that keeps disappearing in the pile of clichés: how a *sanskari* teacher is reluctant to use the word penis in a sex ed class is such an old one. I also wasn't very sure about a North Eastern actor playing the stereotyped role of a canteen cook rustling up spicy chowmein, even though he is held up as a role model in passing. Kay Kay does his best, staying consistently watchable, but that's nothing new. That a teacher can be dyslexic is a good touch, but the clear intention of inserting low-hanging laughs at every step dilutes the impact.

One line cracked me up, though. An act of eating-and-spitting paan is called peek detailing, hehe. Now why wasn't there more from where that came?

Lost in Translation

Yashaswini Sri

THIS WAS meant to be Vijay's send-off — a farewell marking the end of a remarkable three-decade career spanning more than 60 films. And yet, watching Vijay light up the screen one last time while the film around him struggles to keep pace, the feeling is not one of celebration but of a missed opportunity. Vijay delivers exactly what his fans expect and even more. Unfortunately, the film squanders the chance to give the star the farewell he deserved.

Directed by H Vinoth, it is a hat tip to Anil Ravipudi's Telugu hit *Bhagavanth Kesari* (2023). While foundation of the film remains the same, the story is reworked into a political action thriller. On paper, that sounds like a filmmaker adopting a solid emotional core and building it into something bigger. On screen, it plays like two different films stitched together, neither of which fully works.



JANA NAYAGAN ★★

DIRECTOR: H Vinoth

CAST: Joseph Vijay,

Pooja Hegde, Bobby Deol,

Mamitha Baiju, Prakash Raj,

Gautham Vasudev Menon

The story follows Vetri Kondan, a former police officer played by Vijay, who is drawn into conflict when a young girl

close to him, played by Mamitha Baiju, faces a threat that traces back to a powerful international arms dealer named Phoenix, played by Bobby Deol.

Vinoth constructs an elaborate backstory involving civil wars in Africa, terrorist attacks from Pakistan, drone warfare, robots fighting humans, and a confrontation between the villain and his own alter ego. The VFX in these sequences is poor given

• STREAMING WATCHLIST



Protector

LIONSGATE PLAY

IN A new town, Nikki has built a quiet life with her teenage daughter, determined to keep her safe from everything she once was. But when Nikki wakes up in an abandoned factory with no memory of how she got there, her daughter has vanished. What follows is a race through the criminal underworld that Nikki navigates the only way she knows how: with the full force of a military career she never fully walked away from. Directed by Adrian Grünberg, the cast includes Milla Jovovich, Matthew Modine and Isabel Myers.



Watson

JIOHOTSTAR

SIX MONTHS after the apparent death of Sherlock Holmes at the hands of Moriarty, Dr John Watson (Morris Chestnut) returns to medicine, taking charge of a clinic dedicated to treating rare and unusual disorders. But his past refuses to stay buried as Moriarty resurfaces, pulling Watson into a new battle of wits. Blending medical drama with investigative suspense, the series created by Craig Sweeny reimagines one of literature's most iconic characters, shifting his focus from solving crimes to unraveling complex medical mysteries.



Aga Aai

Aaho Aai

ZEE5

AGA AAI Aaho Aai is a heart-warming Marathi family drama that celebrates the

unique bond between a daughter, her mother, and her mother-in-law, showing how love deepens when families come together. Directed by Varun Narvekar and written by Kalyani Pandit, the series stars Hruta Durgule, Renuka Shahane, and Nirmitti Sawant.



72 Hours

NETFLIX

THE MOVIE 72 Hours follows a 40-year-old executive (Kevin Hart) who hopes to revive his faltering career by tagging along on a chaotic three-day bachelor party after he's

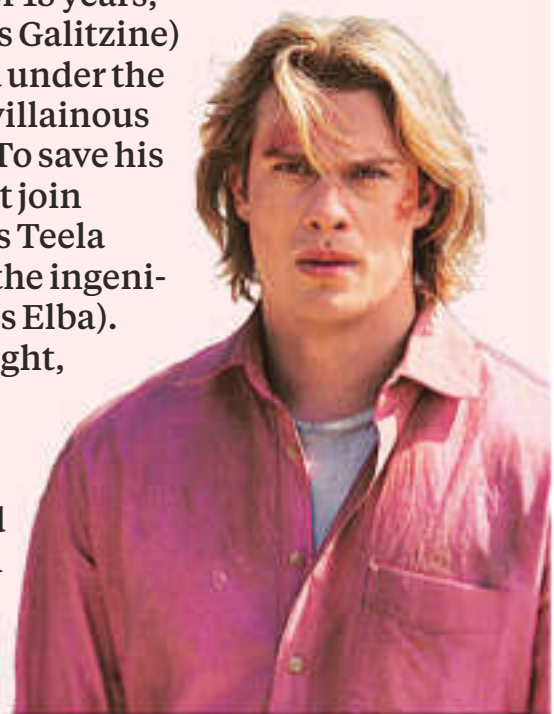
mistakenly added to a group chat of 20-somethings. Directed by Tim Story, the comedy also stars Mason Gooding, Marcello Hernández, Ben Marshall, Zach Cherry, Kam Patterson, and Teyana Taylor.

Masters of the Universe

PRIME VIDEO

AFTER BEING away for 15 years, Prince Adam (Nicholas Galitzine) returns to find Eternia under the tyrannical rule of the villainous Skeletor (Jared Leto). To save his homeland, Adam must join forces with the fearless Teela (Camila Mendes) and the ingenious Man-at-Arms (Idris Elba). Directed by Travis Knight, the fantasy adventure combines large-scale action with nostalgic appeal. It is the second live-action adaptation of the franchise.

ALAKA SAHANI



this is a big production that had three years to get it right. The AI-generated visuals look unfinished; the action sequences that are supposed to establish Phoenix as a global threat end up making him look like a character from a video game.

Where the film works, and it does work in stretches, is where Vijay is allowed to be himself. Mamitha Baiju brings real weight to her scenes and delivers one of the more affecting performances in the film. Pooja Hegde as Kayal does what the script allows, which is not much. Prakash Raj and Gautham Vasudev Menon add texture in their supporting roles, though neither is given enough screen time to fully register.

The deeper problem with *Jana Naya-gan* is not any single bad decision. It is the weight of trying to be everything at once. This is a film that wants to be a women empowerment drama, a political thriller, a modern warfare spectacle, a family sentiment piece, a mass action entertainer, a campaign video, a farewell tribute, and a statement about Indian democracy.

Vijay deserved better. His fans, who waited six months through a censor battle, a court case, a nationwide leak and an A-certificate, deserved better.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I Vartika W/O, Parvesh Kumar R/o 44, Skippetts Garden, Basingstoke, United Kingdom-rg213by have changed my name to Vartika Shiviagi.

0040867945-1

I, Mohammad Junaid S/o Khaleel Ahmad R/o H.No.-12A/47E, Jamalu ka Bagh Maujpur, Bhajan Pura, Delhi, my father name is wrongly written as Khaleel Ahmed in my 10th, 12th Class educational documents and Passport no. S2336211. my father actual name is Khaleel Ahmad.

0071049942-1

I, ASHISH GARG, S/o SUBHASH CHAND GARG, R/o B-102, 3RD FLOOR, B BLOCK, VIPUL-SQUARE, SUSHANT-LOK, PHASE-1, Sikanderpur Ghosi(68), Gurgaon, Haryana-122002, have changed the name of my minor son NIRREVEIR, aged about 3-years, and he shall hereafter be known as NIRREVEIR GARG.

0040868067-8

It is for general information that I, UMAR MOHAMMAD NOORANI, S/o Noor Ahamad, R/o H.No.C-78, Main Nala-Road, Chand Bagh, Karawal Nagar, PO: Karawal Nagar, DIST-North-East Delhi, Delhi-110094 declare that name of my father and my mother has been wrongly written as Noor Ahmed and Saira Khatoon in my school record. The actual name of my father and my mother are Noor Ahamad and Sayra Khatoon, respectively, which may be amended accordingly

0040868072-11

I, Manik Sharma, W/o Rakesh Bakshi, resident of LA Residential Flat 1004 Tower-3 Plot GH-06A Tech Zone -4, GR. Noida West, Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.), have changed my name from "Manik Sharma" to "Manik Bakshi". Henceforth, I would be known by the name of "Manik Bakshi" for all future purposes.

0130067226-1

I, Sunil kumar s/o Ved parkash, r/o F-27-28, sector-11 Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my name to SUNIL GARG for all purposes.

0040868072-4

I Bharat Bhushan S/o Ganga Ram R/o WZ-87, G.F., Virender Nagar, Janakpuri B-1, S.O., West Delhi, Delhi-110058 have changed the name of my minor son from Devansh to Evijan for all purposes.

0040867937-1

I.R.D. Painter S/o Mahavir Prasad R/o A-4/165, New Kondli Mayur Vihar, Phase-3, Delhi-110096 have changed my name from R.D. Painter to Ram Dayal Gupta. henceforth I would be known by the name of Ram Dayal Gupta for all future purposes.

0071049849-1

I Salony D/o Sunil Datt R/o F.No-401, A Block, 3rd Floor, Ribhya Residency, B.V. College, DIST: Patna, Bihar-800014, have changed my name to Salony Datt

0071049946-1

I, Renu, W/o Jitender Singh, R/o RZ-689B, gali no.2, Indira-Park, Palam Colony, South-West Delhi-110045, have changed my name to Renu Singh

0040868067-10

I, Parul Aggarwal, W/o Samir Agrawal, R/O F-1, First-Floor, 27 Block-B, Ramprastha-Colony, Chander-Nagar, Dist:Ghaziabad, UP-201011, have changed my name to Parul Agrawal.

0040868078-2

I, Sushma Devi, B/o Manoj Prasad, resident of B-603, Migsun Green Mansion, HRA-14, Site-C, Surajpur, Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar-201306, have changed my name from Sushma Devi to Sushama. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Sushama for all future purposes.

0071049865-1

I Laxminarayan S/o Lachhmarin Nag R/o Kumharpara, Nagarnagar, Bastar, Chhattisgarh-494001, have changed my name to Laxminarayan Nag

0071049934-1

I, Anju Devi, M/o -Sanjay Kumar, resident of Village- Sukhia, PO-Mohania Chakla PS- Banmankhi Dist-Purnia, (Bihar)-854102, have changed my name from Anju Devi to Anju Kumari, vide affidavit dated-23/07/2026.

0040868067-12

I, Dayal Singh Patwal, S/o- Laxman Singh Patwal, R/o-D-158, Gali No.9, New Ashok Nagar, Vasundhara-Enclave, East Delhi-110096, declare that Dayal Singh Patwal, and Dayal Singh, both name are same and one person. Shall hereafter be known as Dayal Singh Patwal, for all future purposes.

0040868078-4

I, Ex Risalidar JC103069K Mahavir Singh Resident of Vill-Kalyanpur, P.O. Karanpur, Khair, Aligarh, U.P., Presently residing at House No. 2926, E2/69, Molarband Extn. New Delhi-44 have changed my daughter's name from LAJJAWATI to SHIMLA DEVI for all future purposes.

0071049847-1

I, Parteet Kaur Suri, D/O Satinder Pal Singh, R/O A/99, Lajpat Nagar-1, Delhi-110024, have changed my name to Parteet Kaur.

0040868067-5

I Sumit Sehgal, S/o Shri Kuldeep Kumar Sehgal, R/o Flat No. 803, Kamadgiri Apartment, Kasmahmbi, I.E., Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, hereby declare that my father's name is mentioned as "Kuldeep Sehgal" in my Passport, whereas in my other records it is mentioned as "Kuldeep Kumar Sehgal". Both names refer to one and the same person. Henceforth, my father's correct name shall be known and recognized as "Kuldeep Kumar Sehgal" only.

0071049853-1

It is for general information that I, Yash Ashtikar S/o Avinash Ashtikar R/o M D D 102, Phase-1, Kabir Nagar, Raipur, Sondaonagri, Talibandh, Bindrawangarh, Raipur, Chhattisgarh-492099, declare that name of mine, my father and my mother has been wrongly written as Yash Ashtikar, Avinash Asithkar and Sunita Asithkar respectively in my Secondary & Senior Secondary Marks Statement Cum Certificate. The actual name of mine, my father and my mother is Yash Ashtikar, Avinash Ashtikar and Rani Ashtikar respectively, which may be amended accordingly.

0071049940-1

I, SANJAY DUBY ALIAS SANJAY KUMAR DWIVEDI S/o BHOLA NATH R/o 562, UDHOG NAGAR T-HUTS, GALI NO-1, PASCHIM VIHAR, PEERA GDHI, SUNDER VIHAR, DELHI-110087 have changed my name to SANJAY KUMAR DWIVEDI.

0071049907-1

I, BHUPINDER KOUR W/o Ajeet Pal Singh, 5-D-74, JNV Colony, Bikaner, Rajasthan-334001, have changed my name to BHUPENDRA KOUR.

0071049900-1

I, hitherto known as Lakshay, S/o -Shri Sandeep, R/o Village-Dulehra(56), Post Office-Dulehra, Bahadurgarh, Distt Hhajjar(Haryana)-124507, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known Lakshay Deswal.

0040868072-8

I, AMAR KUMAR S/o RAMPHOOL R/o 125, G/F Sainik Enclave, Sector-2 Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110059, have changed the name of my minor daughter DIRRA aged 2 years and she shall hereafter be known as DIRRA KUMAR.

0071049889-1

I, MOHD NAFIS, S/o ABDUL GANI, R/o 2495, Gal Kareem Baksh, Shardhanand Marg, Delhi-110066 have changed my name to MOHD NAFES, S/o ABDUL GHANI, for all purposes.

0040867948-1

I, REETU SHARMA W/O CHANDER PRAKASH SHARMA, R/O H.NO.WB-171A GANESH-NAGAR-II SHAKARPUR, DELHI-110092, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RITU SHARMA.

0040868067-3

I, ASHA WADHWA, W/O-YASH PAL, R/O- HOUSE NO.6 (1/2)1ST FLOOR OPP POWERHOUSE MALKAGANJ, DELHI-110007, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO ASHA FOR FUTURE

0040868072-6

I, Surendra Sharma, S/o Ramesh Chandra Sharma R/o F-107, Sector-17, Vasundhara, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201010 have changed my name to Surendra Kumar Sharma.

0040868072-2

I, Kuldip Raj, S/o Durga Das Mahajan, R/o-1014, Tower 3, Ashiana Upvan, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad-201014, have changed my name from Kuldip Raj to Kuldip Raj Mahajan, for all future purposes.

0040868080-1

I, MOHAN PANDEY S/o BHAWANI DATT r/o Flat No.-198, SFS, Pocket-1, Sector-6, Dwarka, Delhi-110075 have changed my name MOHAN CHANDAR PANDEY permanently.

0040867941-2

I, Ankur Torner S/o Yashveer Singh R/o A-3/402 East Gokal Pur, Amar Colony, Distt- North East, Delhi -110094, have changed my minor Daughter's name from Kavya Alias Aadhya Alias Kavya Chaudhary Aged 05 Years to Aadhya Chaudhary forever.

0071049938-1

I, NEENA KALRA, W/O-LATE SH.KRISHAN KALRA, R/O-4311, PLOT.NO.3, TOWER NOVA-EAST, SUPER TECH SUPERNova, DISTRICT- GAUTAM BUDDHA-NAGAR, PO NOIDA, U.P.-201301, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME, FROM NEENA KALRA TO MEENA KALRA, FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES

0040868072-10

I, Satish chander budhiraja, S/O Ram wadhya, HOUSE, NO-A-10 ground-floor, Vivek vihar phase-1, delhi 110095, HAVE CHANGE MY NAME TO Satish chander, PERMANENTLY

0040868067-7

I, Praveen Bisht /Praveen Kumar Bisht /Praveen Singh Bisht S/o Jagat Singh Bisht R/o J-120/1, Gali No-1, Kartar Nagar, Delhi-110053 have changed my name to Praveen.

0071049893-1

It is for general information that I, AJAY KUMAR, S/O HARISH CHAND, R/O A-552, Mahavir Enclave-II, Street No. 15, New Delhi -110059, declare that name of mine, my wife and my daughter has been wrongly written as AJAY, VANDANA and SIDDHI in my daughter's namely SIDDHI JAISWAL in her school records. The actual name of mine, my wife and my daughter are AJAY KUMAR, BANDANA JAISWAL and SIDDHI JAISWAL respectively, which may be amended accordingly.

0040867995-1

I, Renu Bala w/o Sunil Garg, r/o F-2/27-28, sector-11, Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my name to RENU GARG for all purposes.

0040868072-3

I, K B MALHOTRA S/o N N Malhotra R/O B-33, Sangam Apartment Plot No.23, Sector-9, Rohini, Sector-7, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to KUL BHUSHAN MALHOTRA

0040868078-1

I, Kulsuma Ajaz, W/O-No-9111231Y, Ex Sep Ajaz Ahmad Mir, R/O-Maidanpora Lolab, District-Kupwara. In my husband's service record my D o B has been wrongly mentioned as15th March 1982 instead of5th March 1982.It needs correction, vide affidavit No-IN JK38273377824234Y dated-20th July 2026 before Judicial Magistrate Kupwara.

0020517101-1

I, Anil Kumar s/o Gulshan Lal R/o B-546, Sudershan Park, Delhi-110015, have changed my name to Anil Kumar Dutta Permanently.

0040868067-2

I, YASHPAL WADHWA, S/O-JAGDISH, R/O HOUSE, NO.6 (1/2)1ST FLOOR OPP POWER HOUSE MALKA GANJ, DELHI-110007, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO YASH PAL FOR FUTURE

0040868072-5

I, Meetu, W/o Sh.Navin Arya, R/O H.No.996, Sector-16, Faridabad, Haryana-121001, declare that "Meetu" and "Kum.Meetu Rani" are one and the same person. My father's name is wrongly mentioned as "Nemi Chand Garg" in my 10th-Certificate. The correct name is "Nem Chand" My correct name is Meetu, and these names shall be used, for all future purposes.

0040868021-1

I, POONAM W/O SH. SHIV LAL R/O 16/85, GEETA COLONY, DELHI -31, POONAM & POONAM GUPTA IS ONE & THE SAME PERSON. I HAVE CHANGE MY NAME POONAM GUPTA TO POONAM FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSE.

0040867935-1

I, Kamal Choudhary S/o Rohtash Singh R/O H-No-81, Bankauli, Bakoli, North West Delhi-110036, I have changed the name of my minor Son Kabir Singh to Avyukt Singh aged 5 years.

0071049948-1

I, ASHISH GARG, S/O SUBHASH CHAND GARG, R/O,B-102, 3RD-FLOOR, B BLOCK, VIPUL-SQUARE, SUSHANT LOK, PHASE-1, Sikanderpur Ghosi(68), Gurgaon, Haryana-122002, have changed the name of my minor son NIRRVAAAN, aged about 3-years, and he shall hereafter be known as NIRRVAAAN GARG.

0040868067-9

I, RAY K GAUTAM, S/o RAMESHWAR DAKK GAUTAM, R/o- H.No.45, 6th Floor, Pocket-2, DDA Mig Flats, Tower-A, Triveni Heights, Sector-16-B, Dwarka, Delhi-110078, have changed my name to RAJENDER KUMAR, for all purposes.

0040868067-1

I, parvati prajapati, mother of, Lakhan prajapati, residing at Village Kumda-post Pipliya kulmi ps machalpur, Kumda, rajgarh, Pipliya-kulmi, Madhya Pradesh, Pin-465693, have changed my name from Parvati prajapati to Pari Bai, vide-affidavit dated..23-July-2026.

0040868067-11

I, Yajvender Singh S/o Ishwar Singh, R/O WZ-170, Basaidapurpur, Ramesh-Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110015, have changed my minor son's name Hitesh to Hitesh Baghel. Aged-13-years.

0040868078-3

I, MANJIT SINGH/ MANJEET SINGH, S/O DARSHAN SINGH, R/O B-10, BLOCK-B OLD QUARTER, RAMESH NAGAR, DELHI-110015, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MANJEET SINGH OBEROI.

0040868067-4

I, HARSHIT WADHWA, S/O-YASH PAL, R/O- HOUSE NO.6, (1/2) 1ST FLOOR OPP POWER HOUSE MALKAGANJ, DELHI-110007, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO HARSHIT, FOR FUTURE.

0040868072-7

I Sandeep Kumar Talwar S/o, Late Sudarshan Kumar Talwar R/o C 186, Jal Vayu Vihar, Sector 21 Noida have changed my name to Sandeep Talwar for all purposes.

0040868016-1

I, Shaija Malik W/o Sultan Faisal, R/O-M-60, Street No.14, Brahmapuri, New Seelampur, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to Shazia, for all purposes.

0040868072-9

I, Rishab Jain S/o Sh. Sunil Jain, R/O House No.173, Sector-15, Near D.A.V School, Sonipat, Haryana-131001, have changed my son's name from Rihaan Jain to Aviraj Jain (Date-of-Birth:07.11.2023), for all future purposes.

0040868078-6

I Sachin Kalley alias Sachinr Kumaar S/o Vijay Kumar R/O A-746/1, Block-A, Shastri Nagar, North West Delhi, Delhi-110052 have changed my name to Sachin Gupta for all purposes.

0040867937-2

I, Poonam Dixit, W/O Ravi Dixit, HOUSE, NO-A5A/328 Janta-flats janak puri new delhi-110058, HAVE CHANGE MY NAME TO Poonam Kashyap PERMANENTLY.

0040868067-6

I, KANWALJEET KAUR SACHDEVA alias KAWALJIT KAUR SACHDEVA W/o GURMEET SINGH SACHDEVA R/o 7A/75, Third Floor, Channa Market, WEA, Karol Bagh, Delhi-110005 have changed my name to KAWALJIT KAUR permanently.

0040867941-1

I, Renu Rani W/O Suresh Kumar Gupta R/O-H.No.115, Vasundhara Apartment, Sector-9, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to Renu Gupta.

0040868080-2

I, Lokesk Kumar S/o Harpal Dixit R/o-89 Gyasri, URF Gadhi-2, Janpad, Baghatp have changed my name to Lokesk Dixit.

0071049888-1

I, Nisar W/o Shamim Ali R/o 7200, Lambi Wali, Beri Wala Bagh Azad Market, Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Nishat Begum for all future purposes.

0040867992-1

I, MAMTA DEVI, W/O- ARUN KUMAR R/O-H.NO.-260, GALI NO.-4, SHANKER GARDEN LINE PAR, BAHADURGARH, HARYANA-124507 have changed my name to MAMTA for all purpose

0040868072-2

I, GULERANA W/o AMAAN ALI, R/o H.NO- 73/2, 3RD Floor, Kishan Kunj Extension, Laxmi Nagar, Delhi-110092, have changed my name to GULERANA ALI

0071049811-1

LOST & FOUND

I, Sanjay Kumar Goel, S/o Shri Jagdish Prasad Goel, R/O C-245, Lohia Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, hereby inform that the Original Registered Sale Deed of a residential vacant plot admeasuring 62.70 Sq. Mtrs., forming part of Khasra No.351M, situated at Village Hasanpur Bhowapur, Pargana Loni, Ghaziabad, Regn. No.47901 dated-31.12.2012, has been lost somewhere. Finder may kindly contact Mob.9810371978.

0071049912-1

Lost My 70'original DDA Allotment Letter 5th & Final Installment Electric & Water NOC, Site Possession, Transfer Letter etc. of the DDA FLAT No.C-335, on SECOND FLOOR, CATEGORY-MIG, BLOCK-'C', 'SAKET', NEW DELHI-110017, vide File No. F-32(237)74/LAB(H)-7.(TARUN KAPOOR) R/O C-335, DDA MIG FLATS, GOLF VIVE APARTMENT SAKET, NEW DELHI-110017, Mo-9810267981

0071049872-1

PROPERTY

ESTATE & PROPERTY

Artificial Intelligence Powered Property Search Tricity Chandigarh Panchkula Zirakpur Mohali Pinjore Kaika Parwanoo hobospes(gar) 9811158486

0040867513-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public Notice is hereby given to the General Public that my daughter Raksha Meen and Son: On Walk, near the local owners and persons in possession of Khasra No. 411, (200 Sq. Yards), situated at Vill. Khara Khud, Delhi. On 25.02.2016, after receiving the full sale consideration, we voluntarily sold, transferred and handed over vacant, peaceful and physical possession of the fore-said property to Mr. Kavi Lal Sehrawal/Kavla Arya, W/o Sh. Kipli Devi, residing at Gurgaon (with consideration and stamp duty). Agreement to Sell, Possession Letter, Affidavit, Will and other documents, without any loan, lender or co-owner. The said property and/or our exclusive share, and we had full legal right and authority to transfer the same. That all other family/co-shares had already received possession of their respective plots and demarcated them by constructing separate boundary walls. Mr. Kavi Lal Sehrawal got the property registered in her favour through a Registered Sale Deed on 07.07.2026 before the Office of the Sub-Registrar, Narela, Delhi. Accordingly, neither we nor our legal heirs, successors or representatives have any right, title, interest or claim whatsoever over the said property. If any person, bank, financial institution or authority has any lawful objection, claim, lien or encumbrance regarding the aforesaid property, the same may be submitted with supporting documents before the purchaser or the concerned Sub-Registrar within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which it shall be presumed that no such objection exists. Mobile No. 9773740852

PAWAN KUMAR (Advocate)

Enrl.No. D3337823 KUMAR

Public Notice This is to inform to all that my Client Girish Chandra S/o Late Sh. Govind and Valthib R/o 440-A, Nyay Khand-2, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014 has severed all his relation with his daughter Pooja. Being not dutiful and obedient, she is beyond the control of my client, therefore, my client disowned her from all his movable & immovable properties. Hence public is hereby put to notice that she is not legally competent to represent herself as legal heir of my client. Anyone choosing to deal with her either individually or jointly, would be doing so on his/her own risk and consequences as my client would not be held responsible for out of her acts.

Sd/- Deepak Rikharl Advocate

Ch. No. 109, (First Floor), Western Wing, Tis Hazari Courts Delhi-110054

Public Notice I, Sanjay Harish, S/o Late Sh. Suresh Kumar Harish, R/O C-58/308, Jangpuri, N.D-58 being allotted vide DDA File No. F-32(926)74/HB dt.4.3.74 have lost the original Possession Letter & NOC Slip of Water and Electricity Connection issued by DDA (Sector) Shri Suresh Kumar Harish for aforesaid property has been lost. A.F.R. LR. No. 47685/2026 dated 24.7.2026 in this effect has been lodged to police station. Any person found in possession of original documents may write/contact the above named person at above address within one month from the date of publication of this notice and can personally contact Shri Sanjay Harish or Sh. Navin Harish, R/O C-58/308, Janakpuri, ND-110058. Ph. 9790389601, 999996103

Public Notice Be it known my clients ANITA SONI W/O SH. KANWAL SONI AND KANWAL SONI S/O SH. LACHMAN DASS SONI BOTH R/O 308, 3ST FLOOR, KRISHNA ENCLAVE, SECTOR-17, ROHINI, DELHI-110089 have disowned and severed all their relations with their daughter SAHIL SONI Aged 29 YEARS and his wife HIMANSHI SHARMA and debarred them from their movable and immovable properties due to their misbehavior, unfamiliar activities, undesirable act, misconduct and going against my clients and my clients desire want to keep any relation with them. Anybody dealing with them in financial, civil and criminal matter shall be doing at his/her own risk, cost and responsibility and my clients and their family shall not be liable for their any act.

Sd/- KAMAL SINGH Advocate

Enrl.No. D7482014

PUBLIC NOTICE

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN Notice is hereby given as caution by, Ms. Veena Dua, W/o Late Naveen Dua, to relate that she is the sole, absolute, lawful owner & possession holder of the complete property bearing No. A-1/02, Manwari Nagar, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110027. The collaboration & development agreement dated 13.02.2026 entered into along with Mr. Anil Soni S/o Ashok Soni, R/o B-1113, Manwari Nagar, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110027, also operating at AASONI Constructions Pvt. Ltd., Office at NS-32 (basement), Manwari Nagar, Delhi-110027 has been terminated via legal notices dated 16.03.2026 & dated 18.07.2026 owing to him after the material breach & abandonment of the project by Mr. Anil Soni. It is made clear that Mr. Soni never possessed such right to create any kind of third party interest in the said property, regardless of the recent termination of the agreement. Ms. Veena Dua has never consented to creating any third party rights till the present date. Any transaction entered into by the public with Mr. Anil Soni or AASONI Constructions Pvt. Ltd., in respect of the said property is void and the concerned person has shall bear their own risk, cost, and consequences, as such transaction is not binding upon Ms. Veena Dua. Sahil Gali (Adv), A26, LGF, Jangpura Extn, Delhi-110014.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that the original documents of Orient Electronics Private Limited (CIN: U31200DL1986PTC025229), including the Certificate of Incorporation, MOA, AOA, statutory records, balance sheets and other company documents, have been lost/misplaced and are not traceable despite diligent search. An online NCR No. 47061/2026 has been lodged with the Police. Any person finding or possessing the said documents is requested to return them to the undersigned. Any unauthorized use or dealing with the said documents shall be at the sole risk and responsibility of the person concerned.

For ORIENT ELECTRONICS PVT LTD, Sd/- Director/Auth. Signatory Sudhanshu Shekhar Sharan or Sudhanshu Shekhar Director, Orient Electronics Private Limited (CIN: U31200DL1986PTC025229) Office at-30, Todar Mal Road, Delhi-110001

PUBLIC NOTICE

My Clients Chandra Tripathi S/o Lt. Ram Tirth Tripathi & Kiran Tripathi W/o Chandra Tripathi Both Resident of B-73 Block-B, Lali Kunj Badliapur New Delhi-110044 have disowned their son namely Shashank Tripathi, daughter-in-law namely Pooorima Tripathi, grand daughter namely Tripti Tripathi from all their properties (Movable & Immovable) from today onwards and severed relations with them. If anybody dealing with them then it will be his/her own risk and cost and our clients and their other family members will not be liable for the same.

Sd/- MOHD. NASEEM KHAN Advocate

Ch. No. 870, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi-110017

PUBLIC NOTICE

My Client Mr. KULBIR SINGH S



while officials shared that over 1.65 lakh ASHA workers have already been certified across the country. Delivering the keynote address, Dr. Neelima Mishra, Director, National Institute of Biologicals, described ASHA workers as the frontline of India's public healthcare system.



MPP Dr. Jitendra Singh, Union Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions, called for a comprehensive review of pension regulations to ensure that evolving social realities are adequately reflected in government policies, stating that many pension disputes arise because existing rules have failed to keep pace with changing societal needs. During the event, Dr. Jitendra Singh launched the Compendium of Case Laws on Pension Litigation, a Flyer on Pension Litigation, & the Special Campaign 3.0 of the Department of Pension & Pensioners' Welfare aimed at strengthening litigation management, improving service delivery and promoting citizen-centric pension administration. He said such reforms demonstrate the Government's commitment to making pension policies more humane, inclusive and responsive to contemporary societal requirements.



UCO BANK reported a strong performance for the quarter ended recently, posting a net profit of Rs 656 crore, up 8.05% year-on-year. Total business rose 15.53% to Rs 6.05 lakh crore, with advances growing 21.18% & deposits 11.28%. Asset quality improved, with Gross NPA at 2.08% & Net NPA at 0.25%. The bank's capital adequacy ratio stood at 19.03%, reflecting robust financial stability. UCO Bank's network spans 3421 Domestic Branches, as well as overseas in Hong Kong, Singapore & a representative office in Iran.

PNB reported a robust Q1 FY'27 performance with net profit surging 214% year-on-year to Rs 5,253 crore. Global business rose 10.2% to Rs 29.98 lakh crore, while advances grew 12.7% and deposits 8.5%. Asset quality strengthened with GNPA improving to 2.78% and NNPA to 0.28%, alongside higher RoA, NIM and capital adequacy, reflecting strong financial resilience.

DWCD In collaboration with Sangath, successfully organised an orientation & felicitation programme under the NAMASTE Programme, reaffirming its commitment to strengthening ECD services across the National Capital Territory. The programme focused on promoting early identification & timely intervention for children with developmental delays & disabilities through a community-based screening approach. The orientation session sensitised Anganwadi functionaries & supervisory staff on the objectives, implementation framework, & significance of the NAMASTE Programme. The event was graced by Rashmi Singh, Hon. Secretary, Department of Women & Child Development, Government of NCT of Delhi.

NIOS The National Institute of Open Schooling in collaboration with the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare & NHSRC, organised a two-day national training programme to strengthen the implementation of the ASHA Certification Programme. NIOS Chairman Prof. Akhilesh Mishra highlighted quality training and certification as the foundation of a strong primary healthcare system,

CORPORATE BRIEFS



BHARAT TAXI Bharat Taxi & Department of Information Technology & Electronics, Govt. of West Bengal entered into an MoU to strengthen the Yatri Sathi Partnership to focus on operational support, driver welfare, technology interoperability, platform growth, and service expansion across West Bengal, Kolkata on 19th July. Yatri Sathi is a state-developed digital taxi aggregation platform owned by DITE, providing cab & taxi services to passengers across West Bengal. Through this partnership, STCL will act as DITE's strategic and preferred Growth & Welfare Partner for Yatri Sathi.



GDA Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath inaugurated and laid the foundation stone for Ghaziabad Development Authority projects worth approximately Rs 596.40 crore during his Ghaziabad visit on July 17. The projects included the inauguration of four completed works worth Rs 91.29 crore and the foundation laying of 19 new infrastructure and public welfare projects worth Rs 505.11 crore, providing a significant boost to the district's development.



GMC Ghaziabad Municipal Commissioner Vikramaditya Singh Malik presented the city's integrated solid waste management initiatives to Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath, highlighting waste segregation, recycling, composting, real-time waste collection monitoring and public participation. The CM also unveiled the Ghaziabad Municipal Corporation's coffee table book showcasing its cleanliness and environmental initiatives over the past two-and-a-half years and commended the Corporation's efforts to build a cleaner, greener city.

BOB AGRA Bank of Baroda's Regional Office, Agra celebrated the bank's 119th Foundation Day with a series of events, including a walkathon, tree plantation drive, free health check-up camp and a cultural-cum-felicitation programme. The evening programme, held at Rao Krishna Pal Auditorium, featured cultural performances by employees and children. Paisalo Digital Limited Executive Director and CFO Harish Singh attended as the chief guest, while Regional Head Dhananjay Kumar, Deputy Regional Manager Anuj Chitransh, RRB Agra AGM Avinash Palod and former Bank of Baroda General Manager S.P. Bhanot were among the distinguished guests. Retired officers and employees were felicitated during the event.



NBT The third Chinar Book Festival at SKICC continued to draw enthusiastic participation with engaging literary and cultural sessions. The day began at the Authors' Corner with an engaging session titled 'From Soil to

Soul: Culinary Traditions and Sustainability'. The session was moderated by Tripurari Singh in the presence of Chef Yaseen Reshi, Rajni. Wanchoo & Khair Ull Nissa Sheikh. A key highlight was the landmark discussion, 'Theatre in Kashmir: Reviving a Living Tradition', which brought together playwrights, actors, directors, scholars and theatre practitioners to reflect on the region's theatrical heritage and future. Opening the session, Dr. Farooq Fayaz traced Kashmir's rich theatrical legacy to its ancient Sanskrit traditions, citing the Nilmata Purana and Rajatarangini as evidence of its vibrant history of drama and playwrighting.

CTD Reaffirming the Government of India's commitment to Swasth Bharat, Viksit Bharat, & a TB-Mukt Bharat, The CTD, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, organised an Ayushman Arogya Shivir at Kartavya Bhawan - I in collaboration with the Delhi State TB Cell, the NTEP & the SNA Division. Aradhana Patnaik, Additional Secretary & Mission Director, National Health Mission inaugurated the Shivir. The camp witnessed enthusiastic participation with services including blood pressure, blood sugar, haemoglobin and BMI assessments. The initiative reflects the government's continued focus on strengthening preventive healthcare and a TB-Mukt Bharat.



CPM The Delhi Gujarati Shwetambar Murtipujak Jain Sangh will mark the Chaturmas Praves Mahotsav with the launch of the year-long 'Jeevdaya Year' campaign, promoting compassion, non-violence and the welfare of all living beings. The initiative will include animal and bird welfare, cow protection, environmental conservation, tree plantation, veterinary assistance and public awareness programmes, aiming to develop Delhi as a "City of Jeevdaya". During Chaturmas, devotees will also participate in religious discourses, scriptural study, devotional activities and spiritual programmes centred on self-discipline and compassion.



ALLEN NEET ALLEN Career Institute delivered an outstanding performance in NEET-UG 2026, with five students securing places in the top 10 and 46 featuring in the top 100. Aryan Gupta secured AIR 1 and Panshul Bansal AIR 2 with 715 marks each, followed by Ayush Bhalotia (AIR 4), Aryan Dubey (AIR 7) and Gaurav Singh (AIR 9).

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sanjay Dayal S/o Ganesh Dayal R/o H. No. B-317, Jawahar Mohalla, Patparganj, Delhi also at Ward No. 7, Gaushala Road Mokama, P.S. Mokama, Distt. Patna, Bihar** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 213/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Jaitpur, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sanjay Dayal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sanjay Dayal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sanjay Dayal** of case **FIR No. 213/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC, P.S. Jaitpur, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.11.2026**.

By Order
Dr. Raj Kumar Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class -11
South East, Court Room No. 09, Main Building
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/9886/SE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Theingam Shimrah, S/o: Late Ashok Shimrah, R/o: H.No. 106, Humayunpur Village, Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi; also at: Village View Land Zone-I, Ukhrul, Manipur** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 176/2021, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Theingam Shimrah** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Theingam Shimrah** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Theingam Shimrah** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 176/2021, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Devanshi Janmeja
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03 (South)
Room No. 212, Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/9705/SW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Dhruv S/o Anil R/o B-3, 4/5, Bhatta Sahib Road, Vishnu Garden, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 155/2024 U/S 279/338 IPC, PS Vijay Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Dhruv** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Dhruv** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Dhruv of FIR No. 155/2024 U/S 279/338 IPC, PS Vijay Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **30.01.2027 at 10:00 am**.

By Order,
Ms. Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
North West District, Room No. 109, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8231/RD/2026(Court Matter)

PUNJAB STATE POWER CORPORATION LTD.

Regd. Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall Patiala- 147001
Phone No. 96461-18774, Email id: semeteringpatiala@gmail.com
Corporate Identity No. U40109PB2010SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in

Tender Enquiry No. MQP-267/2026-27/PO(M) Dated 23.07.2026

Chief Engineer/Metering, C-3, Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala invites e-tender for Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning, Reading, Analysis, integration with billing system and 1 year O&M of Power Quality Meters complying to IEC 61000-4-30 class A.

For detailed NIT & tender specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 23.07.2026, 11:00 AM onwards.

Note: - Corrigendum & addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

No.13644/PB C 744/26

PUNJAB STATE TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

Regd Office: PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala. 147001
Corporate Identity No. U40109PB2010SGC033814 www.pstcl.org
O/o: Dy. CE/ TS (Design), Telefax: 0175-2207774, E-mail:tsdtr@pstcl.org

Notice Inviting E-Tender

Tender Enquiry No. STQ-7100 (SHORT TERM OPEN TENDER)

For manufacture, testing, supply & delivery of 780 nos. SCADA compatible TIKV VCB Panels.

1. Last date & time for downloading of tender- 07.08.2026 upto 11:00AM
2. Last date & time for submission of tender- 07.08.2026 upto 11:00AM
3. Date & time for opening of tender- 10.08.2026 at 11:00 AM

Detailed NIT/specification may be downloaded from Punjab Govt. e-tendering website <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> in nicipp/app. Corrigendum, if any, will not be published in newspapers. As such the website may be visited regularly for updates.

NO. 13623/PSTCL Dy. CE/TS (D), PSTCL, Patiala.

HARYANA REAL ESTATE REGULATORY AUTHORITY

New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.

E-mail: hrrapkl-hrv@gov.in, officer.rera.hrv@gmail.com
Website: www.haryanarera.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

For kind attention of allottees of the Real Estate Project namely "Devrachna Lok" an Affordable Residential Plotted Town Planning Scheme under DDJAY-2016 being developed by M/s Tilak Cotton Industries over an area measuring 6.864 acres situated in Sector-10, Residential, Fatehabad.

1. The above-mentioned project was registered with HRERA Panchkula vide Registration No: HRERA-PKL-FTB-540-2024 Dated: 16.01.2024 valid upto 30/06/2026.

2. The promoter has requested the Authority that instead of revoking the registration on its expiry, the Authority may permit it to remain in force for one more year subject to such further terms and conditions as it thinks fit to impose in the interest of the allottees and any such terms and conditions so imposed shall be binding upon the promoter.

3. The Authority is considering the application of the promoter to permit continuation of registration for one more year under section 7(3) of the Act for this project. However, the first right of refusal for carrying out of the remaining development works is that of the association of allottees. Therefore, the Authority hereby invites objections from the association of allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general.

4. The objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority by 07.08.2026 which will be considered by the Authority under section 7(3) of the Act.

Secretary (Acting)
HRERA Panchkula
No. 47490/HR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Taj Khan S/o Md. Rafiq R/o 332, Gali No.-3, Bhagya Vihar, Delhi, Also at: 125A, Vidyapati Nagar, Inder Enclave, Ph.-2nd, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 451/2020, U/S 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, PS Prem Nagar, Rohini Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Taj Khan** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Taj Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Taj Khan** the said accused of **FIR No. 451/2020, U/S 33/58 Delhi Excise Act, PS Prem Nagar, Rohini Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class,
North West, Court No. 109, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/10160/RD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused persons namely **Mihir Das @ Pukai S/o Gopal Das R/o H.No. C-3/678, Gali No. 11, 2nd Pusta, Soniya Vihar, Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence under **FIR No.1526/2025 U/s 316(4) Bharatiya Nagarik Sanhita.**, has been registered at **PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Mihir Das @ Pukai** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Mihir Das @ Pukai** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Mihir Das @ Pukai** of under **FIR No.1526/2025 U/s 316(4) Bharatiya Nagarik Sanhita.**, Registered at: **PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Nishant Bangarh
JMFC-01 (Central), Room No. 180
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/10177/CD/2026 (Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Monu @ Shankar Shikander, S/o Santosh Shikander, R/o WZ-65/55, Indra Camp No. 03, Vikas Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 27/2020, U/s 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Vikas Puri, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Monu @ Shankar Shikander** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Monu @ Shankar Shikander** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Monu @ Shankar Shikander** accused of **FIR No. 27/2020, U/s 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Vikas Puri, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.09.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Sh. Vinod Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, South-West District
DP/10130/WD/2026 Room No. 09, Dwarka Courts, New Delhi

MAHARASHTRA METRO RAIL CORPORATION LTD.

(A joint venture of Govt. of India & Govt. of Maharashtra)

PUNE METRO RAIL PROJECT- PHASE 2

Metro Bhavan, 04th Floor, D. I. Metro Station, Nyaymurti
Ranade Path, Shivaji Nagar, Pune-411005. Tel. : 020-26051072/74
E-mail: ptender.pmp@mahametro.org | www.punemetrorail.org

Tender Notice No: P1PD-60/2026 Date: 25/07/2026

Name of Work: Licensing Internal Advertisement Rights of Corridor-01 Metro Stations of the Pune Metro Rail Project for a Period of 15 Years.

Interested bidders may visit the Pune Metro Rail website www.punemetrorail.org to view this Tender Notice (NIT) and can download the tender documents and obtain further details regarding the tender from e-tender portal of Govt. of Maharashtra <https://mahatenders.gov.in>. from 17:00 Hrs. on 27/07/2026 to 16:00 Hrs. of 27/08/2026.

General Manager (TP & Procurement - PD)
Maha-Metro Rail Corporation Limited

Pune Metro : City's Transport Solution

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Ashutosh S/o Sh. Abhay Kumar R/o M-98, Meer Vihar, Madanpur Dabas, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CR. No. 533019/2016, U/s 394/34 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Ashutosh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Ashutosh** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Ashutosh** of case **CR. No. 533019/2016, U/s 394/34 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **27.08.2026**.

By Order
Apoorv Bhardwaj
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 113, First Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/9771/RD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82/84 BNSS

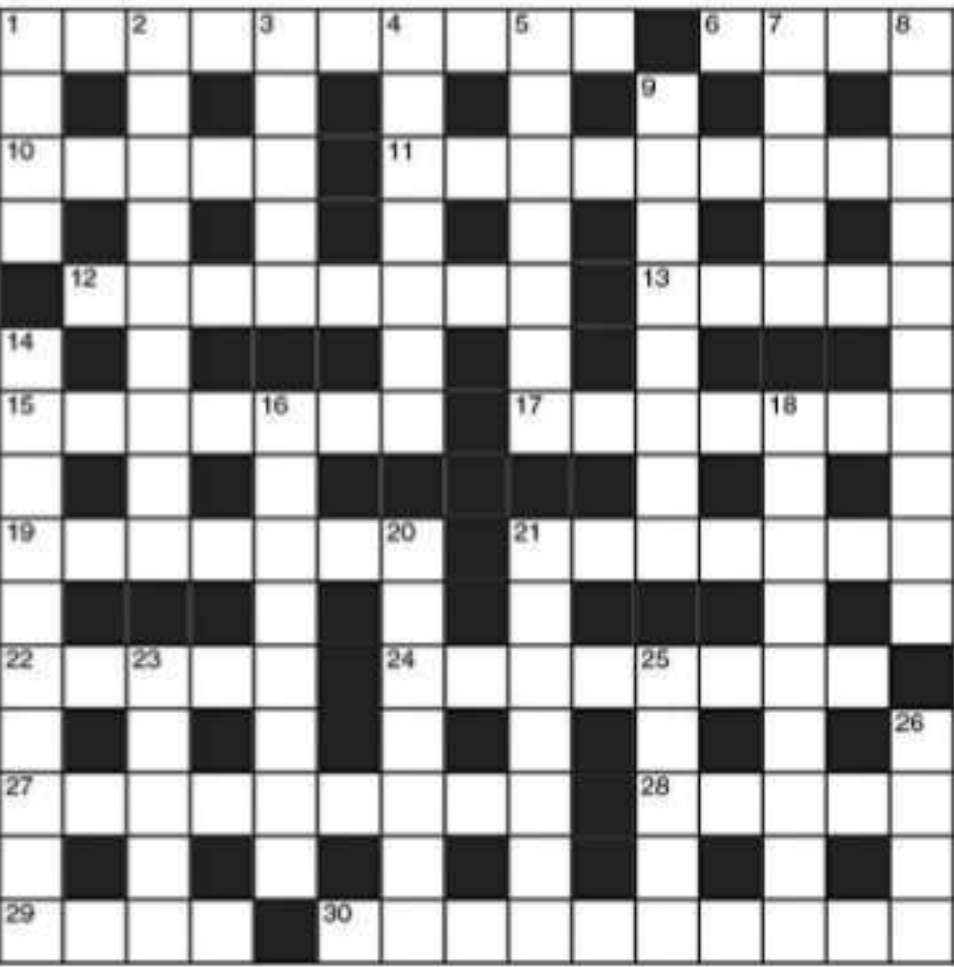
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely **Amir Khan S/o Nabijaan, R/o: H. No. Idgaah Colony, Gali No. 10, Sonipat, Haryana** (or is suspected to has committed) the offence in **FIR No. 0278/2020, U/s 129/55 G. Act**, Date : 29.09.2020, registered at P.S.: New Friends Colony, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused **Amir Khan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Amir Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amir Khan** accused **FIR No. 0278/2020, U/s 129/55 G. Act**, registered at P.S.: New Friends Colony, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.08.2026**.

By Order
Vinod Joshi
Addl. Chief Judicial Magistrate
South East District, Room No. 515
Saket Courts, New Delhi

DP/10181/SE/2026 (Court Matter)

epaper.indianexpress.com

CROSSWORD



ACROSS

1 Island with many debits is undependable (10)

6 List of food (4)

10 The best one to make business arrangements (5)

11 Lavish with everything but mercy (9)

12 A lemon is strangely classified as cereal (8)

13 Free trip to give medical attention (5)

18 Drug possibly oceanic in origin (7)

17 Rent row causes a storm (7)

19 It comes last locked in reverse (7)

21 See sign is incorrect for a start (7)

22 Just a maxim (5)

24 Honoured with high rank in the finish (8)

27 Not having had any hot drinks? (4,5)

28 Cultivating a vine is simple (5)

29 Rough deal for Helen's mother (4)

30 It's said to be praise for good sportsmen (4,6)

DOWN

1 Slight damage to essential part of computer (4)

2 Allegations that may be false (9)

3 I pick up key to look round someone's house (5)

4 Until that is put in order this is useless (7)

5 Pushy type seen to jump out of bed first (7)

7 A green girl (5)

8 Edifice with strong beams (10)

9 Car is not damaged being strong (4-4)

14 Bill gets a medical qualification of college (10)

16 The Utopian has his own collection of notions (8)

18 I stay true to the principle of self-denial (9)

20 Three times surrounded a number show fear (7)

21 Non-specialist officer (7)

23 Directed — in a straight line? (5)

25 Commonplace restriction on almost everything (5)

26 Metal van (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6049 ACROSS: 1 Lenient, 5 Discs, 8 The creeps, 9 Oar, 10 Rifle, 12 Strolled, 14 Errors, 15 Stress, 17 Research, 18 Asia, 21 Era, 22 Hold still, 24 Tudor, 25 Doublet **DOWN:** 1 Later, 2 Nee, 3 Earl, 4 Treaty, 5 Distorts, 6 Shoulders, 7 Strides, 11 Firm stand, 13 Breather, 14 Earnest, 16 Scaled, 19 Allot, 20 Esau, 23 Ill

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Believe those who are seeking _____. Doubt those who find it - Andre Gide (3,5)

THROE

ABPRTU

TRUST

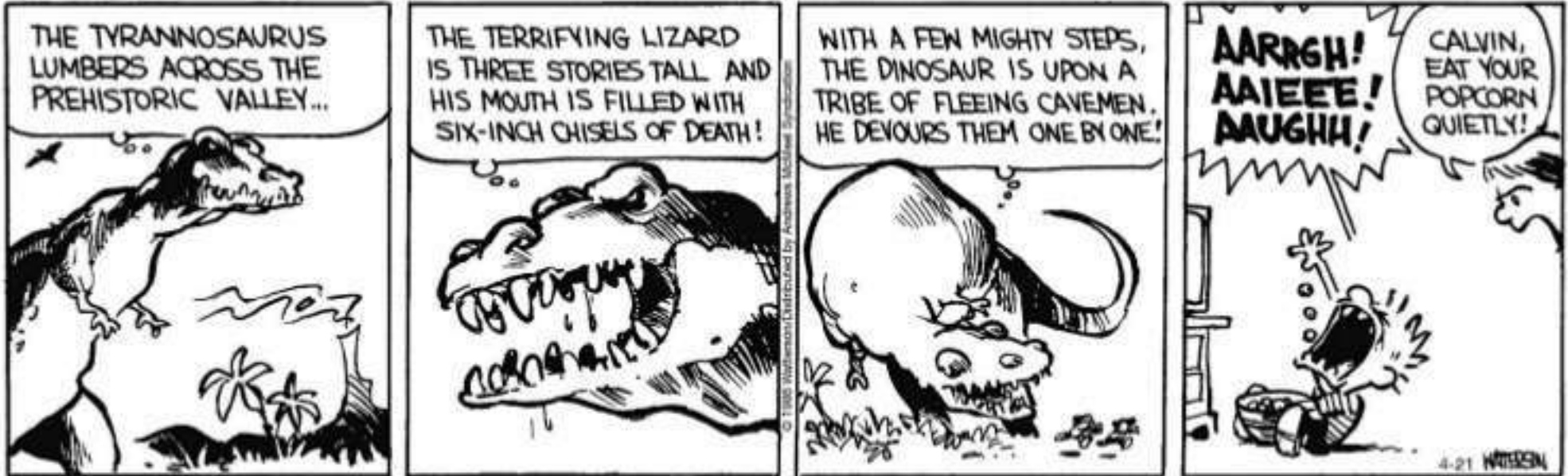
CNOOHH

ANSWERS: Believe those who are seeking the truth. Doubt those who find it. Other, thurt, Abprut, Honcho

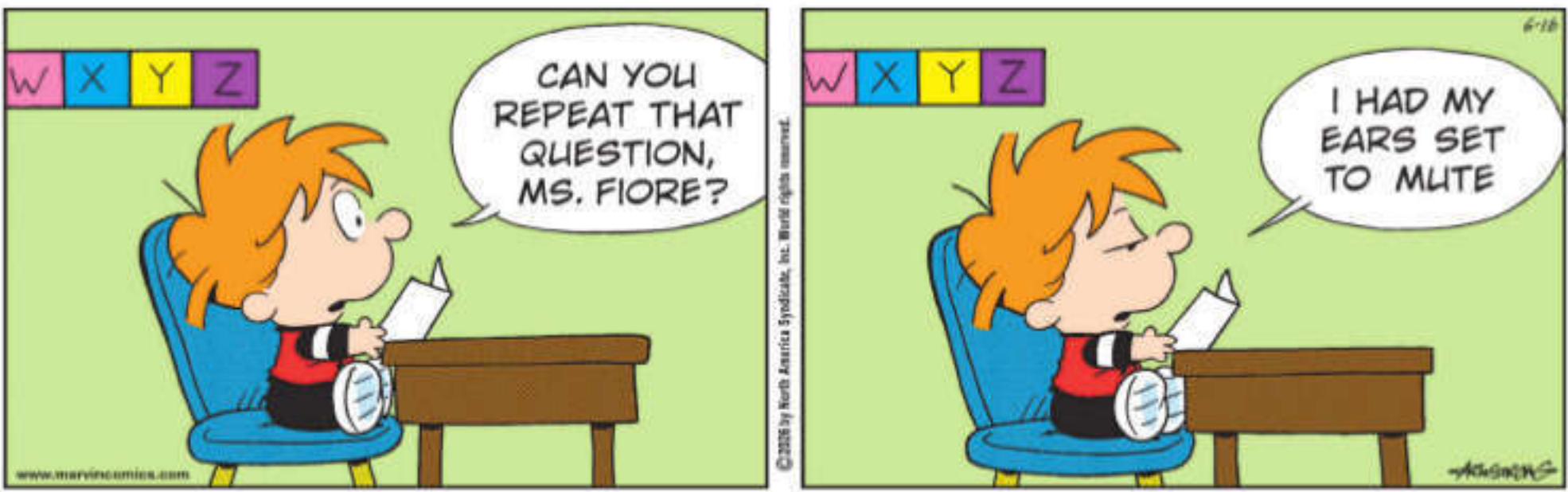
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBES



MARVIN



SUDOKU 6390

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 4s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6389

	4	3	7	8
	7		2	
1	5		9	
6	8			
9			9	4
1		8		3
2		5		
6	4	2	1	

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6389

7	2	9	5	8	6	3	4	1
5	8	3	2	1	4	6	7	9
4	6	1	7	3	9	8	5	2
8	4	6	1	5	7	9	2	3
2	1	7	4	9	3	5	8	6
3	9	5	8	6	2	4	1	7
6	5	2	3	7	8	1	9	4
9	7	8	6	4	1	2	3	5
1	3	4	9	2	5	7	6	8

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD CORP./AUTH	OLD REFERENCE/ NIT NO.	NATURE OF CORRIGENDUM	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER'S CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	THE SIRSA DISTRICT COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS UNION LIMITED	TENDER ID: 2026_HCH_530283_1 REF.NO MUS/E-TENDER/2026/272	TENDER DATE EXTENDED 04.08.2026	https://etenders.hry.nic.in vitaindia.org.in	98123-02168 vitasrs@gmail.com
2	THE SIRSA DISTRICT COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS UNION LIMITED	TENDER ID: 2026_HCH_530291_1 REF.NO MUS/E-TENDER/2026/272A	TENDER DATE EXTENDED 04.08.2026	https://etenders.hry.nic.in vitaindia.org.in	98123-02168 vitasrs@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeaprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in

No. 47481(HRY)

MUTHOOT FINCORP LTD. | GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Regd. Office: Muthoot Centre, TC No 27/3022, Punnem Road, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India - 695001. CIN : U65929KL1997PLC011518, Ph: +91 471 4911400, 2331427.

Notice is hereby given for the information of all concerned that gold ornaments pledged with under mentioned branches of the company , which were overdue for redemption and which have not been redeemed so far in spite of repeated notices will be auctioned on 26.08.2026 from 10 am onwards.

Auction Date: 26.08.2026 - BHOPAL DISTRICT - ASHOKA GARUDA: 4343001491, 4343002899, 4343003340, 4343003434, 4343003482, 4343003549, 4343003572, 4343003618, 4343003654, 4343003703, 4343003706, 4343003758, 4343003784, 4343003792, 4343003796, 4343003812, 4343003827, 4343003847, 4343003849, 4343003895, 4343003905, 4343003931, 4343003974, 4343004018, 4343004029, 4343004031, 4343004036, 4343004054, 4343004075, 4343004107, 4343004116, 4343004136, 4343004165, 4343004225, 4343004229, 4343004244, 4343004268, 4343004282, 4343004283, 4343004327, 4343004362, 4343004380, 4343004432, 4343004436, 4343004449, 4343004455, 4343004456, 4343004457, 4343004458, 4343004459, 4343004460, 4343004461, 4343004462, 4343004463, 4343004464, 4343004465, 4343004466, 4343004467, 4343004468, 4343004469, 4343004470, 4343004471, 4343004472, 4343004473, 4343004474, 4343004475, 4343004476, 4343004477, 4343004478, 4343004479, 4343004480, 4343004481, 4343004482, 4343004483, 4343004484, 4343004485, 4343004486, 4343004487, 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Judoka Tulika banned by NADA for whereabouts failure; removed from CWG

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 24

JUDOKA TULIKA Maan, who had won silver at the 2022 Commonwealth Games, has been withdrawn from the ongoing edition in Glasgow after being provisionally suspended by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for three whereabouts failures in the last 12 months. It is a second blow for the Indian judo team for the Games, with Arun Kumar earlier being suspended by the NADA.

According to PTI, Tulika had made three whereabouts failures in a 12-month period. Under the World Athletics Anti-Doping (WADA) rules, any combination of three whereabouts failures — filing failure and/or missed test — within a period of 12 months constitute an anti-doping rule violation.

One of the most decorated judokas in the country, Tulika had made an exit in the round of 32 at the 2024 Paris Olympics. She had won silver in the +78kg category at the 2022 Commonwealth Games.

This is third case of doping that has hit the Indian contingent since the Games have started. Earlier, Arun Kumar, a Judoka participating in the -73kg category, was removed from the judo squad after he was provisionally suspended by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA).

Hours after Kumar's suspension, it was revealed that another Indian athlete, weightlifter Dilbagh Singh, would return from Glasgow —although for no fault of his own.

Indian weightlifting has reported five positive cases during the period of June 1, 2025, to July 22, 2026. Consequently, India's athlete quota was slashed from 16 to 11.

The sports ministry had approved a 191-member contingent, including 126 athletes.

INDIA watch

GYMNASTICS

Women's team final and individual qualification
Pranati Nayak, Protistha Samanta, Eshita Sunil Rewale, Nishka Agarwal, Riddhi Sharma **2:30pm**

PARA SWIMMING

Men's S14 200m freestyle heats: Chaitanya Vishwas Kulkarni **4:15pm**; final at **12:45am** (if he qualifies)

SWIMMING

Men's 400m freestyle heats: Dhakshan Shashikumar **4:00pm**, final at **11:30pm** (if he qualifies)
Men's 50m backstroke final: Srihari Natraj **12:20am** (if he qualifies)

LAWN BOWLS

Men's singles sectional match: Putul Sonowal
Women's pairs sectional match: Rupa Rani Tirkey and Pinky Singh vs Tonga's Paris Baker and Milkha Nathan **3:50pm**

BOXING

Men's 60kg Round of 32: Sachin Siwach vs Keoma Al-Ahmadieh (Canada) **4:00pm**

3x3 BASKETBALL

Women's wheelchair: India vs Wales **5:00pm**



India checks in

Weightlifter Mirabai Chanu (L) and boxer Lovlina Borgohain carry the flag as they lead the Indian contingent during the opening ceremony of the Commonwealth Games. PTI

BEYOND DIPAS PRODUNOVA

India's gymnasts bet on getting the basics right

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 24

GYMNASTS SPEAK about the bubble of fearlessness that coaches conjure around them, before they go leaping into unknowns. The assured faces hide storms within.

"The 2014 Glasgow bronze medal was memorable because it was the first time I stuck a landing on the Produnova. My coach told me I would," Dipa Karmakar recalls of a sunny late Glaswegian afternoon when magic began weaving for Indian women's gymnastics.

"I'm sure the new girls are going to change the colour of the Indian medal on vault," she says, passing on the baton, wrapping it in the same glaze of confidence that is necessary for a gymnast to hear, before take-off, when it defies reality even.

Balance is linked to ears, and Dipa has confidently whispered the message that she believes in their abilities, into ears of Pranati Nayak, Eshita Rewale, Nishka Agarwal and Protistha Samanta who were all picked based on their vault strength as India mounts a medal challenge at 2026 Glasgow.

Unlike Dipa, the four Indians now are not attempting terrifying vaults.

But finding brilliance in basics, when judges are not blown by the nerveless execution of bravado, is difficult by itself. It's the evolution Dipa is getting behind, as the totem of the sport.

Pranati, big hope

Tokyo Olympian Pranati has thrice medalled at Asian Cham-

Vaulters go to Glasgow chasing not daring but precision, as Dipa Karmakar passes the baton to a generation built on Tuskaharas and Yurchenkos rather than high-risk tumbles



Pranati Nayak is set to go with Tsukahara 360 and a Handspring Forward Pike 360 at the CWG. PTI

pionships, so consistency is her currency, even as she manages ankle troubles. She has lived like a monk at Odisha's high performance centre, leaning on sports science.

She picks vaults working within her fitness confines, so she is slated to go with a Tsukahara 360 and a Handspring Forward Pike 360, a 360 being a single rotation.

Though she will be assured of a 4.4 Difficulty score on the Tsukahara, the block on the table remains the crucial element to pull it off.

Scoring high and clean on execution is her plan to get into the finals. The Tsukahara vault demands maturity and strength that Pranati has, and

minimising deductions is the trick to get into the Top 8.

Yurchenko choice

The gymnast attempting a tougher one is Nishka Agarwal, who has shadowed Pranati for years. If coach Manoj Rana can inject enough confidence, she will go for a Yurchenko with a D-score of 5.0.

Her movement alignment and technique are sturdy, and she tends to cop fewer angular deductions. If she can land the double twist, she can go up to 13.8, while the Tsukahara for a 4.4 D-score can take her to 13.1, averaging out in ideal circumstances.

Yurchenko is an entry-level vault, attempted by half the

Finding brilliance in basics, when judges are not blown by the nerveless execution of bravado, is difficult by itself.

field. A round-off onto the springboard is step one. A back handspring onto the vault table is step two. India's only other CWG medallist, Ashish Kumar, explains: "The back lift-off from floor is biomechanically easier to lead to saltos or twists from the vault thereafter - 360, 540, 720. Three-four Indians have now logged a long journey on the vault," says the 2010 daredevil from Delhi Games.

The Tsukahara is tougher than Yurchenko because you need strength for the round-off on the springboard. "The English are landing them perfectly even if it's half a twist less," he says of the recent Yurchenkos. But someone like Protistha, who shadowed Dipa in here early years, has that necessary strength for a 2014 encore. "Everything is about perfect landing," Rana reminds.

Why vault

Dipa's fourth place at the Olympics spawned a dozen dreams. Aruna Reddy became the first Indian gymnast to win a World Cup medal, on vault.

Pranati has since added Asian Championship medals of her own.

The history has science behind it. India, never a gymnastics nation, has chosen vault and maxed it out for a simple reason. Despite the risk, the acrobatic aerials and the speed, a vault is judged on only two execution skills, one for each vault, while the rest of the apparatus get marked on seven skills each, over lines, passes, elements, dismounts and more.

Nationals gold medallist Eshita Rewale from Mumbai has stuck to two basics, a Tsukahara 360 and a Yurchenko stretch. A lightweight, springy athlete, Eshita will look to nail the rudimentary routines.

Competition check

The biggest name on vault that Pranati and co will be up against is Canadian Lia Monica Fontaine, a 2025 World Championships silver medallist on vault, debuting here.

The debutant joins power-speed bullet Ellie Black at her fourth Games.

Defending champion Georgia Godwin returns from a full rupture of her Achilles tendon sustained before the Paris Olympics.

An all-rounder who has an eponymous skill on uneven bars named after her, the Australian has said she still struggles with phantom pain. She has since earned a degree in medical imaging, and is writing a gymnastics storybook.

England's Abigail Martin is a fiery contender, while Welsh sisters Abigail and Emily Ropers are vault specialists.

OPENING NOTES



King Charles (C) and Queen Camilla step out of the Doctor Who Tardis police box as cyclist Chris Hoy looks on. AP

The king makes an entry, but not quite James Bond style

THERE WAS no parachute jump from a helicopter by the Queen and Mr. Bond. The 2026 CWG spin off of the dramatic royal entry at the 2012 London Olympics was restrained. In place of the most famous fictional secret agent was six-time Olympic medal winning cyclist Chris Hoy, who is battling cancer, and Scottish actor and writer Greg McHugh. The centerpiece of the entry film, the now less common but once ubiquitous police box, which entered pop culture as the Tardis, Doctor Who's time machine. Small on the outside but large on the inside, the reel version of the police box is a bit of a starship. The Glasgow link to the original police box, which actually had a phone to get in touch with the station and a mini office space inside for quick paperwork, is Gilbert Mackenzie Trench, an architect from Scotland. He came up with its design and also served as the chief architect of the police force in London. The Tardis, which has a mind of its own, or a sixth sense as to where the Doctor should be, played its part in the opening ceremony film, which set the mood for

the actual entry at the stadium. A couple of off-target stops later Hoy and McHugh reach Balmoral where the royal couple join them. Of course, they are magically transported to The Hydro. From the yellow-light-lit cabin emerged Hoy, then McHugh and finally King Charles and Queen Camilla. Credit to Charles for being game by shading his eyes to look into the distance to figure out where he had been transported to. He waved and wore a slight smile too, a way better performance than the Queen who looked like she had a bad hair day when he walked into the Olympic Stadium in London. Can't blame her though. The air from the helicopter rotor blades might have messed with her mood. Yet, nothing beats the classy Daniel Craig, in a sharp suit, chaperoning the queen in a chopper over the London skies with the Bond soundtrack playing. 'Good evening Mr Bond' delivered nonchalantly by the queen was a smooth dialogue delivery with more recall value than any of the 'I declare the Games open' lines over the years. ENS



Actor Sam Heughan raises his hand to touch a life-size model of the mythical Loch Ness Monster during the opening ceremony. PTI

Loch Ness Monster spotted

ONE OF Scotland's most enduring legends made an appearance in Glasgow as the Loch Ness Monster — affectionately known as Nessie — emerged from a CGI recreation of Loch Ness, the vast freshwater lake in the Scottish Highlands that has been linked to mysterious monster sightings for nearly a century.

The mythical creature, which has featured in Scottish folklore for generations and become one of the country's most recognisable cultural icons, made contact with Outlander star Sam Heughan inside the Hydro. Dressed in a grey kilt, the Scottish actor walked across the Celtic knot stage with his arms outstretched before gently touching Nessie's nose as she rose from the digital loch to the delight of the crowd. ENS

Scotland and the pipers entry

THE HOME team received the loudest welcome of the night, with a thunderous roar echoing around the Hydro as the athletes made their way around the stage. Scottish flags rippled through the stands as thousands of fans rose to their feet. The only sound capable of cutting through the cheers was the unmistakable skirl of the Great Highland bagpipes. Dozens of pipers flooded the stage and lined the aisles, creating a wall of sound that has accompanied Scottish celebrations, military ceremonies and sporting occasions for centuries.

Few instruments are more closely associated with Scotland, and as the massed pipes and drums filled the arena, the home nation's entrance felt every bit ceremonial. ENS

RISING STAR

World Cup final: Silver in a field of Olympic champs makes Sainyam's best day

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 24

SAINYAM VIJ was tenth after qualification. The final she walked into afterward had an Olympic champion, a reigning world number one, and two Chinese shooters on home soil. By the time it ended, the 22-year-old from Chandigarh had beaten all but one of them.

Shooting a final score of 243.4 at the Fuyang Yin Sports Centre in Hangzhou on Friday, Sainyam finished 0.2 points behind China's Yao Qianxun, the world number one, to win silver, her second senior international

medal after a silver at last year's ISSF World Cup Final in Doha.

"Whenever I shoot, I don't shoot with the idea of whom I am competing against or whether she is an Olympic champion," she told *The Indian Express* from Hangzhou. "Whether it's China or Korea, my competition is only with myself."

She started the final poorly, a first series of 49.7 that left her fifth.

The second series turned it: a 51.9, the best of the eight shooters in the field, put her level at the top with Qianxun. She stayed inside the top two through the eliminations that

followed, trailing Qianxun by 0.6 points heading into the final series before closing with a 10.6 and a 10.7, better than Qianxun's own 10.3 and 10.4, but not enough to close the gap. Reigning Olympic champion Oh Yejin, of Korea, finished last.

"I understood that my first series did not go well and I should not focus on what has happened," Sainyam said. "There was some difference in lighting in qualification as compared to the final range, and I knew I had to adjust. The key for me was to believe in what I have been doing in training. Post the silver medal in Doha, I had some



“Whenever I shoot, I don't shoot with the idea of whom I am competing against or whether she is an Olympic champion. ...my competition is only with myself.”
SAINYAM VIJ

Sainyam Vij after clinching a silver medal in the women's 10m air pistol. NRAI

Manu Bhaker across the 10m and 25m pistol events. Asked how it feels to compete against Bhaker and Singh, and against Phogat, for a place in the Indian team, Sainyam returned to the same idea that had carried her through the final.

"I have never thought about competing for my spot in the Indian team. I have only thought about my shooting and how I can improve," she said. "Yes, I wanted to compete in the Asian Games, but that's shooting. My aim is to win the Olympic quota for India at the World Championships in Doha later this year."

NO ROLE CLARITY

Ton that solved nothing: India’s Rohit dilemma, by the numbers

A 34th ODI hundred at Lord’s kept the debate alive. What comes next, an anchor, an aggressor, or a clean break, is a choice India can no longer defer

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, July 24

INDIA HAVE lost six of the nine away ODIs they have played under head coach Gautam Gambhir. Rohit Sharma, India’s highest run-scorer and the only centurion in overseas ODIs outside Asia in this period, remains the batter closest to losing his spot. Nudging 40, age appears to have become the defining metric of Rohit’s readiness. Not the runs or range of his batting. Rohit is the only opener to aggregate over 1000 runs since last year and is India’s highest run-scorer in ODIs since the 2023 World Cup.

A run of five innings without a fifty was enough for conversations around retirement and succession to gather pace mid-way through this year. A cold snub when the selectors meet again for the next assignment in September cannot be ruled out.

Rohit has not thrown in the towel yet. His blockbuster 34th century in the series decider against England at Lord’s last Sunday confirmed as much.

But lost beneath India’s eventual 27-run defeat in a colossal 388 chase was the true purpose of Rohit’s century itself. The conflicting nature of it, the duality of having to play for one’s spot and the collective outcome, a situation thrust upon him by the management just a year out from the next World Cup.

Between losing his cap-

taincy within two series of a Champions Trophy win under coach Gambhir and settling back to life solely as an opener, India are presented with three choices regarding Rohit.

The first: persist with the anchor. The century at Lord’s was a throwback to the Rohit of the previous decade, the devastating accumulator who could bat deep and bat big. A premium on big knocks has prompted his fallback to cautious starts. Not by design, but his place increasingly depends on it.

The second: restore the aggressor. The shift toward anchoring has almost obscured the version from 15 months ago, a brutal aggressor who nearly batted India to a World Cup win and spearheaded a tricky chase in the Champions Trophy final.

The third involves the idea of Rohit altogether, asking whether India should instead hand over the reins to Yashasvi Jaiswal alongside captain Shubman Gill.

Should the selectors move on, India will miss Rohit’s sixes and aggression, the only proven shape-shifter in a lineup of elite anchors in the top-middle order.

If they lock in Rohit as a certainty, the tempo of his and Gill’s forthcoming partnerships will require recalibration.

India’s 147-run opening stand in the Lord’s chase looked imposing, yet the required rates never truly came down. It rose above nine just before the partnership reached



Rohit Sharma scored 138 runs off 118 balls in the third ODI at the Lords. CREIMAS/BCCI

three figures, stayed there through Gill’s dismissal on 74 and Rohit’s 84-ball century, and climbed beyond 11 by the time he departed for 138. India eventually needed 126 off 11 overs, a bridge too far for a middle-order that lacked the explosiveness Rohit could summon to upend attacks.

Uncertain future

The uncertainty isn’t merely over Rohit’s future. It extends to what batting philosophy India’s core group still believes in. What India have is an accumulation-heavy quartet in Gill, Kohli, Iyer and KL Rahul. With his 110-ball 138, Rohit has shown he can still expand that bracket, and also remain the outlier for his innate attacking strengths in the Powerplay, should India choose to unshackle him.

Between the start of 2023 and the Champions Trophy final in March 2025 that

marked Rohit’s last innings as captain, Gill and Rohit combined for 2124 runs at 68.51 with a 6.92 run rate, the best combination for all opening partnerships. Over 73 percent of those runs (1533) came in the first Powerplay (overs 1-10). Rohit contributed 60 percent of the runs (921) at a manic 122 strike rate. Gill collected 558 at 94.

Post the captaincy switch, the scoring rate has plummeted to 5.71, a conspicuous drop-off that cannot be ignored for a batting group that inherently bore no weakness, save the absence of a left-hander in the top six. Gill’s outputs have remained identical in both periods, his Powerplay share continuing at 97.

The slowdown has come almost entirely from Rohit, whose strike rate in the first ten overs has fallen by 42 points, from 122 to 80. It hasn’t meant the pair have lasted longer either. They have batted past

the 10th over thrice in the last 10 innings, with Powerplay averages dropping by 20 runs (from 86.3 to 67.9) from the two preceding years.

Rohit nevertheless remains the premier six-hitter in the side. At Lord’s, he surpassed Chris Gayle for most sixes (94) struck past the age of 36 in the format. He has hit 38 maxis since last year, level with the next two players in the Indian line-up.

With months between assignments, the lingering absence of role clarity does not temper the load on Rohit, nor the top-order players around him. India must make their choice now. Persist with an anchoring Rohit at the expense of variety. Restore the aggressor who transformed India’s ODI batting through the last World Cup cycle. Or move on from nearly 12,000 runs of experience in pursuit of a newer, untested approach.

The reluctant president: Anand to run FIDE for two months

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, July 24

IN A strange turn of events for Viswanathan Anand, the five-time world champion finds himself as the man running FIDE, the global governing body of chess. Strange, because just five days ago, Anand was explaining why he was voluntarily stepping back from active administration. Anand said he had opted not to run as the Deputy President in Arkady Dvorkovich’s re-election campaign. Anand’s current term as the second-in-command of Dvorkovich would end when the elections are held during the Olympiad in Samarkand in two months’ time.

Anand’s reasoning for not wanting to continue in a role he has held since 2022 was simple: “I simply wanted to have more time at home. My son will probably go to university in three years, I thought these are the years I should be here. That was a big motivation to get a different role. But I am still very much part of the team.”

But now, in a quirk of fate, for the next two months at least, Anand finds himself more front and centre of the global governing body than ever. On Thursday, sanctions from the European Union became public which made Dvorkovich’s position as FIDE president untenable. The Russian has consequently stepped aside as president, meaning Anand is now the interim president of the global governing body of chess.

The sanctions against Dvorkovich mean he is out of running for a third term as FIDE president. In a statement to The Indian Express, Dvorkovich said: “The sanctions are completely unjustified, unfair and based on political characterisations rather than a proper assessment of my personal and professional conduct. The only reason for sanctions is to prevent me from running and



Five-time World Champ Viswanathan Anand,

serving for FIDE. I reject political allegations being presented as an established fact and will challenge them through every available legal process.”

Timur Turlov, the CEO of Freedom Holding, had been named on Dvorkovich’s ticket as a Deputy President contender. Anand, meanwhile, had said that he would be part of Team Dvorkovich, but without running for Deputy President role. Now, with Dvorkovich out of the running, it remains to be seen if Anand will get convinced to run for another term.

The deadline to name the president and deputy contenders is on Sunday, July 26. Ukraine-born German Wadim Rosenstein (with Gordon Tang as his running mate) and Jan Henric Buettner (Malcolm Pein as Deputy) have announced their intention to run for FIDE President. In his role as the Interim President, Anand is likely to preside over the decision to award hosting rights for the FIDE World Championship at the end of this year where Gukesh will defend his title against Uzbekistan’s Javokhir Sindarov.

“Following the decision by President Arkady Dvorkovich to suspend the exercise of his duties, and in accordance with

the FIDE Charter, I have assumed the responsibilities of Interim President,” Anand posted on X.

“I want to thank Arkady for his leadership and for putting the interests and stability of FIDE first. Together with the FIDE Council, the administration and our member federations, my focus will be on ensuring continuity and serving the global chess family. FIDE’s work continues. Arkady has built a strong team and vision and I today take it as our collective responsibility to carry the work forward.”

Dvorkovich hit back

Hit with the sanctions, Dvorkovich, who had been Russia’s deputy prime minister before he took over the FIDE presidency, opted to step aside.

In written comments shared with The Indian Express, Dvorkovich slammed the sanctions and questioned their timing. “The sanctions are completely unjustified, unfair and based on political characterisations rather than a proper assessment of my personal and professional conduct,” Dvorkovich said. “The only reason for sanctions is to prevent me from running and serving for FIDE.

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